Forever is the Sweetest Con

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36725845.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Western, Worldbuilding, plot heavy, Long chapters!, Action/Adventure, Friends to Lovers, childhood friends that is uwu, Established Relationship, Married Glimbow, Pining, Fluff, ofc there's fluff i'm not a savage, Angst, because i am a savage, title is from T Swift... good luck, Angst with a Happy Ending, yeehaw adora, outlaw catradora!, Swift Wind doing horse thingsTM

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Forever is the Sweetest Con

by stingingscorpion

Summary

Ten years apart. Another ten years in a life of being on the run perpetually. A familiar man approaches Adora with a difficult task she has little say in: round up her old gang members and turn them in. The people she grew up with. The woman who raised her. The woman she grew up alongside and loved for years and years—they will all swing for their crimes. With heavy blackmail weighing her down, Adora must face the life that abandoned her a decade ago, desperately plotting a way to save the one she loves most in the process.

Together, the Trail We Blazed

Chapter Notes

> The funniest thing about this story is the fact I didn't realize it was basically the plot to the video game Red Dead Redemption until about four chapters in. Oops. This story will update monthly at the end of the month, because each and every one of these chapters is going to be massive. I'm going for the feel of every chapter being a new "adventure" in Adora's journey in this story. Just a little experiment. And frankly some of the later chapters don't break up very well in terms of flow.
>
> I am super excited about this one. I hope you enjoy!
>
> I also gave Adora a very slight southern accent. As a treat

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Knock it off.”

Nudge. Hard nudge. The rope between her hands slips from her fingers, the whole knot loosening itself. It falls to the dirt below, flimsy and lifeless. If not tied, useless.

“Hey! Stop it, please!”

Whining. The horse is uncaring. He hits Adora with his big pale head, big baby blue eyes bearing down on her. The donkey between them both becomes anxious with his impatience, only making everything harder. Of course.

“Swift Wind, I’m taking you too. Can you please just let me finish this?”

Nudge. The animal’s nose alone is enough to pop her entire shoulder out of place, though such a thing would be the least of her problems.

Determined, dead set on ruining Adora's trip into town, Swift Wind stares her down with eyes almost human. Adora finds herself staring back, challenging him, then she returns to the donkey, forcefully tying down the cargo the animal will be hauling. Today she thinks to buy something extra. Buy something sweet.

Then it happens.

Rope falls. Cargo tips dangerously to one side of the donkey and the animal nearly topples over. Horse neighs. Hooves stomp. The air itself shifts, bad omens stinking up her nostrils.

A posse is riding onto the land. Lawmen; their badges sparkle underneath the late morning sun, stars shining like they might be real. Like they might belong above, the natural show Adora has spent much of her life staring at in fascination. What makes the lights so great? Why must they be so far away? Why can't she be among them?

No, not lawmen. Bounty hunters. Adora's heart jumps out her throat, beneath Swift Wind's stomping hooves, to be crushed forever. Finally, after all these years of dread and stiffness from looking over her own shoulders, she will be free from this life.

Unfortunately, it won't happen that way. She could never take the easy way out. Instead, her brain begins to assess options as they present themselves: run or fight. Shoot one or two of them and ride off. Her horse could cross the country in a blink. Run now: they'd never be able to catch up.

No, neither will bring her good fortunes. Nothing will ever free her from this life, nothing so easy as running. Running and fighting—that's her entire book so far. She'll simply stand here, a fool, a statue, a walking corpse, and the universe will finally deliver to her what she's destined for years now. At least she'll finally get to see those stars up close.

Boots. These people are well dressed. Moving in a calculating way, a coordinated way. Long guns sit on the same side of each horse,

and each horse and each gun appears to be identical. All carbon copies of one another. Clean boots—not a speck of dust on any of them. Badges shining—

Those aren't badges.

It's the Horde. The group the old man used to—

Adora isn't smart enough to examine the man in charge here, and she curses herself for it. She's been on the run as long as she's been alive. Why wasn't it first instinct? No, instead all she can think about, selfishly, dumbly, is how tired she is right now.

The man standing in front of her is one she can never forget. He did not raise her, not the way his father tried to. He was never sat around and told stories. He was the shut-in, the one hissing and baring his fangs. He stands now, after years and years he's supposed to have spent in the grave, his intense eyes grappling themselves into the deepest crevices of Adora's existence.

"Adora Grayskull." This isn't the villain monologue. He doesn't grin down on her, showing his twisted, pointed, bunched up teeth. He barely makes the effort to look down on her, to look at something other than the anxiety boiling in Adora's eyes.

Adora looks up at him, a bead of sweat crawling down her face, just barely missing the bottom of her eye. She's forgotten how to breathe. "Hordak."

Well dressed, the way she remembers him. A long black suit jacket hangs from his bone-skinny frame, the tail of the coat beginning at the ends of his hips, trailing long past his knees and creating some sort of skirt. After all these years, he still looks skinny enough to fall over to his death. Adora catches the gold chain hanging from between the two ends of the jacket, holding them together. Overall, it looks too big for him. A bright undershirt with matching pants that have never seen dirt in their life. One item perfectly recalls Hordak to Adora: the green and white cane keeping the man upright. He steps forward one, his arm shaking

with the effort. The chain shifts around. The jacket sways. His boots, remaining perfectly clean above the dirt and dust around them.

Dark eyes weighing down on Adora, almost strong enough to force her head into the dirt next to those perfect city shoes. Hordak speaks again: “Your country is in need of your services.”

Anxiety washes away as Adora straightens herself out, becoming a proper human. This is different from any other time. No guns are loaded yet, making this the strangest encounter by far with bounty hunter or law. Or the Horde, the largest religious cult the small country of Etheria has ever seen. The scariest one. It's time to be scared for real now, yet all Adora can feel is energy. She’s tall, energized, conscious of her rifle slung over her shoulder, ready to bring her big, eye-opening, life-saving argument. “I already did my time, sir.”

Pushing her luck now. Playing the tough guy. Adora is kept awake at night, wondering when such luck will expire. There’s something in this reunion ready to force the rest of it out of her, and she can’t stop herself. This is Hordak. Hordak, the man she grew up with. He’s no better than her and here he is, riding with the biggest names he could find. His father might finally be proud of him.

The man’s horse is huge, a massive beast one might find in their nightmares. Swift Wind isn’t small by any means, but he looks like a puppy in comparison. It’s an obvious tell: this is the man in charge. Hordak is the biggest person in a group of the biggest people. The fact he isn’t remotely smug about it is, in all honesty, rather impressive.

He’s readied for the windy weather, a wide brimmed hat pulled low over his eyes and a green bandana over his mouth. He removes it, a clean shaven chin and trimmed mutton chops decorating his face. He's trying too hard to keep an authority about him, but Adora was always a bad kid. He used to say so, and his father used to say so. Authority was never on her radar.

It’s the very thing keeping the law’s greedy, nosy eyes on her. The very thing keeping her awake at night. She’s a bad kid, a criminal, a selfish bandit whose only companion is a horse and a donkey. She’ll never be the hero in any of those silly old books she used to read.

This is Hordak. Cold, unamused, uncaring Hordak. With his new friends, he’s an ice pick now, ready to stab and stab and tear into Adora until there’s nothing left. With everything, she can’t possibly blame him. None of this is his fault. He has his demands, and he’s never been interested in speeches. “It’s time to bring that old bitch to the grave.”

“I ain’t seen her in ten years.” Her tongue feels fat. Her throat is heavy, bruised the way her heart is racing. Hordak was a threatening force before. Now he has friends who have guns. It’s becoming rather difficult to remain the tough guy. “I wasn’t sure she was even still around.”

“All of them—” Hordak continues on, apparently unaware of Adora’s mouth speaking words— “that gang you ran with. All of them will see the light. It’s time for them to become civil.”

Some degree of amusement runs through Adora. “You ran with them, too.”

“They will pay their dues.” Again, like she’s not even here. Maybe she could try running off. Would he even notice? “There is an old fort. North of Thaymor. Has not been used since the war. I know you know it. No one has set foot in that old place.” He pauses, as dramatic as the old Hordak would be. “Until recently.”

“I’ve done my time, sir.” It’s a plea, with everything she has, but this man won’t let up. Quickly, Adora makes the extra effort to add, “Respectfully.” Hordak doesn’t care.

“You’ve served, yes. But let us not pretend there aren’t other, unproven *incidents* . I can erase those cases. Make my colleagues forget the other trouble you’ve caused. You can do me this favor,

Ms. Grayskull, or I can visit you again in a cell. Better yet, an ‘accident’ can happen by that fort.”

Adora’s eyes leave the beast-horse's giant hooves for this man’s face. Wide brimmed hat. Soulless eyes. “What do you want from me? Come on, Hordak—”

“Do not—” He stops. What happens next is strange. Hordak becomes vulnerable, beyond what can be shown with that cane. He’s never enjoyed the cane. He’s never enjoyed appearing weak. But this man, unable to catch his own breath or hold his own balance as he coughs himself nearly to death, can’t help but appear weak. Adora almost feels the need to run over and help him. She notes none of his colleagues are doing so. The horse behind Hordak accepts him as he uses the animal for balance. It doesn’t phase a soul.

This happens often. If it’s so normal, Hordak isn’t right.

He can feel Adora’s eyes bearing down on him now. Adora is the strong one now, and it fills Hordak up with that classic Hordak rage; teeth snarling, twisted, pointed, deadly. A small chest breathes hard underneath a shirt and a fancy jacket, a gold chain bouncing up and down. The green bandana returns over his mouth, and here Adora notices blood is beginning to seep out from between his teeth.

“Your gang has excellent marksmen. My bosses prefer them turned in alive. The state has suffered enough; they want to see bodies swing.”

Adora isn’t sure how that’s better than blowing the entire fort to pieces.

“I need to see the old hag. And the Mexican. You know which one I’m talking about.”

“She has a name.” Adora catches herself, clenching her jaw to hide away her frustration. Yeah, sure! Pick a fight with the

religious government agent! “I would prefer to do without the race labels. You know that. She’s a person.”

It sounds so stupid. She's supposed to be a saint? After what she’s done in her time? Even the dying man with the collapsing lungs laughs about it.

“Befriend them, if you must,” he continues. “Tell her you’re coming back to the family. You’re a silly, stupid, lost child. I know you remember how to lie and swindle. Lead them out of the fort. We will be at the ready. Do this, and your other, pending debts will be forgotten. Don’t do this, and you won’t have any freedom to care about debts.”

Adora takes a moment to appreciate the concept of a “pending debt”. Then the man she’s known and forgotten and now can’t recognize is handing her a single card and a stuffed envelope.

“Prepaid postage. Keep me updated.” Hordak turns, climbing up the monster horse like the young man he used to be. Grasping the reins, Hordak keeps eye contact with Adora. He’s not done yet. “If you try to run, Adora, remember this: we are a civilized country now. We will not forget you. Nor will we forgive you. Good day.”

All riding off, going about their business, like nothing has happened. Like no one was threatened. Certainly no one Adora cares for, right? The card in Adora’s hand reveals Hordak’s new life. His new address. His new title under the cult his father was so obsessed with. The man would ramble on and on, old and senile, and here his son is now, their leader. Their dying, ill leader spending his numbered days bent on revenge. Adora wasn’t even there when it happened, and she’s left to clean the mess up. She opens up her red jacket, the fringe decorated on the front swaying all about. The postage and the card disappears into one of the inner pockets. Right above her gun.

Swift Wind nudges her shoulder again, keeping his giant head where she can pet him. Even the horse knows the situation is

bullshit. She scratches Swift Wind's face and neck, feeling herself begin to calm. Her mind beginning to wander.

"Mexican," she repeats. She sighs, the tightness in her chest threatening to choke her. "So you are alive, Catra."

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Young. She began this life young, an apprentice learning to be the best they can. Learning to devote their lives to something unique, useful, profitable, something to keep their family and their interests supported. Something to keep a roof over several heads and warmth in the fireplace. Unique. It's the perfect word, the only word Adora can use to describe the strange, awful life she's had the pleasure of experiencing.

Swift Wind trots along, aimlessly, without haste. There is no goal here. They're simply wandering around, waiting for something to happen. She's been given the privilege of lounging around on a peaceful walk, with absolutely nobody staring at her, peering over her shoulders, waiting for the moment she makes the mistake of letting her guard down.

The thought makes Adora laugh.

She makes no haste because she is frightened. What's to come terrifies her, the same way it always has. The wide and open plains stare back at her, soulless, free, a gentle hand caressing them, smoothing them as loving fingers might on a cat. They stare at her, and she desperately wants to scream back. Look at something else! Mind yourselves! You have never known terror, and you might remain lucky to be so uninformed!

It was Catra's least favorite thing about Adora. So much, they'd argue hours into the night about it. Adora remembers the others, too. She could never forget them. The way Rogelio would stare at them the next morning, devoid of any and all sleep, hating them both dearly. Kyle would drag his feet beside the large man—from large boy to large man; Rogelio was always a giant—with nothing

in his eyes but the sheer misery of listening to two girls fight one another all night. Lonnie, the third of the trio, looking not tired, but ready to murder them both.

Jobs with the trio were never uneventful. Something going wrong almost every time. Catra and Lonnie suddenly becoming competitive for no reason. Catra and Rogelio making fun of people in Spanish, loud enough to make the dumber of their victims lash out in confused rage. Kyle was a klutz, in such a way he wasn't to wield a gun until he was well into his teenage years, and would always manage to get them caught. They were all young, stupid, trying to prove something. They all wanted to be something, and it was the most dangerous trait any of them could carry. Even the one soul of them who seemed to understand this kept her long nailed bared and long incisors ready to kill. Every single one of them was a bumbling mess, and it used to drive Adora's brother crazy with sizzling authority.

When they would age, early into their collective teen years, new members would fall into the gang. For the most part people came and people went—usually into the grave. Double Trouble, as they were called, being the favorite of the group. Never failed a job. Never saw a bounty under their name, because they were in and out like nothing. They were a ghost on every job, and it used to drive the younger crowd crazy. Catra used to refer to them as a lizard; their tall, skinny frame and their ability to blend in. Adam used to tell the old group it was nothing to be threatened by; they were all a team, all a family, and Double Trouble was picking up the slack.

The moment Adam mentioned slack, everything became competitive. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, heading off on their own jobs they managed to mess up in their own ways. Adam and Adora, together on cattle rustling. Adora and Catra, sneaking off onto their own things. The gang's secret member . . .

Adora needs to focus. She can see the road ahead, clear in the light of day. A light wind graces the side of her cheek, some dirt kicking up beneath her steed's hooves. Swift Wind's always liked

days like these. What a shame they can't both sit out here forever and enjoy it. Still, Adora might take some time to stall, pulling them both over on the side of the road. Hopping off, checking her inventory before she storms back into her childhood all over again. Here, foolishly, she actually believed she was free from all this.

"I can't believe he found Shadow Weaver." Adora strokes the side of her horse's head, watching his eyes blink in bliss. Swift Wind finds it relaxing, Adora finds it therapeutic. She holds onto it with everything she can. "He's probably been looking for her for years. *Years."*

Adora can't say she blames him. Not like she hasn't been doing the same.

The old man was his father. The old man used to call everyone his brothers. Shadow Weaver, Octavia, Double Trouble, every short-term member of the gang. His brothers. They were all equals under the light of understanding, and all sorts of nonsense like that. He was obsessed with the First Ones—those who settled this land long before today's time. He hated them. Said they never bothered with unity, structure, togetherness. Brotherhood. He used to run away to a cult called the Horde. Spending days with them before returning. Hordak hated it. Now Hordak's using them to destroy everything that destroyed him. It's poetic. It's the exact thing forcing Adora's hands to shake in fear.

"I need to focus."

Hordak and his new group. Their visions for a perfect future. Adora can't trust a group who would never leave the Fright Zone. Between the region's obsession with fair skin and how lined one's wallet is—she hopes this place is never the future. She hopes this place is destroyed, a horrible memory, a horrible lesson on what not to do. Then Adora grins. That is exactly what Catra would say.

From Swift Wind's loaded saddlebags, carrying what little Adora has managed to her name, a notebook greets the afternoon sun.

The red shade perfectly blends with her jacket and all its fringe dangling and wiggling about, the leather soft in her palms. Brand new. She's left the others behind, beginning a new one for her new, unexpected journey. She regrets not taking that donkey into town and keeping the profits. Not like she'll need the community service anymore. What she really needs now is food. And some sort of invisible spray, one which gives her the ability to blow off Hordak forever.

First entry in the journal: a doodle of Hordak. She makes it as childish as possible: elongated teeth, an extra pointy brow, a large frown. The picture waves his hands in the air, steam popping out from his ears. Then she becomes serious. Notates her bounty is somehow still active. Probably Hordak's fault. He mentioned other, pending debts. It could mean a million different things. Hordak could've penciled Adora in for some other lucky fool who got away. Or, somehow, much more frightening, he knows what she did. But that's impossible. No one knows about it. Not even Catra.

It's more likely Hordak would lie. He doesn't have much time left. Adora can hardly believe he's gotten himself sick with such a miserable disease, but something about it suits Hordak. Maybe it's the way the man has never looked as if he belongs among the living to begin with. He doesn't look good. Days are numbered. It's not a big surprise he'd dedicate his final breaths to getting revenge on Shadow Weaver. She tried to kill him, and Hordak doesn't let things go easily. It's what makes him her perfect opposite.

Adora can't afford the same risks as Hordak. But she's no different from him: she's spent years and years looking for the same person, and she cannot rest until they once again sit in the same room. Her fingers write the last day she and Catra were together, and her eyes can't believe it. Has to be fake. She has to be mistaken. Would Catra even remember her after a decade? Will she even care? What meaning is Adora to her now, a ghost roaming the plains lifelessly for ten years now?

Things will go wrong at the fort. Doesn't matter how close they all were. Double Trouble is no killer, but they're no fool. Octavia, one of the older members, she's always liked Adora. But Adora is an outsider now. Lonnie, Kyle Rogelio—they aren't best friends anymore. Aren't teammates. Family, as Shadow Weaver called them. Adora used to be Shadow Weaver's favorite. There's a million different ways the woman could react.

-

Under that mask, Shadow Weaver has never been easy to read. Adora can't forget her. An older African woman with long silky raven hair. No one can pronounce her real name, other than the fact it sounds like "Shadow" and "Weaver". Coworker to Hordak's father, before their jobs fell apart. Tall. Shadow Weaver was always large; tall; massive. A towering figure. Bright red dresses. Sometimes the memory of those outfits hits Adora, and she wants to rip off her own jacket and do away with it forever. Most of all, Adora will never forget that mask. Something happened to her back in the day, either on the job or within her new lifestyle. Never takes it off. It rests on the bottom half of her face, thin strands of hair keeping the rest of her features warm and hidden.

When those eyes meet Adora again, for the first time in a decade, Adora feels the need to drop to her knees. Start groveling. She's done wrong, so wrong, and she needs to make up for it. This should be the part where Shadow Weaver reminds Adora how much she's provided. Adora was nothing. Her and Adam—orphans to nameless parents. She took them in, and Adora's response to that was to lash out. To run away.

But she stands here. Staring into Adora. There is nothing in those eyes. They drill into the depths of her heart, traveling about her organs, searching for something hidden inside. Worth. Shadow Weaver is always looking for the worth of her target. It's the reason she's such a good businesswoman. It's the only reason she's still alive.

"Adora."

She’s a teenager again. She’s standing outside some well-protected fortress in the middle of nowhere, dozens of nothings strapped to her horse behind her. Adora has nothing, and she will never have anything so long as she stands against Shadow Weaver.

So the woman invites her inside. And Adora follows.

Dozens of eyes stare at her. Thirteen, fourteen. This is the largest the group’s ever been. Yet, none of them look confident. None of them look the part of a bandit, successful, feared, bathing in gold every night. They all look terrified. Cornered rats waiting around for their last breaths to leave them. Adora passes Octavia, the older woman who used to say nice things about her. Used to say Adora was a good kid. Would go far. Had the “stuff”, whatever that meant. Rogelio, standing not too far from her. He looks confused to see Adora. Octavia looks like she’s watching Adora take her last breaths, terrified and anxious.

Well, the good news is Adora *is* terrified and anxious!

Before Adora can think to hide her shaking hands, Shadow Weaver stops her in a small room. Windows look outside the fort, not inside. No one can watch them, and the eyes trailing Adora slowly begin to branch off, finding something else to do. They’ve looked at the corpse. No one cares much for a corpse once it's dead. Adora is dead, and she didn’t even see Catra.

Her hands shake harder.

“Your poker face, Adora.”

The sound of the woman’s voice forces Adora to sit up. She expects one of her wrists to be lashed, but Shadow Weaver shows no interest. After all, Adora is all grown up now. They’re both adults, sitting together in an abandoned war room, bounty hunters hiding in the perimeter, here to chat peacefully. Adora is sweating so hard she has to force the beads away with her jacket

sleeve. Fringe on the arm and even her chest bounce around in a way that somehow worsens her nerves.

In this war room, too small to possibly be used for any great war, Shadow Weaver sits in front of Adora. Alone. The woman never carries her own weapon. Adora has one of her brother's revolvers on her hip. Rifle on her horse, though this will do her no service now.

Together, alone for the first time in years, Shadow Weaver speaks again. "It's a miracle you didn't swing."

"It was a Fright Zone county. We both know why, ma'am." Catra used to say Adora owed this woman no respect. Maybe she was right. Maybe this woman frightens Adora, since forever, and she can't help it.

"Hmm." The silence to follow isn't thoughtful. It's demanding. Adora isn't here for no reason. Isn't here to reunite, or party. If she cared, surely she would've tried harder. Surely she would've been here many, many years previous.

Creaking. The chair Adora sits on is old, groaning miserably with each ounce of her weight she shifts. She sits with impossibly perfect posture, while the woman across from her sits sideways in the chair, leaning dangerously against the weak chairback. "Hordak." Adora decides to come right out and say it. She owes this woman everything. Unfortunately. "Shadow Weaver, he's with that church now. The one the old man used to talk about. They're powerful people—they get things done. He wants—"

"I'm aware." Expressionless eyes examine a broken nail. Filed. She's aware the nail is broken, too, and she'll be patient in its recovery.

Patient. Neutral. There are dozens of people outside, and their leader has no sense of urgency for the pack of bounty hunters waiting outside for all their heads. The same old red dress. The same old mask. Different woman.

“Shadow Weaver, he’ll kill you.”

“What meaning would that have to you?”

Adora can’t answer. She’s not sure, other than cruel irony, what is keeping her fighting for Shadow Weaver so hard. Shadow Weaver knows this. She’s no fool.

“You’ve always been soft,” she tells her old student. “It has held you back in ways you cannot comprehend.”

Adora thinks to tell the woman what she did thirteen years ago, but she holds her tongue. It’s another one of her flaws Shadow Weaver would be happy to point out: her need for competition. Catra always said this trait was directly implanted by Shadow Weaver.

Suddenly the woman leans forward, sitting correctly now. She’s halfway over the table, bent over as if she’s crumpling over herself with imbalance. Adora doesn’t move. Shadow Weaver’s eyes finally find expression, searing into Adora’s retinas with violent intent.

“You will march out there. You will meet your new colleague, a walking corpse posing as a man, and you will tell him any of the following: I was never here; wrong gang; you saw nothing; you are both incompetent fools and you should both be on your fruitless paths, separately. You, Adora, will make up a story. You will remember what I have given you, and you will repay me for it. I’m too close now for such miserable distractions.”

Adora is the one sitting forward now. “You’ve found that family’s old treasure?”

Silent. The woman holds her gaze, gripping the sides of the stone table in a way that makes veins pop out of her loose skin.

“Don’t you know it’s wrong to dream, ma’am?”

Shadow Weaver has no care for Adora's game. "If that is true, why are you here?"

She falls backward, a defeated kid before the Fright Zone's greatest and most notorious criminal. The country hates her. Everyone in Etheria knows Shadow Weaver and her gang, and they hate every single one of them. They tear through the countryside, spreading terror. Opening their pouches and placing money which never belonged to them inside, riding off without a care. They could buy anything. A boat. A ticket out of here. Buy off their bounties, and restart the climb back into criminal infamy from a clean slate. They could buy off the entire police force, every single one across the lands, and still have enough coin to bathe in.

Those are the stories, anyway.

Adora, childish before a celebrity, doesn't know what to do. Shadow Weaver doesn't care about Hordak hunting her down, and somehow Adora should've known this would be the reaction to the news. She probably knows Hordak is sick, too. If not, Adora wonders how long Shadow Weaver's lungs might laugh for. Maybe she'll take the news so well she'll invite Adora back into the family, to be loved and longed and part of something again. At least she'll have someone to hate this awful life with.

One family member enters the war room, breaking the privacy of the meeting. The intimacy of mother and best daughter is gone forever, and Adora can't help the relief washing over her in overwhelming waves. It's Lonnie who would save her, out of breath, sweaty, anything but anxious the way Adora is in this moment. She pays Adora no attention. Everything for the leader, the top dog out of all of them: "Ma'am, those bounty hunters are back. They're not hiding this time."

Then her eyes catch Adora, allowing the information to hit Shadow Weaver's steel walls and bounce right off bluntly. When Shadow Weaver is set in her goals, there's no hope for anyone

else. There's a reason they never struck it as rich as those city folk tell each other they have. Bathing in gold and blood.

Lonnie's hazel eyes look Adora up and down, examining her roughly. Lonnie looks as healthy as ever. Strong. She keeps her thick hair tied back, but it manages to bounce around as she double takes from Shadow Weaver back to Adora, confused. Not a part of the welcoming crowd from earlier.

"She knows that, you dumbass!"

Adora's heart stops.

There she is. Ten years away. Ten years of desperately scrounging around for enough to buy newspapers. Reading every single word in the hopes of the slightest mention of her. Ten years of notebook doodles. Of dreams, of longing, of yearning, of heartache so intense Adora sometimes forgot how to breathe. She's never forgotten Catra. She never could, even under the will of drug or the wrath of god. After ten years, the one thing on Adora's mind walks in so casually, so annoyed by her everyday life, her job, her purpose. Lonnie forces Catra to roll her eyes. One blue, blue as the ocean, blue as the morning sky Adora has spent hours killing under. One yellow, as the sun she's spent hours sweating under, hours of reading, hours of blind and desperate obsession.

Catra is healthy. Not as skinny as she used to be. Definitely the same level as annoyed with her peers. She's always been smarter than the rest of them. Better than the rest of them, and she knows it. Catra always said knowledge and education struck harder than any weapon could ever hope to. Here she is, the smartest among them all, the least likely to slip away into nothingness.

"Damn it Lonnie, why can't you—"

Adora doesn't know what to do when Catra's eyes fall on her. She's never thought ahead this far. She's never given herself the

pleasure of imagining this moment, this final rush through the checkered flag, to land victorious until the end of time. Adora's never imagined how she'd feel in this moment. Logically, she might feel like crying. Realistically, she feels like passing out.

Then her blood goes cold. Catra is staring at her strangely. She's not annoyed, because Adora isn't Lonnie. Adora has her own looks reserved, just for her, and in this moment Adora can recognize the unique expression Catra has tucked away: trouble. There's trouble. Neither of them are safe, and neither of them will be safe. Adora shouldn't be here. She should run away, run somewhere far away where they'll both be safe and alone and finally free to be themselves without the weight of the world around them crushing their bones.

Catra looks at Adora with great pain, and it only makes her want to fall unconscious all the more. This isn't the time, or the place, and it kills everything Adora has left inside.

Things get moving again when Shadow Weaver stands quickly, apparently caring for the danger they're all in now. Lonnie doesn't pick sides; she'll damn well tell everyone if Shadow Weaver proceeds not to give a damn. She won't preserve the woman's image the way Adora would. There's a reason she was never the favorite.

"What will it be, Adora?" Shadow Weaver crosses the table, placing herself between Lonnie and Catra. Lonnie, where she nervously glances out the window. Catra, where she stares at Adora like this really is the last time. "Would you turn in your own family, or would you help them?"

There is little thought put into Adora's response, and it's the most fatal decision she's ever made. "You're in danger, Shadow Weaver. And you're running out of road. You can't—"

"I see."

Fatal mistake. Immediately, Adora's gut twists with a regret that makes her sick. She really might pass out now. Right in front of Catra, she's ignored Catra's greatest lines of advice: never tell the boss no. Tell her yes, *then* proceed to do whatever the fuck you want. Adora doubts she'll remember, when she awakens in the next life.

Shadow Weaver dismisses Lonnie. Tells Adora their meeting is done. In this moment, Catra springs to life with a promise, eagerness overtaking her usual calm and cool. Her usual poker face Shadow Weaver tries so hard to induce onto Adora.

"I'll make sure she's out." She tosses the woman a glance before roughly grabbing for Adora's wrist, dragging her out the door so quickly the chair beneath her legs falls backwards. They're not too far to hear Shadow Weaver's following,

"Of course you will."

Passing through the courtyard. Swift Wind was not invited inside, simply waiting outside the gates for his rider. Eyes quickly pass over the pair as they make their way, and Adora knows it's because Catra's spent years of her life perfecting her scowl. The rather large hat she keeps on her head helps focus the look, she used to say. Her hand is soft around Adora's wrist. Nails are still much longer than what can be regarded as safe. Items clink around where they're mounted across her waist, a thin belt managing to hold up dozens of knives. On one side of Catra's thin waist is the other revolver previously owned by Adora's brother. It's mostly hidden by the black jacket around Catra's shoulders, showing just enough to remind those around her what she's carrying.

Catra doesn't say anything, and Adora can't help but swim in the dread of what this moment was supposed to be. Something from a romance novel. Something beautiful and shiny and bright, a field of flowers and a marching band and sunshine. Instead she's walked into her old gang's hideout, told their leader to stand down against the bounty hunters she's now revealed herself to be with,

and is rightfully being escorted out. It's a reuniting that can be written about, though it's not what Adora wanted in the books.

Once they've finally hit a safe distance from the rest of the gang, their prying eyes and their bored ears, Catra takes the first possible opportunity to tell Adora she's the dumbest person on the planet. Adora wants to kiss her, right here.

"I mean really, you are a fucking moron, you know that?" Catra stops them, just before the gates. In front of everyone, though not within their range of hearing or clear sight. Catra takes the red hat off her head, smacking Adora on the shoulder with it. Her frizzy hair, slicked back with sweat and the constant weight of accessory, jumps to life when released to the free world again, only to be smushed back down one second later.

"Come with me." It's all Adora can say. It's all Adora wants to say, and it kills her even harder when Catra doesn't immediately rush out of this place, onto the horse, and with her into the sunset.

"Idiot," Catra says instead.

"The law is coming for you, too! Come on—"

"Ten years I haven't heard from you, and the first thing you do is remind me of what's out there. Good job! Can I ask you what color the sky is next?"

"Green, obviously." Catra doesn't laugh, but it was worth a shot. Wasn't it? "Catra, please. This is it. It's Hordak out there, don't you know that? Hordak. He hated all of us, and he is not holding back—"

"Since when are you law? I always knew you were a goody two-shoes, but come on."

"They had my ranch swarmed."

"Oh great! You have a ranch! Got a wife, too?"

Catra starts for the gate, forcing it open with ease despite her smaller frame. The best way to describe Catra: she's far from what she looks. "I would never," Adora defends. It gets her to stop, all for a moment before she's pushing the gates again.

"Look," Catra tells her, "I'm finally doing well here. I'm finally off her shit list, and I finally stand a chance. I've got plenty planned, and we both know I'm smarter than any of those idiots out there. Churchgoers think they're bounty hunters now." She rolls her eyes, before grabbing Adora's arm and motioning her outside. "You're the one in trouble here, Adora. *You* need to get moving, before Hordak goes after you. Get yourself somewhere safe. Forget all of this. Wait it out."

She could never forget any of this. Adora's never been a fan of waiting, either. Not with all the million things she carries on her back, every single day, waiting for the moment her vertebrae collapse in on one another, rendering her a pile of misery on the ground. Adora marches back out to her horse, hurt and confusion weighing her down the most. She doesn't turn for Catra, unsure if she can.

Then hurt takes over and she forgets the rest.

"He's not playing this time," she tells Catra. Not turning. She's not sure she can. She's not even sure she can get on the horse, no matter how exposed she's leaving her old gang to Hordak. " *When* he gets you, it won't be pretty. You'll swing, Catra. This is it. This is nothing like before. He knows you. Knows us. It's all different. This is your last—"

Of all the dumb things she's managed to do today alone, Adora is most thankful for her ability to stand, her back physically turned on what she once cared about the most.

Because when what she once cared about the most shoots her with actual, live ammo, she's most grateful of her inability to see any of it. When she collapses against the pavement, her shoulder slamming first, then her head, then her side screaming for

bloodied mercy, she's grateful she didn't see Catra's face. Adora always thought she'd want most of all to take Catra's face to her grave, the last, beautiful sight she'd ever see. Now she's happiest of all to see pale hooves, stomping up and down, before she falls unconscious.

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"Can you wake up, please?"

"I'm not sleeping."

A long nail reached over, faster than Adora could sense in that moment, and poked her right on the bridge of her nose. A funny feeling, a tickle, slid down her spine. Adora remembers opening her eyes, finding her partner in crime—in the most literal sense of the word—examining her. Catra tried to be annoyed. But no matter what Adora did, Catra could never truly be annoyed with her.

"You're bored," Catra said. She tried to force some sort of playful smile, but Adora caught the edges of her lips. How they wanted to curl into a frown. Offended. Adora sat up, the borrowed hat she'd stuck over her eyes falling forward as she straightened up against the tree trunk behind her.

"No, I'm not! Honest." She'd examined Catra's features from this point, desperate to reverse any possibility of that frown forming fully. Adora always hated to see Catra upset.

Catra stole back the red leather hat from Adora's lap. Smooth, a little rough in some places. The leather is old, and the hat is older. It's the only thing strong enough to tame Catra's massive mane of hair, but she set it aside for now. The book in her lap remained opened, tilting dangerously as she inched closer to Adora. When her head met the edge of Adora's shoulder, Adora quickly slouched again. Both of them, relaxed. Comfortable. Such a rare feeling.

Book is forgotten. Untouched. It rested in Catra's lap, loyally opened to where she'd left off, patiently awaiting to have another page turned in a few moments. Catra's hand left the edges, unsupporting the thin pages to battle alone against the soft wind. The top left corner of the page on the left threatened to turn, flapping up and down with indecision. Eventually it finally sat down, weak and tired. It's so bright out today, even underneath the large tree in the old camp, Adora could easily make out every word on the page. They all jumped out with desperate anticipation, adventure and imagination impatient to infect its reader.

Each and every book in Catra's massive collection was expensive. That's just how books were. They could truly only be enjoyed just the one time, yet each and every copy cost enough for three nights' worth of dinner. But Catra collected them. They barely brought in money. Most of it went back into repairs. Old wagons. Medicines, when jobs went horribly wrong. Clothes for rapidly growing children. The old man needed tons and tons of paper, for hours' worth of psychotic scribbling. Most costly: weapons and ammunition. Catra barely had anything to wear, sometimes to eat, and still she'd rush to the nearest town, find their book store, and return with one or two new tales. She'd spend hours reading. She'd make Adora spend hours reading, and Adora was annoyed with violent impatience with every word they read together.

Little did younger Adora know, her future self would become obsessed with the act.

"What's it about?" The best Adora can do for today is try. Try to invest herself in this expensive thing Catra is obsessed with. If Catra liked it, Adora would try as hard as she could. Anything to erase any possibility of that frown.

"Fiction; a sailor stumbles across a lost treasure in Salineas. He tells a bunch of villagers about it, in the town nearby, and they all try to trick him out of it." In the moment Catra started laughing, so hard Adora couldn't help but smile to herself. "It's fucking hilarious. What an idiot!"

Adora turned to her, accidentally causing Catra to lift her head off Adora's shoulder. "What would you do if you found a buried treasure? Don't say buy books."

"Well obviously I would buy books. Come on, you dummy." Catra leaned forward, grabbing a handful of grass. Her long nails scratched into the backs of each of her fingers, lightly pressing down as she pulled a whole wad of green from the earth. She rubbed each of the blades between her fingertips, using her palm as a table. Then, at the end of her thinking, she dropped the green back into the whole heap beneath them. Leaning against the tree once more. "Do you remember that house we robbed in Plumeria a few weeks ago?"

Adora raised a brow, tilting her head humorously. "We robbed a lot of houses in Plumeria."

"I know you know which one. They just built it—you can tell from the paint, the fact the wood was barely chipping off, how clean the kitchen counters were—and they just had to leave it alone for the night. Remember, you said it was a house warming present we were giving them?"

"That big white one? Crooked fence?" Adora was no rancher, not much of a handywoman. But damn it, that fence was offensively bad. Catra nods excitedly in response, her frizzy hair bouncing all over the place. "Yeah, I remember that one."

Catra makes a gesture with her hands, as if presenting the house right now.

"You would buy that big old place? That's a lot of land."

"One day, Adora, we will be ranchers. *We* will be the assholes getting attacked by rustlers. And hanging their bloodied skulls on the porch when they realize how badly they fucked up, messing with us."

"Ranchers." Adora leaned against the tree once again, feeling herself relax again. She could imagine the blissfully boring life,

waking up every morning to argue with a bunch of sheep and pigs. Hauling a wagon into town, always returning with money. Money and no bounty. It's the easiest life Catra could imagine, and Adora longs for it until her chest begins to ache. "That would be nice, wouldn't it?"

Catra collapses against the tree next, bending her legs in front of her. The book falls aside, forgotten, knocking against her hat and her discarded boots. Catra's other weird trait: her natural hatred for shoes. Boots, slippers—everything. She'd go about bare foot if they didn't all spend their lives constantly on the run. Her head plopped against Adora's shoulder again, still and quiet. Adora didn't feel herself drifting off to sleep until Catra spoke again.

Black jacket draped across her legs. Some time has passed, or Catra reached for the garment and Adora didn't notice. The tale about the unfortunate Salineas traveler formally sat on the ground, closed carefully. "Are you sleeping again?"

"No." Adora forces her left hand into her eyelid, rubbing at it until her vision turns to spots. "You're sleeping."

"Did you hear what I said?"

Other hand rubs the other eye now. "Yes. But I like your voice, so you should—"

"Very smooth." Catra sat up, away from the trunk and away from Adora's shoulder, looking into her eyes now. One blue, one yellow, staring into Adora. She was going to ask something serious, and the mere prospect of it made Adora's nerves begin to buzz. "There's only one real way to get a place like that. Not the bank—don't say it, smart ass—not the rich guy down the road. There's only one real place with money around here. Shadow Weaver's stash. We both know she has more than she's letting on."

Adora's head twisted upward, a confused dog left out in the rain. "What? Rob Shadow Weaver's stash?" She wanted to laugh, but

she wanted to hurt Catra's feelings less. Instead she settled for, "Good luck."

"You want to get out, too." Catra leaned forward, sitting closer to Adora. Lining their faces together. "What's stopping you? What's stopping us from getting the life we deserve?"

Starting with the fact stealing from Shadow Weaver was an impossible feat . . . "We both know Adam and I can't live a free life. We need structure. All that open land—we'll go mad by sunset."

A finger jabbed harshly into Adora's chest as Catra leaned back, sitting on her haunches. "Not funny. We both hate this life. What's the point of sticking around?"

It wasn't the first time they had the conversation. It was almost a bit between the two, a rehearsed show that never ended well. No matter how many times the scenario came up, no matter how many, many chances Adora had to practice her answer, she could never come up with one. It used to drive Catra insane.

Then, one day, the universe chose for the both of them.

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Getting shot wasn't the hardest part. It was easy, falling over into the pavement, lifeless, ready to see the great beyond and start the next life. No, the hardest part is getting up the next morning—or the morning after that morning, Adora isn't sure when or where or *if* she even is—and pretending she's alive, a functioning human being who totally didn't have a large piece of lead shred through her skin. It isn't the first time she's been shot, but nothing about the amount of times she's been shot means she's about to become immune to it. As nice as it would be.

Someone has taken care of her. Someone ventured to the fort, someone stupid who should've stayed on their own path, and brought her in. Took care of her. Without her fingers, she knows the bullet went through her side. Didn't hit anything important.

Warning shot. Then again, with her fingers, she can tell the bullet wasn't too big. Nothing insane.

Nothing bigger than a revolver bullet sitting on her ex-partner in crime's hip.

Adora forces herself up. She's going to pretend really hard to be a human today, mostly because she's unsure how long she's been a zombie for. At least one day has passed; it was near nighttime when she was shot and now the morning sun is threatening to burn her eyes out of their sockets. The inspection comes second, after her body is rudely disturbed from its wishes and dreams of eternal slumber, regretfully forced to remember how to function again.

Small hut. It should be a storage room at a large ranch. Somewhere to store chicken feed. Extra shovels for extra large horse shit. It could pass as a small merchant's stand, if the merchant were incredibly poor and incredibly low on self respect. No, this place is decorated. Staged as a small home. A trunk is at the end of the small bed she's been dead for how many days or hours in, filled with something she can't guess. A pre-filled death certificate, just in case.

Adobe, just like the fort. A small wood table is in the corner, a set of lumber and a tiny cooking spit next to it. Small dishes are left behind, perfectly portioned for one person. Small bed. This is a one person home; a guest house. Rugs bring the atmosphere to life, some colorful and some tame to keep the energy neutral. The blanket trapping Adora to the bed is made entirely of fur, soft beneath her hands when she reaches over to stroke it. She turns to the other side, her wound cursing her, and finds a deer head mounted on the ceiling.

If this place has been decorated, she's not in a camp. The chances of Hordak waiting for her outside are lesser than she initially anticipates. Good. Last thing she needs is a lecture from Hordak on why she couldn't grab her buddy Shadow Weaver for coffee and a good old fashioned hanging.

After several moments, Adora decides to make the biggest mistake of her life: stand up. All her stuff waits for her on the other side of the room. Jacket, boots, even her gray jeans are staring back at her. One half of Adam's revolvers. Rifle. Notebook. Catra's hat.

Catra's hat. She would never, ever leave that thing behind. Can't be anybody else's—Adora has yet to meet anyone else walking around with a bright red hat.

Instant regret. Instantly begging to lay back down, the earth collecting her mortal body forever and taking it somewhere she can't possibly get shot ever again. Take her to the heavens, bless her with the chance to ever do anything but watch ever again!

The moment Adora's socks take the floor, her feet for balance, her ankles for support, her knees and hips ready to carry the rest of her, she feels her stomach preparing itself to show her just how dumb she is for choosing to get up and live. Sweat breaks out across her head. She won't sit back down. That hat is calling her, teasing her, and she wants to go over there and ask it why and how it got away from its owner.

It's embarrassing, frankly, how long it takes Adora to get over to the table. This home isn't particularly large. A normal person might make the journey in three or four steps. Easy. It's right there. Everything in here is right there, yet so far away. Everything is miles and miles away, and everything is slowly inching away from her the closer she gets, the harder she tries. Adora hugs the wall, bumping past the boarded-up window. Some sunlight manages to seep in through the wood, a mechanism waiting for her to turn the place into a tanning zone. No way. She might puke her guts out for real.

In the next lifetime, when Adora finally completes her journey to the lone table in this lonely hut, she finds it. The red hat. Her red jacket. Her red boots. Her red notebook. Her red blood, she imagines, when she coughs her lungs out of her chest in a perfect Hordak impression. She doesn't sit. She's afraid of what happens

when she does, afraid of getting stuck without any chance of getting out. Much like the encounter at the fort. The fort, where she was shot!

The red hat stares back at her, and Adora swears it's winking at her notebook. They're both red leather. Friends? Family? Old partners in crime?

A note falls out from the binding, where it's been crumpled between the second and third pages. Crazy handwriting. Only a madwoman could create such a horrendous sight, such an awful calligraphy best left behind on the side of the road. Only one person in the world has handwriting this bad, and she's left behind not only the note, but her prized hat.

The law left you behind.

Adora immediately copies the words into her notebook. She can't forget them. Can't lose them. The law left her behind—Hordak thinks she's dead. She's free. Free to go wherever she wants, free to ride off and forget any of this even happened. She can return to that old farm and take the donkey into town, saving her extra earnings for something new. Something that isn't this life, the old life, or a new life of perpetual investigation.

No way. Catra left her hat behind. Adora needs to get back into that fort.

Eventually. In time she'll get there, preferably when it doesn't take her hours and hours of effort to put on the same pair of jeans she's had for years, the boots she's had for decades, and the jacket she's sure she's had all her life. Adora won't even try to bother with her hair for now. She slaps on Catra's hat, the safest place for it being right on her person, because hey, she never does anything stupid! Revolver on her hip. She'll leave the rifle for now. Definitely leaving the saddle for now. Adora slips the slim journal into one of her inside pockets, weighing one side of the jacket slightly. The note is forever preserved inside. The notice of her freedom, forever preserved in writing.

Catra shot her. There's no way it was anyone else. No one was close enough. If Catra did shoot her, why is she trying to help now?

Bullet went to a non-lethal location. Adora woke up with the note, a trusted source of information. The hat, a sign of trust. Catra is on her side. Then why does it feel like she isn't?

When the burning, blistering morning sun bursts into her view, immediately searing her corneas and invading her skin with the vitamin D she knows she's missed for however long, it's hard to debate anything regarding Catra. Something about going blind in the natural light forces Adora to grasp for her side, and in turn grasp for the wall behind her. It's all too much. Her ear rings the way her heart decides to pound, screaming and shouting about how stupid she is for one, getting up in the first place and two, bothering to go outside. Lay down and die, damn it!

On reflex, she bends her head. Catra's hat protects her eyes from any further brightness, and somewhere along the way her hand leaves her side and starts rubbing at her eyes. Her head feels ready to burst. She'll see her brains out on the floor, and unlike what Shadow Weaver used to say, it won't be from some silly gun.

A third hand grabs Adora's shoulders. She should swat them. Normally she would. How dare they put their hands on her! Don't they know how wanted and hated she is? Post-zombie Adora can't help it. She's going to fall over any minute now and she knows it, and somehow it's bunches less embarrassing to accept the help than it is to stubbornly slam against the dirt. A fourth hand, on her other shoulder. She feels herself moving, her feet dragging along as the sunlight disappears. The sun is miraculously turned off for the day, and she's eternally grateful for the wizard responsible.

"They'll be with you in a second, okay? They've both been waiting for you."

No effort is put into whoever her mystery saviors are. If "they" even are her mystery saviors. Adora spends the next few moments trying to re-center herself in the universe, and more importantly keep the contents of her gut within her gut and not all over the nice floor. Back in the hut. She will never, ever touch those windows. Adora sits alone at the small table, her left boot resting against her horse's saddle, her left hand continuing to rub at her eyes. Weirdly, it's relaxing her. She feels her head slouch sideways, against one of the walls.

Knocking at the door. Adora remains slouched miserably against the wall, half alive, half walking regret, barely able to process what it is she's staring at. They are here. Two individuals. One sheepishly places a cup of water on the table in front of her, taking her hand from its incessant rubbing and placing it around the drink. Another, smaller hand rubs at her shoulder before backing off. Sympathy for the walking dead. Hand feels smaller. One of these people is a woman. Look at that, she's managed to make a useful observation!

"We didn't think you'd be up yet." It's a man. A woman and a man are in the room with her. His voice is deep, refined, mature. He's seen some things. Adora wonders if they've seen the same amount of things. "You're really tough!"

"Or really stubborn." The woman. Her voice is riddled with sarcasm, yet she also manages to seem concerned. It's exactly what Catra used to do. Trying to keep things playful instead of dreadfully awkward. Though Adora isn't so sure what's so awkward about finding a corpse on the side of the road, bringing it home, and watching it walk again.

Something about the sentiment, or perhaps the word stubborn in itself, brings Adora back to life. It's her last hoorah before everything goes black again. She can't quite sit up, as lovely as it would be to have that type of strength, but she can lean her head upwards. She's sweaty, she notices.

Both of these people look nice enough. They have to be, she guesses. That, or they need something out of this corpse. Adora gets a better look at them. One of the tricks she's learned over the years: always look the person over before you talk. She recalls the one time she and Catra were at a bar and Catra slung insults at the guy next to them, not looking, not realizing how giant and murderous he looked. Neither of them returned to that town for months.

First thing Adora notices is they're both people of color. Definitely good people. Brave people, in these parts. Wherever she is. The second thing she sees is the fact the couple is sharing the same pair of earrings; the woman with a diamond hanging from her right, the man with a diamond out of his left. Standing close together. They're familiar with one another, intimately. The man looks like he's supposed to be holding this woman's hand, but things are too anxious right now to do so. He's the caretaker; she's the one who gets things done. A gentle man and a tough woman—Adora thinks she might stay here forever.

Thirdly, and probably Adora's favorite part: the woman has bright pink hair. All of it. It's short in length, cutting her maintenance time way down, but every single strand of it is bright pink. Every single one.

"Stubborn sounds like me," Adora finally says. Gets some amusement out of the woman. She nudges the man, though he looks paralyzed with fear. He also looks almost as sweaty as Adora. It runs down the stubble on his soft baby face, shimmering down on his stomach where his shirt is cut, exposing his navel to the world.

"We don't really have a doctor here, so I did my best on you," the man says. Adora has no idea how to thank him.

"Military experience," the woman explains. Adora notices her boots are bright pink, as well. She reaches a gloved hand outward, before deciding there's no way Adora can shake it just

now. instead she puts it upward, half waving. “I’m Glimmer. This is my husband, Bow. We found you.”

If Adora didn’t still feel like spilling her guts everywhere, she would stand up, have some manners. Shake their hands. Thank them vigorously before explaining how much she hates imposing, leaving out the door and out of their hair forever. For now all she can do is use her only asset and nod at the both of them. “Sir. Missus. I’m Adora. Adora Grayskull.” She blinks twice, considering drinking that water. Ultimately she turns it down. Looks at Bow again. “It’s a lovely land you’ve got here, sir. I managed a whole blink of it before I died all over again.”

“Thanks,” Bow says. It’s quick, deflective. One hand moves through his short, thick hair, cropped on top with nothing on the sides. Big hand. When his arm flexes with the movement, Adora notes how muscular he is. Then he corrects, “Uh, but Glimmer sort of runs things around here. Her family’s land.”

“Recently my land.” Glimmer’s voice is far away, before she brings herself back. Waking up. “My parents passed and left it all to me. I’m still figuring it all out. Ranching isn’t as easy as it looks, you know?”

Ranch. This place should, indeed, be a store room, but it’s a room for guests. How large is this place? Adora wonders what type of shape it’s all in. How much Glimmer has managed to figure out on her own.

With renewed energy, Adora finds she can sit herself up slightly better. Lift her head off the wall. Her left hand can grip the cup a little tighter, and once again she contemplates taking a drink. Maybe in a second. She eyes the both of them, before focusing her attention to Glimmer. The one who runs things around here. “We’re on a ranch, missus?”

“Huge ranch.” Glimmer eyes her curiously, unsure of Adora’s intent. The fact she can’t guess it, the fact she hasn’t brought it up already, tells Adora everything she needs to know about this

gentle man and this tough woman trying to pave her way: these are kind people.

"Let me help you out. It's the least I can—"

"Hey, you don't have to repay us." Bow places one of his hands outward, stopping Adora. "Really, you don't have to."

"You didn't have to pick me up on the side of the road. I want to help." Adora thinks to prove her point by standing tall and giving a huge speech on usefulness, but the mere thought of standing up makes her head spin all over again. "I'm not much of a rancher, but I know some things. I'm strong. My horse is huge—he can help too. Please, it's the least I can do."

"Maybe when you feel better," Bow says, accepting her offer. Glimmer smiles about something, stepping slightly closer to Adora.

"Your horse is a hit. Everyone loves him. He's okay, by the way. Nothing happened to him."

Good. Swift Wind is the largest portion of what little she has. Him, and a hat left with her body on the side of the road. She tells them, "I really appreciate you both. Thank you. I'll get to work when I can."

Bow is halfway out the door, his diamond earring sparkling under the morning sun in a blinding light, when Glimmer stops walking. She turns around, looking back on Adora once more. Her arms are crossed. She's a big woman, in a way Adora doesn't often see. Usually the size comes with paranoia and special cheats to get thin, but Glimmer doesn't seem to care. Doesn't seem like the type of person to care. Again, Adora kind of wants to stay here forever. As long as she can before these people figure out what kind of person she is and kick her out in terror, disgust, and loud cussing. Shoving soap in their mouths to erase the feeling of sharing a simple conversation with her.

Glimmer asks, with an innocent curiosity, “What were you doing up by that fort, Adora? Everyone here knows that place is a death trap.”

“Honestly, ma’am,” Adora finally takes a sip of that water, feeling the warmth all the way down her throat, “I have no friggin’ idea.”

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“Adora! Good morning!” Bright and early in the morning, as any day, Bow stands as happy as ever in his perpetual good mood, waving at Adora. His hands are full with some crates, which appear to be in rough shape, but he stops to greet her. Every day. He’s the nicest man on the planet and Adora wonders how it’s possible for one person to curate so much happiness. Though she supposes if she were as happily married as he, she’d wake up every morning ready to shake the world’s hand.

Couple of days have passed now, almost enough to see the end of the week. Adora has yet to fall over and die formally, meaning she’s healing. She’s going to heal, and she’s going to get better, which means she needs to start doing something before she falls apart inside and explodes of pure boredom. She owes these people a lot. They should be regarding her a mooch for laying around all day, drawing silly doodles, but no one has said a thing. Not to her face, anyway.

Lately she’s been feeling tremendously better. Almost like it never happened. Today might be the best she’s felt all week, so today she’ll be the most pushy she’s been about getting up and doing something. She tails Bow, following him until he places the busted up crate near what this little place regards as a marketplace. Some merchant passed by years ago, almost nothing to her name, and Glimmer’s parents took her in. Let her stick around and sell any extra supplies for the convenience of not riding hours into town. Adora waves at the woman, who if she recalls correctly is called Juliet around here.

Then Adora eyes Bow, the sweaty outcome of hauling multiple boxes back and forth all morning making itself present across his forehead. He pants slightly, a perfectly healthy man who does these sorts of things every day with a bright smile on his face. He's shaved recently. "Walked all the way over here without vomiting!"

A breathless laugh escapes Bow, hunching him over slightly. Then he takes a handkerchief from his back pocket, cleaning up his face a little. "I knew you'd live. I never gave you the tour."

Adora gestures with the hand on her not-shot side, waving it in the general direction of sheep. A cattle dog sits with them in the pen, sunning himself and watching his stock wander about. "Let's go, then."

Sand crawls against Adora's scuffed red boots as they go about. Bow starts them at one end of the ranch, close to the open road leading back to the nearest town and the next ranch over. Adora spots a stagecoach driver laying around, taking a rather hard nap as he snores into the afternoon air. Her revolver digs into her side as she walks, rudely reminding her it's here. Of course it is—she'd never willingly part with it.

Horses. The pen is huge, horses being the biggest draw and the biggest payout on the land. Glimmer's parents, right before they passed, finalized a deal with a huge stagecoach company. They raise the horses, the company pays a fortune for their drivers to sit around and nap all day. A separate stable is closer to the head family's mansion further down the road. Bow says Swift Wind has been staying there, when he's not running around the pen impatiently.

Crossing down the road. A slight wind is kicking some of the dirt up now, threatening to seep over the top of Adora's loose boots. Harder to tie them these days. Though dragging her feet doesn't help much. Bow shows her more of the houses on the land, belonging to some ranch hands and their families. An older man is standing outside, taking down wet clothes that have dried rather

easily in today's heat. A white dog grazes his legs, and he stops fighting with the fabric to pet their head before continuing onward. Bow regards the ranch as a small town—complete with a merchant. Everyone knows everyone around here, who to turn to for help, what makes their neighbor tick. The second Adora was brought in, she became an instant celebrity born of pure curiosity. Even now she finds eyes staring her down. A little kid waves at her, saying something about the dead stranger walking around. Seems accurate.

They pass by the small house Adora has been staying in. Bow tells her he and Glimmer want to be more open to those who pass them by. Get more guest houses like the one Adora occupies currently. Glimmer's parents always managed to attract strangers to the property, and in turn connections and coin. Her father had a way of getting along with everyone, Bow tells her. Adora thinks to tell Bow he seems to be the same way.

"What we really need is a physician who's willing to stay around here. Someone who can do stitching much better than I can."

"Who cares if the stitching is a little crooked?" Adora regards Bow where they've stopped in front of her temporary home, sheep making noise behind them. "You did a good job. You saved a corpse!"

"Right," he responds, shaking his head. "Dr. Bow. Anyway, these are the sheep I'm sure you've probably heard all morning and all night. If they ever get too loud, just speak to Kowl."

Furrowing her brows, Adora asks, "Kowl?"

Then Bow starts laughing to himself, pointing across the way. The dog. The Australian cattle dog sitting in the corner, tanning, yawning when Bow's finger meets his direction. "He's in charge. He makes the big bucks, you know. The biggest steaks we have."

"Hopefully not stray sheep," Adora jokes.

“He’s a good boy.” The dog’s red coat glows in the sun, the color pronounced and highlighted in the lighting.

“Good enough to not bite me when I steal his steak?” Adora isn’t sure if she’s kidding. Depending on the steak, of course. Bow gives her a curious look, wondering who on Etheria would steal from a poor dog.

“I am not stitching that one up,” he tells her. “But if you want to ask the cows nicely, you can find them in the fields outside our little town.” They both keep walking at a moderate pace, passing by where the chickens and the pigs dwell. Adora can smell the pigs from a mile away. “We’re mostly livestock here—I’m glad to hear you’re more of a steak girl. Don’t worry, we’ll get you some later. Other crops we get from some of the other farmers around here. Specifically a farmer out in Plumeria—her crops are *amazing* . She’s magic with it!”

Other farms out in the area. Bow says they’re all buddies, trading with one another often. Sometimes doing personal favors, like the one time Glimmer forgot about Bow’s birthday and needed to throw together something fast. Bow says he’s not much of a birthday party guy, but Adora knows for a fact he’s the type of man to go all out for Glimmer’s day.

Then he says something that really catches Adora’s attention: “It’s good for everyone to stick together in this part of the plains.”

Guest house. So casual about finding Adora on the side of the road. She wonders if she’s the first corpse they’ve brought back to life on the ranch. She’s never been anywhere near Bright Moon ranch before. The place is too small and the towns are too far. Not worth any profit. Shadow Weaver had a lot of mouths to feed, mouths that got hungry quickly.

Reading her mind, Bow mentions something about not needing extra food for Adora. There’s plenty to go around. He says she doesn’t eat much and she’s unsure how to respond. She’s always been thin, much smaller than her brother, though never smaller

than Catra. Maybe she'll pick the habit up while she's bumming around this poor ranch.

They stop at the end of the road, where the giant horse pen finally ends and Glimmer's giant house sits higher on the hill, watching everything. Adora sees Glimmer herself, quite easy to spot with the bright pink hair, working around the stables. Talking to someone about a new hay supplier's lower prices. She's unsure to make the switch. She values loyalty and would hate to suddenly put their guy out of business.

The moment Glimmer notices Bow and Adora walking over, she perks up with the prospect of ignoring the difficult conversation, even if only for a moment. She takes her time smooching Bow, asking Adora how she's feeling. Then Glimmer thinks of something else, running off, leaving this conversation and the pale man she speaks with to tan in the sun no different than Kowl.

"I bid you and your wife good day for now," he tells Bow. His small-lens spectacles sit low on his nose, looking ready to completely fall off his face. He's not worried about it. He closes the large book in his hand, the binding sounding miserable and used. He walks off, his perfectly polished black shoes scraping against the dirt. Bow says he's the man who does the numbers for the town. They've been in a really rough patch since Glimmer's parents passed. Adora can imagine how dead inside the poor accountant must be.

It's all the thought she can give to the man before Glimmer returns, holding the reins to Swift Wind in her hand. The horse excitedly shifts, bobbing his head at the sight of Adora. She can't help but run over, relief washing over her in the knowledge they both managed to survive her supremely stupid plan.

" *Everybody* is in love with him, Adora," Glimmer says. She stands nearby, petting Swift Wind with her own gloved hand. Bow reaches over and gives Swift Wind his love, too. "He's a really funny guy. Very expressive. It's like he's a human in a horse costume."

The horse makes a happy sound, practically hopping on his front hooves next. “As long as you’re making friends, buddy,” Adora tells him. “Maybe you’ll charm some poor girl into getting you a steak.”

“He’s a beautiful horse,” Glimmer says again. “But don’t worry, I won’t steal him.” She grins, mischievously. “I’ll just wait until you get shot again.”

Great, he’ll belong to Glimmer by next week. Adora turns away from the horse, facing the owners of the property. The two who would take her in without question and without debt. “Look, we gotta get to talking about that. I’m feeling better. I’m ready to work. Let me say thank you.”

“You really are stubborn,” Glimmer sighs, and Adora shrugs. One gloved hand runs through pink hair, messy with the sweat of the day’s work. Bow hands her the handkerchief.

“There’s something here needs doing, I’m sure of it.” Adora is quick to talk before her hosts can cut her off and baby her any further. “If not me, Swift Wind. He’s big, and he’s strong. He can haul.”

“Hey,” Glimmer says, pointing her finger at Adora’s face, “he’s famous around here. He’s too cool to work!”

“How about—” Bow steps forward, and though he appears amused by Adora’s psychotic need to harass them to let her help, she knows he’s just trying to get her to shut up about wanting to help out— “in the morning you help with the chickens. Just feed them. Right now you need to rest up. You were shot, remember?”

Honestly, she doesn’t remember much other than smacking against the pavement. “Fine. But I’ve never been much good at resting.” She points at them both one last time, her own way of threatening them with whatever organs can actually maintain a threat right now, before returning to her home.

Sundown creeps up on Adora as she spends the next few hours in her journal, drawing nothing. She recreates the horse pen, and

then the sheep. Kowl, napping in the morning sun. She has to peek outside to remind herself exactly where the dog's fur is spotted on his body. Adora draws her own horse, hosting some kind of social event in which he stars in. He speaks, like he's human, perhaps a little too much.

Most of all, she wonders. Wonders what she and Catra would do in a place like this. Would they run the merchant stand? Be terrible stagecoach drivers together? Tan under the afternoon sun like an accomplished cattle dog? She imagines spending the entire day tending to the animals together, falling to bed exhausted, both their bones tired, their muscles quaking in physical achievement. She imagines Catra in the mud, refusing as usual to throw on some boots, saying something Adora can't possibly agree with about living in mother nature's embrace. Catra's eyes in the afternoon sun, the sweat on her brow pronounced and bold. Living in a small house. Living in the big house at the end of the road, their names the most important on the land. They would be in charge, they would be responsible for the happenings of the day. They would be married without the threat of the law coming down on them, chasing them until the end of time itself.

In the morning they would both wake up, ready to start another day of ranch work together.

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One minute she's feeding the chickens, the next she's running out of the coop to the sounds of screaming. All in all, the chickens were kind to her. Didn't care that Adora was nervous at all. Adora, who used to run around and rob banks, afraid of chickens. Chickens don't care who feeds them, only that they're fed. She takes note of all of them. Most of them are pretty large, others with some ways to go. She's about to tack on another task for herself, ready to ask the other ranch hand in here if they need help collecting eggs for the morning, when the sound of screaming erupts from elsewhere.

Suddenly Adora is aware of two things more than anything else in the world: the gun on her hip, and the way the gun on her hip digs into her right side. It's her brother's way of telling her she's not well enough to run a few paces down the road, so how can she possibly help someone with eggs? How can she possibly hope to get into manual labor like everyone else around her? She stops running, only because people are fleeing from a storehouse. Not because Adam won this round, no way. Glimmer and Bow arrive on the scene and they all make eye contact with one another.

Bow asks someone how it's possible. They were so careful. They tell Bow they're not a liar and Glimmer sends them away to lie down before they start something. They grumble about rats in the food stores as they walk away, steam erupting from their ears.

"My dad hasn't seen rats on the ranch since he and Mom bought the land," Glimmer says. She shakes her head, disappointed in herself. "What would he say now?"

"We can get rid of them, Glimmer." Classic positive Bow. Not even rats and the loss of food can get him down, and Adora wonders how she can possibly learn this from him. "I can set some traps and—"

"Bow! They're eating our food! There's no time for traps!"

Gun leaves Adora's hip. There are some extra rounds inside her jacket pocket, right next to the journal. This will be an interesting entry. Glimmer sees the weapon first, and Adora worries she'll take it as a threat. Yell for her to put the weapon away before someone else gets shot. Not Glimmer. She sees the older weapon, jaw opening and grin widening the moment her eyes fall on the revolver. Bow is the opposite. He looks terrified not for himself or those around him, but for the unfortunate rats who would wander onto the land.

"Please don't murder the rats," he says, sympathetic for the parasites doing away with his hard-earned food. Glimmer is the

opposite. She chants *Murder them! Murder them!* until Adora steps closer to the doors, then she's full on cheering.

Adora pauses at the door, pushing the red hat on her head upwards slightly. She looks directly at Bow, her gun in hand, one finger pulling the safety off. "You might wanna look away, sir."

He makes some sort of sad sound, meanwhile his wife urges Adora Onward! To the slaughter!!

Even in the shade of the wooden structure, Adam's revolver manages to shimmer, a gold bar in a clear river, washed over and over again for the person who would manage to wield it. It was the only impressive, expensive thing he ever let himself buy. Not steal. Adam bought both these revolvers, with honest money from working a ranch not unlike this place. Two golden revolvers with long nose barrels, six inches in length. The handle has no wood finish, not like most of the other guns Adora has seen and used, but pearl. Ultimately it looks like the kind of thing that should be boxed up in a fancy display frame in a fancy man's mansion, waiting to be stolen by a person like Adora. It's almost too beautiful to shoot, Adam used to say, before following up with how much he paid for it and shooting off several rounds.

When the gun shoots, Adora feels nothing. The weapon barely jumps, graceful and polite as it splatters rat guts all over the walls. Some of the others scurry away. Adora catches one on the ceiling, watching it fall back against the sand floor. Another scurries past Glimmer outside, who stops cheering joyously for a second to scream in horror, and Adora tags it when it passes in front of her boots. She inspects the crates and the large sacks of potatoes, finding and downing one more. Seems to be all, for now.

"On the bright side, we can make rat stew later." Adora meets the couple outside, where they've yet to move, tucking the weapon away. Bow looks heartbroken over the dead creatures, but he certainly can't hide the feeling of relief that washes over his face.

He seems to slowly accept the deaths of these animals, slowly straightening his posture out. Relief becomes more prominent in his features. “You’re not a bad shot, Adora Grayskull.”

He should’ve seen the rightful owner to this gun, in his prime. Adam could shoot a man upside-down, blindfolded, and drunk, all while spinning around in a circle. Curiosity takes Adora over, “How was your shooting? In the military?”

At first, all Bow offers is a shrug. “I was okay, I guess,” he says. The answer isn’t confident. He’s too nice to brag, Adora guesses.

“That is such nonsense.” Glimmer confirms it for Adora: too nice to brag. She nudges Bow on his shoulder, looking at him like she’s ready to scold him for lying. Bow doesn’t change his answer, so Glimmer delivers it for him. “If someone could be a certified genius in shooting, it would be Bow. He’s amazing. It’s an art when he does it.”

“We need to check up on the food.”

Strange. Bow walks away, uninterested in finishing this conversation. He becomes someone else, someone more silent and abrasive, almost shoving his way into the storeroom. Adora watches him as he makes himself busy with the potato sack. Not too nice to brag. Too upset.

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Lifting becomes easier as the days pass. First Adora starts with a basket of eggs, taking over this job for the time being, carrying them all around the property. She tries quietly and privately in her room to lift Swift Wind’s saddle, until she feels like she’s going to tear her entire abdomen open and has no choice but to loudly drop it back onto the floor, dust kicking up against the wood. She has to lie down for about twenty minutes afterwards the way her side starts cursing her foolish existence. Someone ought to. Later she tries lifting one of the chairs across from her bed, having the same amount of luck.

One day she helps a young woman when she loses grip on a crate. Either the crate was exceptionally light or Adora really has been getting better. She helps the girl out, young, in her teens. They walk halfway across the entire ranch making the delivery together. Then the girl asks Adora if they can go shoot something and she has to flee before this girl's mom kicks her ass. But she knows for a fact Catra would help this kid indulge in some destruction.

Glimmer assigns her to help with the recent hay shipment, sensing her boredom. Never changed suppliers, from what Adora can tell. Glimmer doesn't seem the type to change for money, anyway. Adora doesn't take the lead, rather lets someone else direct her. All that sitting and laying around, waiting to get better —she needed some mindless manual labor. No more doodles about dead rats and violent teenagers.

It's all so delightfully boring. Go to the carriage. Grab some hay. Take hay to the stables. Say hi to Swift Wind. Turn around. Go to the carriage. Grab some hay. . . . Adora's so stuck in it, she turns her brain off for a second. Ignores the occasional angry input from her side. Right now all she wants to do is focus on this hay and stacking it high, then starting another stack that will grow just as high. Right now she has the blessed option.

Then she notices the men. Waiting at the carriage, her partner in this job staring off. He turns back to Adora, dropping the hay in his hands and becoming nervous. He even jumps off the carriage and starts staring them down. His eyes go to his house. Then the men. Then house again. His hands shake with indecision, his eyes darting all around. He can't make the choice, and instead stands here, frozen as these mystery men walk rather fast onto the land. No horses.

Adora circles the carriage, wanting a better picture. The men aren't law. If they're bounty hunters, it's strange they don't have any horses. Some people around here, those who don't freeze up or curse their lungs out, begin to retreat to their homes. Inside of barns. Some ask where they left their rifle. Adora sees Bow and

Glimmer rush onto the scene, walking right up to the three men. Bow steps in front of Glimmer, protective, and Glimmer pushes him aside. Not good. She's going to lose her temper. The man Adora works with tells her the hay can wait, before finally making his decision and running off. Adora agrees. It can wait. She starts walking. Pulls the red hat on her head over her eyes a little.

"We've already done this with you," she hears Glimmer say. Adora makes herself scarce, hiding behind the chicken coop. The chickens couldn't care less about anything going on right now. "We've got our own mouths to feed."

"Please get off our land," Bow tries next. The men like his kindness even less, one of them spitting to the side about it. "We don't want any trouble, and neither do you."

Footsteps. Slow footsteps. Adora puts her hand on her revolver.

"But then what will keep me from slitting your throats in your sleep, Mister?" one of the men asks. Adora shakes her head. Just had to go there, huh?

She turns the corner, and in an instant changes the conversation with a simple removal of someone's hat. She's far away, but she manages to shoot the accessory off the lead man's head with perfect precision. It's enough to get him to shut up, to back off, and it's everything Adora was hoping for. He goes red in his skinny little face, growing more and more cherry as Adora makes her way over. She's the one walking slowly now, and her weapon isn't even raised. The men have knives mounted on their hips. One has a rifle slung over his shoulder. She decides she's not bothered by him.

This would be another perk of Catra living in a place like this with her: there isn't a soul on this earth who isn't afraid of Catra. Even Hordak wants to spend his last breaths getting rid of her. She would walk up to these three, stare at them until they start running away. Adora can't. The best she can do is channel her

inner Catra. What's the worst that could happen, she gets shot again?

Tucking her gun away. It's her way of showing them she's not afraid of them. She's not convinced she is, in all honesty. She tells them, not smiling or frowning, "I don't sleep too lightly. You can take me on, if you'd like." Then, as Catra would, she grins right in their faces.

No one says anything, other than Glimmer clearly fighting back laughter. Either for the last breaths Adora is about to take or the fact the now hatless man is growing impossibly redder. Bow is eyeing Adora, the same way he longed for the safety of those dead rats.

Rifle leaves shoulder. The man in the back left corner of the trio's perfect triangle. He tries to be fast, tries to be the hero for his buddies, but for a brief second he fumbles with the long gun. In that brief second, Adam's revolver is returning to Adora's hand, rising in the air. In the next second, as the rifle begins to rise to the same height, Adora has to make a decision: begin another slaughter, or scare them.

Her bullet goes right through the man's hand, forcing the rifle from his grasp as he desperately holds his new injury with his uninjured hand, screaming to the heavens. The sun is trying to set peacefully, and Adora finds the blood pouring out of the man's hand and onto the floor. Not far from the discarded hat. She can hear Catra laughing in the back of her mind. Catra. She'll try to psyche them out next.

Tucking the gun away again. This time she really truly has their attention. Man in the right corner looks like he might start sweating. "I grew up a certain way," she tells them all. "We worked. We didn't sit around, except when gathered for dinner. We helped people who needed helping. When we had a problem, we took care of it in a way that wouldn't hurt everyday folk. You know what we needed to do all that? Every single one of us? Two, capable hands."

Adora lets the words sink in, staring specifically at the guy she shot for a minute, and then eyes back on the leader.

It's all words—they had plenty of unconventional members with disabilities who were miles scarier than these losers. Most gangs turned them away. Told them they were weird. Shadow Weaver told them they were welcome.

"We were hungry, too. So hungry. I get it. But one thing we never did, was wander onto some poor family's property and take what little they had." In truth it was the bigger families, but Adora won't share that information yet. Maybe later, once they're all friends and having tea around the campfire. "Do you understand the problem here?"

One of them nods, probably hoping to win some points with her. Maybe he does.

"I can be meaner than any old empty stomach." She takes the gun out again, though she doesn't raise it just yet. "And I can kill twice as fast. Understand?"

Catra was never a fool. Never bit off more than she could chew—certainly would never wander into a protected fort and end up shot and dead in the dirt—and never started a fight she couldn't win. If she couldn't win head-on, she would find another way. It was always Adora's instinct to run in. Figure out the rest later. Adora could never sit for more than ten minutes without getting up and running to do the next thing; she's impatient. Now she stands here, waiting, words leaving her mouth instead of gunpowder leaving her hands. Waiting. She waits and watches as the three men sulk off, not even bothering to collect their gun or their destroyed hat. They walk off, and they don't turn to look back even once.

Adora puts the gun away, before taking off the hat and rubbing the edges with her thumbs.

It isn't until the men are gone, completely out of sight from the property, Bow and Glimmer exhale and begin to celebrate. Adora doesn't stop staring down the road. Doesn't stop rubbing at the brim of the hat. It should feel good to watch them walk away. She should feel good about not slaughtering each of them and walking away. Moving on to the next town would have her. She doesn't. All Adora feels is a crazy amount of anxiety. She actually cares about this town, she considers.

"Adora, that was—"

"They'll be back. Soon." She finally turns to the pair, returning her intact hat onto her head. "I embarrassed them and I doubt they'll take it lightly. I'll stay up a little later and keep watch."

"It's been happening more and more. Especially since my parents died. They *know* I have no idea what I'm doing." Glimmer frowns now, looking back off, down the road.

"I tried, but I'm not enough." Adora remembers the expression on Bow's face. Ex-military shooting superstar can't even protect his own home—that was the reason. "We have people patrolling the property, but sometimes things like this still happen. Last time those three were here, they started shooting at our horses until we gave them something."

That's when Adora smiles, awful timing considering the detail Bow just dropped, feeling her spine straighten out. She points her finger at the both of them, walking a little closer. "I told you I'd find a job needs doing. I can take care of this for you. I'll get your people trained—some self-defense never hurt to know—and I'll start writing up emergency protocols for when something happens. I'll figure out good patrol routes for the numbers we do have."

The pair look at one another, before looking back on Adora. Bow nods his head in satisfaction. Glimmer is full on grinning when she tells her, "I like you very much."

Then Adora is off with a nod, walking rather quickly to her home. Can’t help it. She’ll finally do something worthwhile around here while her side repairs itself. She’ll keep these people safe, far from the state she’s currently in.

Afterwards, when she finally returns to a clean bill of health, she’ll find a way back into that fort.

Chapter End Notes

> Technically Swift Wind's eyes are purple. But y'know. I remembered too late--
>
> We will see Catra again, don't worry. WHEN we will see her again is the real question...
>
> Thank you so much for reading! This story is halfway done on my end and will most certainly see the second installment next month :)

A Peaceful Walk in a Beautiful Place

Chapter Notes

Heeeeyyy welcome to the longest chapter in this story byfar :D

Did I post this a day late? Maybe. Shh

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bright Moon is different. Where the rest of the country has agreed it is summer day and night—albeit nearing the end of the season—Bright Moon has decided to opt out of nighttime warmth. Adora sits outside the fort, tucked away in the tall grass, wondering how she survived both the gunshot and the threat of frostbite. She tucks her jacket closer, watching briefly as the fringe is graced by the easy winds. It should feel nice, and yet. Cloudy tonight; she won't be surprised (or pleased) if rain should grace her, next.

Her hair is what's bothering her secondly. Catra was always the one who wore the hats. Hair tied back, the front of her hair creating a voluminous poof—that was Adora's everyday look. She'd only recently been able to tie her hair up by herself, and only recently she was beginning to notice how much Catra's hat, much like its owner, hates Adora's ponytail. All those times Catra tried to convince Adora to match her look. Let her hair down. She used to claim it was freeing, in a way, to let one's hair loose in the wind on their horse.

Adora remembers the time Catra and the old man got into a drunken knife fight. He took off a good chunk of Catra's hair, and she slashed two deep scars on the outside of his right eye. They formed what looked like two extra eyes on the side of his face. Adora remembers sitting there, helping even out the rest of Catra's hair by cutting it a short length. Catra was *furious.* Of what little they had, at least she'd always have something as simple as her hair. She would not return to a happy mood until she got her

length back. Adora spent those days wondering. What if she was the one who got into the fight with the old man? Had to cut her hair down to Adam's length? Would she like it? Would she hate it? Would she be happy it was different?

But then she could finally say she did something different.

Ultimately, she should be pleased her hair is bothering her and clogging up her thoughts—it means she's getting better. She tied it herself, this morning. Progress. In something, thankfully. Adora's eyes fall back down to the notebook in her lap. Each night she's spent here, she's managed to sketch different angles of the fort. That giant gate being the only entrance, and the stone walls being much too strong to throw dynamite at. Dynamite was more Adam's thing, anyhow.

Leather satchel next to her boots. A gift from Bow, because the gift of his hospitality wasn't enough. These people are so nice, it twists and wretches her gut in fury. They shouldn't be nice to someone like her. Notebook returns to the satchel. It's getting late. She'll return tomorrow to scout again, the time period she knows bandits would be too lazy to hit the ranch at.

Patrol routes are better. Their numbers are small, but Adora made do. Some even seemed excited by the idea of protecting their neighbors. Wait until they come across a real threat. Then Adora will have to start recruiting at an urgent rate. She rides fast on Swift Wind through the night, the horse happy to push himself and stretch his legs. Normally they're out doing things all day. Lately they've been stuck in one place, immobile and lazy.

When they arrive on the property, the main road giving away every detail of the ranch, Adora is greeted by two of her trainees. They immediately ask where she goes every night, why it's so secretive. Usually she ignores them. Tells them to straighten out their stance, correct the way they hold the gun, where to keep their eyes. Tonight she'll humor them: she's looking for an old friend. A dear old friend.

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As the days morph into weeks, Adora's stomach churns with anxiety. She's on a timer, a doomsday clock, and she can feel the bombs warming at her back. Finally she finds she's strong enough to lift and carry Swift Wind's saddle by herself, all the way to the stables without stopping or waving off help. Progress. Not the kind she's aiming for, but she'll take it regardless. Dread begins to fill her bones when she realizes it's been one month she's lived here. Hordak could've killed them all, by now. Catra would've swung by now.

No. There's no way. It can't be.

When her anxiety seems to be spiraling at its peak, dizzying her vision with every clouded step, Bow and Glimmer call on Adora for a new job. Perhaps they've seen her going insane and have finally contracted a physician. They'll probably tell her she just needs a drink and a nap. If only. She arrives at the large house at the end of the main road, passing and waving to her horse on the way over. He's not bothered right now. Someone has learned how much he loves apples and keeps sneaking him them, not that Adora minds. If everyone gathers around to gawk at her horse, maybe she can steal a prime rib from that damn shepherd when no one's looking.

"We're going on a trip!" Glimmer is beaming with the promise of adventure in her eyes, grinning widely. She senses no danger. She cares nothing for the bandits who prowl the area. She's getting out of the ranch for the day and nothing in the world will ruin her spirits. Adora can't argue. The first night she snuck out to stare at that fort for hours into the night, she was vibrating with pent-up energy. This whole laying down and healing thing sucks.

Bow begins to explain, high up on a loaded carriage, the main Bright Moon contacts for trade. Crops out north. Fishery northeast. A long trip. Then he reaches into Adora's mind and says something along the lines of skipping an errand boy and doing these bigger trips themselves just to get out into the world

for a bit. Stretch their legs. Widen their eyes. Staring at the same things every day can really damn a person, Adora knows, even someone as positive and upbeat as Bow.

"But," he says, shifting slightly in his seat, "it's dangerous out there. As you know. Of course you know. Glimmer and I take these two trips on the same day mainly to lessen our chances of being hit, and the danger of leaving our home without leadership."

Glimmer continues for him without missing a beat, as if the two were connected. As if the two had planned the conversation and rehearsed it until this exact moment. "In all honesty, we feel a million times safer taking you with us. And you've been around long enough to meet our friends out there."

"We consider you one of us." Again the two have switched with one another, seamlessly. Adora wonders if this is what marriage between two people is like. Before promptly ignoring the fantasies that arrive with the concept.

First instinct is to refuse. To tell Bow and Glimmer how sweet they are and then make up some excuse about how she's afraid of the north. There's something crazy in that northern air! Must be a government plot! Which of course isn't true. The north is quite beautiful, and Adora has rarely gotten the opportunity to poke around up there. Everything in her life to this point has revolved around the Fright Zone—a better name for the region would be Purgatory. She knows the grass grows differently up north. The sun shines differently. Catra once read to her a book about an adventurer who spent all his life up here, taking in every ounce of air and walking the earth's blessed dirt every day. Catra laughed at the concept, but Adora never stopped thinking about it.

Then Adora is hit with the rotting knowledge of Hordak, hitting the fort dead-on with a full attack force. That was two nights ago. He could be doing anything tonight, tomorrow night, this weekend. Catra could be gone as early as next week. Catra would have never learned what was so great about the north, and the feeling of that possibility makes Adora want to barf all over her

nice boots. She needs the distraction. She's been thinking about Catra for ten years—albeit nothing of this scale—and needs a break. One day of sightseeing and flower picking. One day to forget how bold and desperate Hordak is getting.

She hits them with such a nonchalance she considers dropping everything in her life and entering the theatre field. She'd be great! She'd get to feel the grand feeling of wanting to barf every second of the day! And get paid for it!

Adora looks up at the two, making herself seem cool by placing one of her hands against the side of the carriage as she responds, "Sounds fun."

The trio find fitting everyone onto one seat is difficult. Adora takes the back, sitting on a sturdy barrel. Glimmer feels bad. They invited her and now she's one of the cargo. What Glimmer doesn't know is the amount of times Adora's ridden a carriage with the strapped-down cargo. What neither of them know is the precise ratio of Adora owning the carriage and Adora hiding to steal something from the carriage. The top is uncovered, and the three hold conversation as comfortably as they might if sitting together on a pleasant train ride. Which brings up another interesting ratio Adora can't exact the numbers on.

Cloudy today. Bow and Glimmer talk together about business affairs, leaving Adora's eyes to wander. This morning looked right to rain but now it looks like a small inconvenience. Winds pushing the clouds somewhere south, for some other town to deal with the weather. One or two puffy obstructions give and take the sunlight from time to time, and sometimes the sunlight peers through just to highlight the next wonderful thing for Adora to stare at. They're reaching closer to the goal. Adora stares at fields and fields of endless sunflowers next, wondering how she can send them to Catra. Shadow Weaver always hated flowers—Catra might leave the wilted remains in her private quarters.

Two horses cross in the distance. No, four. Side by side. Their shadows elongate once they pass under the peekaboo sunshine,

nearly reaching the carriage. Four horse figures. Five people. One drags behind one of the last horses, brushing the dirt with his back, his foot tied tightly to one of the horses. Adora's hand flies forward and squeezes Bow's shoulder.

"Stop the carriage." She points before he can say anything, though Bow obediently stops the carriage right when he's told. The horses complain, stomp their feet impatiently. Adora watches the four and their unfortunate buddy, taking their sweet time down the road. Someone tips their head back in what has to be laughter. They're having the time of their lives being the same asshole Adora was, and she's jealous. How come she never had that much fun?

A few minutes pass before Glimmer chimes, "I'm so sick of these guys." Bow nods in agreement.

"They're from the Crimson Waste, right?" Adora asks, and again Bow nods. Glimmer keeps her eyes locked on them, her father's rifle ready at her side. It's a beautiful long gun made of pure silver, styled at the ends of the barrel and the hammer with what Adora has noted to be the family color scheme of purple and pink. She's yet to spot Bow's weapon.

"They're closest to the border west of us. It's a dying and dead town. No lawmen would be stupid enough to go there." Bow shakes his head at the thought of the place. "I try my best to believe in people. It's what both my fathers taught me. But those people? I have no faith in them; that place is lost."

Glimmer is the one nodding in agreement now, eyes trailing each and every one of the men. Having fun. Laughing to each other, best buddies for life, as a man screams desperately for his life behind them. They're likely making fun of him. Adora doubts they'd be talking about anything else.

There was a time, years ago, when Shadow Weaver was considering packing everyone up and moving out there. A lawless land for a lawless family. Her perfect little family, curated with her

morals. Ultimately her family failed her tests, and she deemed all of them unfit to survive. Weak, she called the gang, and for days and days afterwards everyone spent every second trying to change her mind. Everyone but the other Grayskull twin. Adam was thankful. Adam was never a fool. He convinced Adora with enough horror stories, and soon enough Catra. Everyone else fell in line naturally, and they returned to their normal lives terrorizing normal people with abnormally large purses instead.

Then Catra and Adora took that trip up to the mountains, and Adora never wanted to go anywhere ever again.

"Do your friends have adequate security, too?" Adora asks. The men have passed the main road largely enough for her to finally remove her hand from Bow's massive shoulder, deeming everything green again. The carriage proceeds smoothly despite the nerves from its passengers.

Glimmer answers first while Bow ponders the question further. "They mostly manage. The fishery never really sees any action, they say. Our first stop? They see some visitors from time to time."

Bow seems to agree, relaxing his straining brow. Suddenly, Adora finds herself occupied for the rest of this trip: she'll do some review, once they arrive. Some teaching too, if necessary.

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Once upon a time there was a series of books Catra read of the fantasy genre, every single one of them containing characters who frequented a magical forest. They met the oldest wizard in the lands here, trained here, learned to slay all the dragons and save all the lives, right here in the trees and the meadows. Adora recalls the author describing the meadow. It stretched west to east, starting at one end of the world and stopping at the other. It was the prologue for the mess of trees, and it was more than any old normal prairie Adora knew. Multicolored flowers, reds weaving into yellows into orange and green, twisting together to make an

art piece mother nature would remain unmatched in. She imagined bright pink, vibrant skies where the sun would never hide and storms wouldn't bother to visit.

Adora sees Perfuma's extensive property and wonders if the author simply spent a weekend at this ranch. From the rear of the carriage, standing now, Adora gets a perfect view of red flowers, red as Catra's hat, lining the roads leading into the property. Behind them, spreading east and west, no different from the fantasy tale, a long line of sunflowers. Then green, as far as the eye can see. Even the beaten path is a gift from Heaven, smooth and yielding nothing remotely within the consideration of a bump. Adora could fall asleep standing up right now, and she might hold herself upright with heavenly grace.

Fences are painted bright blue to match a clear day's sky, warm and welcoming on the border of produce and traveler. The farther they advance, the more Adora sees tall, thin trees. Some of which have been turned into homes, branches stacked horizontally across standing wood to make a roof. Must not get cold much in this region. Catra read about houses like these, designed to catch light winds and keep the occupants warm, safe from the piping hot heat. Odd weather, given how they've spent quite some time traveling north today. She doesn't see so much as a patch of fur, save for the trimmed dogs who vacate some areas of the land.

At the end of the road waits a giant tree, massive in both width and height. One or two circles are carved straight through the front portion, serving as windows, and a crudely made door sits somewhat in the front, mostly to the left side. Bow brings the carriage around and parks it right here. He grins at Adora, gesturing around all the homes and the monster tree with his left hand. "Adora, welcome to Serenity Ranch, the biggest farm in Plumeria."

No response just now; she's too busy taking it all in.

More fantasy appears just then: a slender woman, tall, long flowing hair, exits the crooked tree door. She's a fairy before them,

complete with flowers weaved into her long blonde hair. A paper-thin red dress hangs from her paper-thin frame, gracing the grass below her feet as she makes her way over to the three of them. A bright smile occupies her freckled face, right before she practically sprints over to Bow and Glimmer and swallows them in a giant hug. Both Adora's allies are wrapped around the woman's arms when her eyes fall on Adora, who has to push and climb her way to freedom from her makeshift seat in the carriage. Hopping over the last crate, Adora lands without grace in the dirt below, nearly losing Catra's hat. Her hand flies upwards to catch faster than she knew her hand could move.

Quickly, the fairy woman travels over to meet Adora, apparently fascinated with her. Glimmer gives the short introduction. The family friendly version. Adora's new to the ranch. Helping out. Good with a gun. Nothing about finding Adora dead on the side of the road outside the fort everyone knows to avoid, the same fort she visits every night in the hopes of peacefully running away with her childhood love forever and ever . . .

Behind Adora, the locals get to work. Some bring over agreed-upon goods to trade, while Bow directs the ones they should take off the carriage. In front of Adora, Glimmer is formally introducing the owner of the land, Perfuma. Perfuma, who continues to smile warmly at Adora. There's a calming energy about her, something so powerful Adora considers if she stays here for a month she might see all her problems solved forever and ever.

Perfuma starts introducing the crops they have here on the land, walking both Adora and Glimmer back to the main road for a better physical overview. Corn fields. Apple trees. Grapevines. Potatoes. Nuts. There's a wide spread of variety, and every time Perfuma mentions the crops she has to add how blessed everyone here is to be on this land, because this land is a gift from nature herself. Those who live here incorporate a lot of the produce into their daily lives, and although it's extremely convenient it can become extremely dull. Adora wants to make a joke about Swift Wind eating apples religiously until the day he dies, but her eyes

get caught on a group of little kids, playing and laughing and yelling as they run through the fields.

"I love animals." Adora can hear Perfuma somewhere in the back of her mind. "I find them charming; they're beautiful and graceful and we as humans can learn a lot from them. Animals are nature's way of guiding us, I think. Showing us how to survive. It's why I could never be in the livestock business. I think it would break my heart!"

"There's a reason I'm not around on slaughter days," Glimmer tells her. "And speaking of slaughter—" Glimmer places one of her hands on Adora's shoulder, effectively breaking her from the trance she's lost herself in, the kids freeing themselves from her eyes and going about their lives— "I need a small favor for this one here."

Glimmer eyes Adora in a knowing way, but Adora isn't quite sure what it is she's meant to know in this moment. All she can really do is watch as Glimmer's shoulders slump in disappointment, before she continues.

"She's extremely stubborn and refuses to sit around and heal. She thinks she's tough, but she's been holding her side all day. Gunshot wound. Got anything?"

Funny. Adora didn't realize she was walking around doing that this whole time. Even now she looks down and finds her hand there, finding itself at home without command or concern otherwise. Then she glares at Glimmer, who shines a wonderful smile her way, her best way of telling Adora she's an idiot. Not the first time she's seen something like it.

Right away Perfuma falls into a ball of concern, once again walking and then sprinting at full speed back into her house. Perfuma is an herbalist on the side. Glimmer says something along the lines of Perfuma making magic potions and Adora has to consider whether or not she actually did die and end up in Catra's fiction book.

“You’re not a superhero,” Glimmer says. She walks Adora back towards the carriage, scurrying bodies moving cargo back and forth, a perfect puzzle in the small space. “You need rest, too. If you don’t start taking it easy, you can’t show me any of your super cool moves!”

Adora laughs. The pair stand around, entertained by the chaos around them. Bow and Perfuma’s coordinator are both so calm, listing off all sorts of numbers and items at breakneck speeds. Adora isn’t quite sure how they comprehend one another, but they’re managing perfectly fine. It’s impressive. Perfuma appears from her picture book tree, the same cheery expression on her face as she speeds over with a concoction trapped in a small jar. The paste inside appears creamy in color, soft like a lotion. The jar itself tinted almost orange, a thick glass and a metal cover with thin braided rope hanging from the side. Perfuma hands it over, and Adora takes extra care not to shatter the object. Tucking it away in the satchel given to her by Bow.

“It’s my parents’ remedy,” Perfuma tells her. She’s proud of that fact, and the fact she’s managed the skills to replicate the same product. “They taught me everything, before they passed away. Bandits, you see. From the Crimson Waste. Cruel, awful people. My parents tried to take them on themselves, but ultimately they were unable to.”

Adora almost drops the jar. Security patrols—these people need it, too. Her spine straightens enough for her to ask the question, and Perfuma barely has anything of a response. She’s fighting hard to keep the positivity in her expression—exactly the way Bow might do—but it’s starting to fail more and more by the second. Every day Adora is happy she never ended up with the Crimson Waste crowd. She feels guilty enough having hit places like Perfuma’s ranch. She can’t imagine how different things would’ve been operating out of a place like that, dragging everyday people by their feet in the dirt and laughing about it.

“That’s something I’ve been helping Bright Moon with.” Immediately Perfuma’s energy chances. Bow already mentioned

Adora being a good gun. Bow being the most trustworthy person on this planet or any other. "Show me around, I can help you, too." She doesn't miss Glimmer's satisfied smile, a gloating expression that happily tells the world *Yep! That's our dead body we brought back to life!*

It eats up the rest of the morning, throwing the schedule slightly off, but every minute spent is worth it. Adora finds commanding and coordinating with Perfuma's people to be the easiest job in the world. No arguments when she talks. No sarcastic answers when she asks a question, no matter how simple. Most of all, no one's trying to outdo anyone else. They're all equals here. They're all a team, a proper equal team, and it drives Adora's brain crazy with wonder. If the gang she grew up with were even slightly different. Slightly worse, slightly better. Would everything still end with her in this place, desperate for a distraction and desperate to get back into that fort?

On the way out Adora finds she's a celebrity. Unless everyone is waving sarcastically at her, in which case she'll grab those reins herself, red-faced, and ride out of here, never to be seen again. Lying in bed for hours into the night, wondering what they're saying about her behind her back. She nearly misses Perfuma's final conversation with Glimmer for the day.

"I just made this new contact. She's a woman named Lynda, sort of out of the way west. She's really kind! I recommend talking with her."

The name throws Adora for a spin. Lynda. She knew a Lynda once, long ago. She doesn't ask. Just gets back onto the carriage, riding off to the next contact.

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Adora can't remember the last time she saw the ocean, or was anywhere near one for that fact. She can recall the lake the gang used to live by, the lake Adam spent all day fishing on and Catra spent all day hissing and cursing about. Adora imagines her here

now. She'd probably jump off the carriage and tell them she'll be waiting in the woods for their return.

From Adora's memory, the lake was different from the view in front of her. Enclosed land, almost mocking a giant swimming pool. The lake was run-off from a river, and the waterfall created as a result was both a perfect natural shower and the perfect spot for the younger members (save for Catra) to play around in. Rogelio was the angriest one when they had to move on—he practically lived in that fall. Catra was the first one to pack.

Salineas is the territory of the hour. They should make it back to Bright Moon by the end of the afternoon, if they push the horses. Adora isn't crazy about them staying out after dark, certainly not with so much cargo. It makes everything about their current stop harder: she finds she desires to stay here for hours. Waves push in from miles out, licking the sand before retreating. Children scream and run on the shores, imprinting their little feet onto the moist earth. Adora stares. Stares and wonders . . .

Vibrant, bright green grass soon morphs into beige sand. If they stray too far from the hard beaten path, the horses will have to strain themselves through the mush. Bow is aware of this and remains hyper-focused on the road, meanwhile Glimmer takes a few deep breaths of air and enjoys the wonder around them. She asks if Adora's ever been out here before, and Adora can't recall. She mentions the lake and nothing else.

Huts and shacks are scattered along the shore, none of them equipped with doors. Two or three windows, and a giant cut-out of where a door should be. The closest thing is a few surfboards laying around. Adora looks a little further around and finds rowboats large and small, tied down. Some at a formal pier, and others at a simple wooden pole on the beach. Bow takes them far down the road, closer to the pier, to a hut looking just as average as the rest. No giant tree, like Perfuma. This next merchant isn't too flashy, and Adora doesn't really blame them. She wouldn't bother, if she lived in such a relaxing place, the sun beating down on her all day with warmth and welcome.

Glimmer's boots go flying before she jumps off her seat, landing with her bare toes in the sand. She giggles to herself about it and Bow watches, smiling on her. She tells him to do the same, and when Bow reminds her he hates the sensation she calls him a dork and heads for the door, kicking sand in the air as she goes. Adora almost yanks off her boots and tries it, too.

No door, so Adora watches Glimmer knock on the doorframe and call for someone. Mermista. Adora turns the corner, getting a better view of the land owner's personal quarters. Small, cozy. Two or three surfboards strung up, as well as fish bones as decoration, such as what Adora guesses is a shark tooth necklace hanging from the wall. Most impressive of them all: a silver trident hanging over Mermista's head.

Mermista sits inside, lounging on the most comfortable looking bed Adora has ever seen, reading a book. There's piles and piles of them stacked about. She's reading a book about a frontiersman Catra once read. Just like Catra, she looks bored to death by it.

"Okay," Mermista says, not bothering to look up from the page, "I'm going to need you both to verify the authenticity of this book." She closes the hardback, the sound echoing briefly throughout the space. "Because this is boring. Like, *violently* boring."

Yep. That's exactly what Catra said.

Behind them, Bow begins unpacking crates, some of which are filled with leathers, and Adora runs out to help. Glimmer and Mermista talk business. The ocean has been extremely giving, Mermista claims. She's going to throw in free catch today, and Glimmer doesn't know what to say. Mermista even whips them up something to eat while they're here, ready by the time all the crates are unloaded. She says someone will be over with her catch to load up.

Overall, Mermista seems to be more laid back than Perfuma. Adora wonders how she can't be, walking around all day in

gorgeous temperatures. She wears a thin tank top and shorts, both tight to her frame. She's been out swimming today, or plans to be. Though the way her loose hair tangles to itself, Adora guesses she's already been. Then came back inside to read a book. What a perfect life. Adam would've loved this place.

"Mermista is a one-woman show, you know," Glimmer says. They're all sitting around a small table, freshly steamed salmon looking back at them. Adora fears she's going to eat not only the fish, but the entire plate itself.

Mermista rolls her eyes. Leaning back in her chair with the same consistent mellow energy Adora wishes to achieve. "That's not true. I have people helping me."

"But you should still be proud!" Bow now. He takes a huge bite out of his salmon and the sight of it makes Adora's mouth water. Brittly the soft meat breaks apart in Bow's teeth, pink flashing from the inside. "Mermista managed to figure out a way to automate most of her trapping nets. All she does is check them periodically. It's amazing!"

"Less work, more money than my parents." Mermista actually looks proud of herself, despite the expression on her face trying to fight it. Adora wonders where the hell everyone's parents are going around here. "It gives me more time to read. Relax. I can really check up on the people around here and see what they need—that's nice, too."

Bow explains some of the other duties around here, including deep sea fishing. The bigger catches Mermista freely gives credit to other peoples' efforts for. Namely her delivery people. She says nothing about patrols on the property, immediately intriguing Adora.

"How many Crimson Waste bandits do you see around here?" she asks. Mermista shrugs. Not caring anything for the worst people Adora's ever interacted with. And she's interacted with a lot of bad, horrible people.

“We don’t see them much out here. We’re on the coast, far away from the desert.” Then Mermista goes completely blank, followed by the longest sigh Adora has ever heard. “There’s only one real danger around here.”

Mermista gets up from the table, poking her attention out the windows. One way north, the next south. Then she steps completely out the doorway, looking all around again just to be sure. Then she returns to the table, thinking nothing of the inspection.

“I have a . . . friend.” Glimmer laughs when Mermista says the word, and Mermista groans before continuing. “My *friend* is paranoid about those Crimson Waste bandits, even though you have to travel far away from here back onto the main road to even see them. I banned him from sailing. Not because he’s a bad sailor. He’s a great sailor. But now he runs around and acts like he’s the law around here. He’s started at least eight fires in the past month. If you want to talk to him, you’ll be a miracle worker. But good luck, seriously.”

That’s when Adora finds herself across the beach, abandoning her boots once they fill up with sand, staring at the back of a mustached man’s head as he rifles through a bush looking for “spies”. Spies. Maybe she should turn around.

Too late. The man jumps right up to his feet when he notices her presence, threatening her with a stick he’s pulled from said bush. Adora tugs back her jacket, calmly showing him her gun. He sobers up quickly.

“Hello stranger I’ve never seen before—have I seen you before? No? Hello!” He tosses the tiny stick aside, slapping it against a pile of sand that immediately engulfs portions of it. “I am Sea Hawk! The last line of defense against the putrid creatures of—”

“Adora. Mermista said you need my help.” Adora crosses her arms, eyeing him. “And that you have a problem with fire.”

“A problem? No, no.” He straightens out, pulling a full torch from absolutely nowhere. “The real problem here is the night air. Do you know what happens at night, stranger?”

“Adora. And anything. Literally anything can happen at night—”

“It gets pitch black! Oh, it’s the perfect opportunity to strike.” He kicks the sand for emphasis, a handful of grain flying from the end of his pointed leather boot. Adora has tied hers together and strung them over her shoulder at this point, and with every few steps sand pours from the accessory. “You see, these folks from the Crimson Waste? They’re after only one real treasure. Do you know what that is?”

“Gold? I hope?”

“Correct!” He yells so loud Adora jumps slightly. “Gold, unexplored and untouched by man—oh it’s littered all over these waters! Don’t tell Mermista that, she’ll disagree—have you met Mermista? Oh, isn’t she lovely? Many moons ago I—”

“Crimson Waste natives are allergic to gold.” Hey, she’s got to try something. Something that in fact does not work.

“They can send their brethren who have emigrated to the Wastes! Don’t feel bad, it’s a classic rookie mistake.”

Adora is way too determined to win against this guy. No way is she returning to Mermista and getting laughed at. She has one more tactic in her brain, and after this one she’s willing to subject this guy to shock therapy. “Yeah, well, you know what they say about fire, Sea Hawk?”

His face goes completely blank given the tone Adora’s supplied, and even his bushy mustache seems to be pointing downwards. Sea Hawk is an exceptionally thin man, running a bony hand through his short hair. Adora’s also now realizing he’s dressed in a way that makes him look like a cartoon pirate. “No,” he asks, hushed, “what do they say?”

Adora motions him inward, and he quickly closes the gap. She leans in a little closer, leaving little room for spies or other intruders to hear. She looks him dead in the eye, silently questioning if he's ready, and Sea Hawk stares back with curious impatience. "It attracts bandits."

He practically screams for ten minutes, tearing down all of the torches set across this part of the beach, before sprinting back and desperately asking Adora what to do. She gives him new patrol routes as quickly as possible, before retreating for her own sanity. For Sea Hawk's own sanity, he starts sprinting off into the sand, mumbling desperately.

Adora laughs the entire walk to Mermista, who is regarding her with massive interest. As Bow tightens down their freshly loaded cargo, Mermista tells Adora she's impressed. Adora is in fact, a miracle worker. Then she says they'll see how long the new programming in Sea Hawk's head works for before the beach is set ablaze again.

They're on their way out when Mermista catches Glimmer's attention again. "Don't forget to visit the ice queen," she says. "You guys barely survived last winter, and I have a bad feeling about this year."

Silently, Adora curses. It's going to get colder around here? Can't she stay on the beach forever?

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Winter manages to find Adora unfairly early, and she's ready to point Adam's revolver around like a madwoman and demand they turn to carriage towards the beach. Bow throws on a simple jacket over his short-cropped shirt, and it makes Adora seethe with jealousy. Perhaps if she took Catra up this far north both Hordak and Shadow Weaver wouldn't bother with them.

Adora sees the fort in the distance and wonders if Catra is even ready for winter. She was never great in the cold, less so than

Adora.

Drop-off at the ranch. Then Bow and Glimmer hop into another, smaller carriage, one big enough to fit Adora and a small crate, riding quickly north. Lost a lot of time today. After spotting the fort Adora focuses her eyes on the carriage. Splintering wood. It's old, probably been on the ranch for years now. Probably seen more winters than most people around here. The shade of the wood matches the shade of leather Adora had on her old pair of spurs. Never bought a new pair post-prison. The sound used to annoy Catra, between both Adora and Adam's boots singing a silent tune with every step. One time Adam started jumping up and down just to tick her off.

White trees peek in through Adora's peripherals. Already, it's snowing up north, despite the season barely moving into autumn. They're somewhere long past Perfuma's ranch, Adora overhears, and Glimmer questions why they didn't come here early in the morning. Bow says the carriage was already packed. Besides—the weather is just as bad in the morning as it is late afternoon. Glimmer pulls her coat tighter to her frame, though it doesn't seem to be doing the job she wants. Adora can relate.

Adora hears something and pivots, gripping Bow's shoulder rather roughly. "Something's in the road."

He pulls them to a stop, falling dead silent. Glimmer doesn't hesitate in reaching for her father's rifle now, the silver fogging up in the cold air. Glimmer didn't reach when they saw bandits; something is here. This is a dangerous road, dangerous enough to send paranoia into these regular travelers, and it heightens Adora's senses as she places her hand onto the revolver resting at her hip. Her eyes, which she's certain have to be fogging up the same way as the shiny silver, scan the road with every ounce of precision she has in her person. That's when the trees rustle, her gun enters her grip, and a man comes sprinting from the woods onto the main road.

Behind him, the biggest, angriest bear Adora has ever seen. Glimmer's beautiful rifle fires a shot, freeing the man from the bear's wrath. He runs down the road as the bear turns its attention over to the purple and pink finished rifle, a crop top man and his bow and arrow, and a tough-looking girl with a revolver who is terrified out of her mind. Adora hops out of the carriage, running somewhere off to the side and shooting at the bear again. She should've brought her rifle.

Bear charges, barely missing the very tip of Adora's toes as she dives out of the way. Snow cakes itself to her chest and jeans. She's entering the woods now, leaving the free road, and it's everything she doesn't want. Too crowded in there. Not much room to dodge this beast. She's not a fast climber like Catra; she'll face this monster dead-on. Bow and Glimmer aid her in the background, but Adora doesn't want them to have to deal with this. This is the whole purpose of her even traveling with them today. She dodges the bear, watching it bump into a tree. Then she turns, pointing herself back towards the main road. The guy originally running from the creature is long, long gone.

An arrow flies into the bear's neck from the vicinity of the carriage. Followed by several rifle shots coupled with tons and tons of cursing. Adora wishes she had something more effective. Like dynamite!

Thick strains of spit can be seen between the bear's teeth as it snarls at them, swiping its large paws when Adora gets too close. She throws herself backwards, leaving her defense exposed as she scrambles to her feet. Hate is in the animal's eyes as it approaches, before suffering more shots from Glimmer. Glimmer charges forward, allowing Adora enough time to get back on her feet, shooting and shooting until the mountain of brown fluff falls backwards, defeated.

Before anyone can cheer or wonder how they've managed to live today, a small voice next to the carriage yells: "That was AWESOME!"

Adora finds she's accidentally turned her gun onto what looks to be a teenager, though the teenager isn't bothered in the slightest by the gesture. In fact, the teenager isn't even giving her the time of day. The kid is all wrapped up in a huge fur coat, safe from the icy road and the nipping winds, and she's cheering on Glimmer now. Gun lowers. Glimmer approaches the kid with a familiarity, calling her name before asking what she's doing all the way out here.

"I heard you were coming today!" The kid, Frosta, pulls her hood down, beaming up at Glimmer with bright eyes. Glimmer is unimpressed.

"We didn't tell anyone we were coming today." She stares down on Frosta, who never loses her spirit. Glimmer starts the interrogation, pointing her in the direction of the carriage. Asking the kid if she was out hunting without her parents again.

"I was bird watching," Frosta clearly lies, hopping in the back of the carriage. Adora watches her closely. Makes sure the way she's leaning over the edge doesn't lead to her falling completely out of the transport. Glimmer tries to lecture her on the dangerous wilds, but Frosta goes off on a tangent about how cool Glimmer's kill was—oh it was so awesome! She's a storybook hero!

Adora glances over to Bow as he climbs aboard. "I handled three guys alone with a gut shot wound. Where's my fan club?" She remains leaning over the seat the way Frosta is, keeping conversation between them. Frosta's too busy telling Glimmer how great she is to hear, and Glimmer's too busy trying to lecture the teen to notice anything else as Bow eases them down the road.

"Her family was close to Micah, Glimmer's dad." Bow gives the full details, and Adora leans ever closer over the seat. "Frosta's always thought Glimmer was cool. Glimmer thinks it's the hair. She's a lonely kid out here. Always getting into trouble. She's *just* like Glimmer, but Glimmer doesn't see it."

Adora observes the pair in their lively conversation. Eventually Glimmer completely gives up on the lecture, giving in to Frosta's clear distraction, the child's short bobbed hair flying all around as she uses wild gestures telling Glimmer about a kill her dad made earlier this week. Glimmer is engaged. Impressed, even, when Frosta tells her she helped out. Glimmer calls her a monster hunter and Frosta's ego easily grows twice in size.

It doesn't change throughout the course of the ride, snow crunching beneath horse's hooves and frozen trees shaking, begging for a small ounce of heat. The scenery never changes much, to the point Adora questions if these trees are all the same and they're all stuck in a loop. Then Frosta starts guiding Bow, despite what Adora assumes are regular trips here. Frosta goes back and forth between her stories and why the paths Bow is taking are wrong.

A kid talking a person's ears off. Adora hasn't been around that feeling in ten years. She wonders how that kid is now. If the child is okay. How old they are now. If they even remember Adora after all these years.

Her mind wanders for so long, Adora doesn't realize they're at their destination until Frosta jumps right out of the carriage, over the small rails on the sides. She has a heart attack before seeing they've stopped at a small trading post. Bow says the rest of the town lives inside the mountains a few miles ahead. Trading post makes lives easier in terms of navigation. There's one guy standing around, huddled by a fire burning inside a small hut. He's bored, energetic when he realizes people are here to interact with him. Hopping off his butt on the ground and practically racing for the little window to greet them.

Adora beats Bow to the single crate in the back, leaving Bow to beat her out for the mountain of furs that soon engulf his person. Blankets, jackets, anything that will get them all through the winter. Adora considers laying underneath one of the piles on the ride back to the ranch. She packs the piles in a way that creates a

nest in the carriage, her next consideration going to the concept of taking a huge nap all the way back to Bright Moon ranch.

Something tugs at Adora's jacket when she stands by Bow's side, watching him as he finalizes the trade with the man. Crop top. Not shaking. Not shaking one bit. His abs aren't even flexed, and it's driving Adora crazy. She's wearing her undershirt, long sleeve shirt, and a jacket! He has a crop top and a flimsy jacket made of paper!

Tugging again. Adora finally looks over her shoulder, turning when she finds Frosta staring up at her. The teen is quite serious, in such a way Adora finds herself nervous. Looking over at Glimmer to silently ask what she's done wrong. Glimmer just winks and something about it makes Adora even more nervous.

"Glimmer told me what you did at the ranch with those guys. I think that's very cool." Adora feels like doing a backflip.

With effort Adora tries smiling down on Frosta, and maybe she does end up forming some sort of grin, but all she can see is the familiar face of a child she once knew. Every ounce of that child, right here in Frosta's eyes. Her heart beats with ache, threatening to shatter itself against her ribs.

The words are difficult to manage. "You're a really interesting kid." Adora places her hand on Frosta's shoulder, not thinking of the child's potential reaction. Luckily Frosta doesn't reject her. "Never change."

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She'd examined his face, the only face in the world so identical to hers, a perfect mirror image save for the stubble on her brother's chin. It was frustrating her, the expression he was making. One-handed he trotted his horse along through the small town they'd decided to supply in this day, a moderately sized steed not too big and not too small. Meanwhile Adora always managed to tame the giants, the biggest horses she could find. The animal was a

chocolate brown, shiny dark hair and light brown eyes. Gorgeous horse. Adam loved taking his trusted companion around, almost as much as he loved those expensive revolvers he was always cleaning obsessively.

Finally he looked up at Adora, who was grateful they were both going so slow through town the way neither of them were paying the road any attention. Adam caught himself in his bad habit of biting his cheek, shifting his jaw around. His sister waited impatiently in the middle of the road, staring at him. "I'm not going on that job," he finally told her. "It *is* a great idea. You're absolutely right. But it's not the kind of job we should be doing."

"We are both down to our last dollar." Adora balled her fist up in that moment, tight against her horse's reins. Sometimes Adam was too much for her to handle. She made sure to remind him with great conviction, "We are not and have never been in a place to bargain. Money is money, and we need it."

They'd reached the gun store now, the primary reason for the stop in one of the smallest towns Adora'd ever seen in her life. Neither sibling bothered to dismount or even approach the hitching posts just yet. They remained in the middle of the road, staring one another down. Adora with the temper she would spend years trying to lessen, Adam with the temper he never seemed to carry. He eyeballed her calmly, apparently taking amusement in the steam coming off his sister's head, out through her ears and spreading across the street like a virus.

"Adora," he began to ask, in a grounded tone that was already driving her crazy, "what's the most important thing in your life?"

"You, obviously." Aggressive tone to combat his. Adam is unmoved. All he really did was motion her onwards, and all Adora can do is roll her eyes at him. "Catra. Food. Not starving."

"The people around us are everything." He flashed her a grin, one that made her want to reach over and slap his face. Adam took the hat made of soft brown leather off his head momentarily,

running a hand through his sweaty hair. The strands were long, greasy. Of all Adam's philosophies, the one he preached the most was hygiene; he was probably going insane right now. Hat in hand, he gestured to his sister, repeating, "Everything. Everyone we pass by, everyone we meet—they all have people around them. Everyone is struggling. Maybe not with the law, like us, but they struggle. If we go around, robbing small, remote farms, where does that put us? They don't have anything, Adora. The same way we don't. Let those big city people be their thieves, not us."

Adora stared at him, annoyed. Annoyed at the prospect of losing an easy hit, but mostly annoyed with the feeling of being morally upstaged by her brother. Again.

"We want the big guys," Adam said again, "the ones who can recover. Leave the little man alone."

He moved his horse, chocolate and not too big, not too small, to the hitching post. Adora followed, if reluctantly. Thinking of the best way to insult him; there was no way she was letting him walk away from this round without something.

"I see you've been hanging out with the old man," she said. Adora dismounted her horse first, one elbow bumping past the rifle she mounted steadily onto the beast. Adam double checked the revolvers decorating his hips before lowering himself to the ground as well. Both siblings round their animals, meeting somewhere in the middle. "I never thought you so wise, Father."

"Very funny. Oh, you're so funny. I'm dying." The effort he made into keeping a plain, dead expression was perhaps the most effort of his life. At least, Adora thought so. "Some things he says have truth, you know. He's always cursing the First Ones for settling this country and leaving it to become so heartless. It's the one good bit of wisdom he has, Adora: be kind."

Adora crossed her arms, leaning her back against a sturdy wooden post holding this old building together. It was no bigger

than a shack, probably with one or two boxes of merchandise inside. She can't possibly imagine anything beyond that. "Is that secondary to walking around looking homeless?" Adora tapped her fingers against her chin, grinning. "Nice beard there. Really makes you look like a bandit."

It was every joy in the world to watch her twin fall into a swan dive of panic, one with no grace and no swans as he cursed and flailed his arms about reaching for the pocket mirror in his coat. He was mad in the face and red in the cheeks when he saw the stubble he'd allowed, decorating his perfectly plain face. Two fingers caressed the spot, circling the chin before feeling around the cheeks. Adora never understood him. His hair was long and messy, always flapping around in the wind, but he had to keep his face perfectly clean. He was such a weirdo.

"Oh man, are you kidding?" The mirror flew back into his pocket in a hurry, Adam looking at his sister with a crazy expression. "We need to find a hotel or something. I do look homeless! My hair—"

"You'll go to the gun store, and then I will throw you in a lake. I promised Catra I would go hunting with her today. If I'm late I'll make sure she kills you first."

Suddenly, Adam straightened himself out. A wild grin grew across his lips, one that told Adora she'd be stealing his precious guns today and running down the streets with them. "Wedding day haul? Will I finally be getting a sister who isn't so lame in the head?"

"I'm going to shave your head." Hurriedly, Adam abandoned the scene and rushed into the shop, one hand tightly gripping his hat. His horse appeared to laugh at him, snorting before the door could creak shut.

In the corner of her eye, Adora noticed them. Two men, sitting on a small bench just outside the door to the neighboring shop. Neither looked friendly. Adora reminded herself where her gun was in that moment, trying not to stare them down in response.

Outnumbered. Both men were staring her down in a hateful fashion, and Adora spent a quick second trying to clock any weapons on their person. No alcohol, she noticed. One of the men, the one sitting further away, had a revolver on his hip. Older. The metal is fading into rusted patterns that managed to look quite artful.

Nodding once at them, Adora tested the waters. “Good morning, fellas.”

“Stay out of trouble.” She hadn’t planned on a response. Maybe a growl or the sound of spitting. She nodded again, turning away. Debating whether or not to get back on her horse. She thought about joining Adam inside, but she wasn’t about to leave her rifle here. Reaching for her rifle wouldn’t look too friendly, either, and it’s everything she didn’t want. So outside she remained, observing. Thinking.

It could mean one of two things: this town doesn’t like outsiders. They could make their purchases and ride off without another thought. Or, the cattle rustling Grayskull twins have been made and need to leave here as fast as possible. Adam liked his guns—didn’t mean he was ever in a rush to use them.

Further down the street Adora’s eyes trailed. Often she’d found other pairs of eyes already looking at her, quickly pivoting her attention somewhere else. A lot of these people were armed. What she assumed to be a bounty board was posted outside across the street, hanging on the side of the grocer’s that began the left side of the street. Couldn’t make out what the contents were, though she had a few giant hunches. A woman stood outside, helping her husband pack up her family’s carriage, and she stared at Adora with squinting eyes. Studying her, scanning her. The Grayskull twins had been made, and Adora grew more and more aware of her rifle by the second. Fear kept her frozen on the porch, unsure if Adam should’ve been included in this equation. Sheriff’s office was down the street. Still time to run. Adora hoped all Adam needed was ammo. Otherwise they’ll both be fitted for graves later today.

Adam took one step out of the store, and Adora grabbed him with all the strength, speed, and panic coursing through her system. Two boxes of ammo went flying out of his hand, into the street by his horse's leg. He gets no chance to call Adora crazy, before recognizing the way her hands were shaking. Quickly, he ran out into the road. Changing his tone instantly to the danger around them. Both twins and both their sets of eyes hadn't managed to clock the civilian walking past the horse when the suspected criminal practically dove into the road, scaring them.

Adam scared the young passerby, and the two men jumped to their feet. Adam apologizes to the young woman. The men take a step and yell something about professional swindlers. Adora jumps off the porch and runs for her rifle.

Too late. Adora was one step in before one of the men, the closest to her, is shoving her out of the way. Adam's hands are barely on his revolvers before the second man shoots him in the back, just below his neck.

Rifle is forgotten. Adora hears the opposing gun drop, saw hands shaking in her peripheral vision before all of it left her focus. A voice behind her told her and Adam the rest of the devils she associated with will meet their end. She'd turned to threaten them, and the simple motion she made was enough to scare them away. All of them. All of them, cowards. Adora heard the rush of feet. Two or three pairs. The sheriff's office. She forced Adam on his feet, and one of her hands had turned red as she pushed him upright against her horse. She grabbed the reins, jumping onto the saddle and pulling Adam to sit behind her with all the strength in her body. They managed to ride off in a flash, forgetting his horse to the post. She could buy him a new one later.

Adora hit the camp in a frenzy, nearly rushing three people on the way in. All of which cursed at her, unaware of the trouble she was bringing them. Even Catra approached her, ready to joke about being late for their trip today. None of it seemed real. Nothing. One minute they were at the gun store, the next minute Adora was at the camp again. It was all a dream. She'd wake the next

morning and laugh about it. Then she and her brother would head out, scouting which places to hit for the day. It was all fake. It was all a funny joke.

When Adora saw the expression on Catra's face shift, so quickly, so suddenly, she finally allowed herself to lose her cool, in a way Adam would never, dropping everything strong within herself and falling to her knees in the grass. Luckily the people around her are healthy enough to take care of Adam.

Unfortunately, as Adora learned in the seconds to follow, there was no Adam left to save. The first thing Adora felt was nothing. Then she swatted Catra's hand away from her person, the single time in her life she would ever do so before longing for years to feel said hand again. Next she felt herself hovering over her brother's corpse, too weak and miserable and pathetic to form real words.

The sun was down and firelight was bright in her eyes, shimmering off the bottles piling up around her. Someone told Adora to pack it up for the night—Lonnie, she thought—and her fist went flying for the person who would dare speak to her. Arguments. More violence. Catra had rushed onto the scene and calmed everything down with her own authority, sending Adora away to walk it off.

Adora walked. For miles and miles. She walked and walked, following an invisible path in her mind, a red string before her eyes begging her to follow. She passes Adam's horse, tied up right where she left him behind, and she set the animal free.

Then she entered the bar, a full house which recognized her with the same ease of her falling under the influence of drink, and she set the two golden revolvers borrowing her hip free.

Adora wakes in Bright Moon with a yelp, finding herself halfway on the ground and halfway on the short bed she borrows now. Her heart pounds between her ears when her injury greets her rudely. No sun yet. She even opens the windows just to be sure,

before deciding the open air might be best for her and opening the rest. Open air. Everything she's ever wanted. Everything that's ever made her feel better.

Every day of her life Adora wishes she could erase this recurring memory from her thoughts and dreams, to purge it into the blissful void of nothingness. She longs to forget that day almost as harshly as she longed to reunite with Catra, a violent sting vibrating throughout her heart and shattering all the joy around it. There is a being in the universe which could grant her this simple wish, but it will come with the greatest cost: the single reminder of her desire to escape this life, forever.

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"Heard you were looking for me?"

Adora knocks on the fanciest door she's ever seen in a ranch house, standing in the hall of the fanciest ranch house she's ever been in. Outside the building stands long and wide, a bright white beacon of safety and community. Inside is a place decorated with years and years of hard work and success, expensive and tasteful and far from bragging. Inside is comfortable, the way a home ought to be, and it psyches Adora out. Mostly due to the fact she knows the owner and isn't here to scout out the place for a robbery.

In the home's massive library, a place Catra would lock herself in for days, violent to anyone who would dare to bother or disturb her peace, Glimmer sits between two mahogany bookshelves. The room shares the color scheme of the rest of the home's interior, the same pink and purple the head of the family of Bright Moon is known for. It's the color on their logos and the color of some of the horse's saddles, unique and vibrant and proud. Bright pink curtains catch the early afternoon sunlight just right, transforming the room into the kind of library one might find in a fantasy book. Again Adora thinks of that particular novel Catra invested so much time in.

A mighty book slams closed with a giant thud, and the figure sitting on the white couch in the center of the room turns slightly to face Adora. Glimmer opens her mouth to say something, before catching something else and making a curious expression. “What happened to your shoes?”

On the patterned carpet below her torso Adora finds one pair of gray socks poking out from her green jeans. She also finds dirt has kicked up against her knees. “Sorry. Habit. When I’m in someone’s home—”

“Can you teach Bow that? He says he keeps the house clean, and then he tracks mud in here!” Glimmer stands now, crossing the distance between them. She almost bumps into a pretty lamp the way she stands, just barely missing it. Adora remains by the door, waiting awkwardly. “I wanted to ask you a favor. I know you were out all morning, but I want to follow up on that lead from Perfuma. That Lynda person she mentioned. Bow’s in the city today and it’s slow around here. Want to come with?”

If today were any colder, Adora might refuse. But it’s beautiful outside, possibly the last true summer day they’ll all see around here for a while, and she can’t hesitate to agree. Glimmer has the horses prepared while Adora slips her boots back on, trying to ignore the voice in the back of her head. Swift Wind is excited to be on the road again, as impatient as ever for the taste of adventure. This morning’s ride was far more peaceful than those before, especially those Adora takes to scout out the fort. The way she’s been feeling overwhelmed—Adora needed her trip this morning. She and Swift Wind, alone, taking in the countryside without being on high alert for the sake of her peers or thanks to roaming Hordak associates. Thankfully no bears presented themselves on this morning’s venture, only birds, rabbits, and the occasional traveler stretching across the beaten trail. Adora felt the morning sun beating down on her back, in such a way she considered removing her jacket to feel the full force of the warmth. Then she spotted a few Crimson Waste stragglers and pushed onward. She considers it again now, but ultimately

decides to leave it. Who knows what the weather's like wherever this Lynda is.

Mostly, Adora wants to know who exactly this Lynda person is.

Glimmer's steed reveals himself to be an average sized horse, slightly bigger than most. Still, next to Swift Wind, he looks like someone's large dog. His dark hair and dark coat contrast wonderfully against the purple banners hanging off his saddle. Glimmer jokingly asks Adora if she wants to race, and for now she kindly declines.

"So what's Bow doing in the big city today?" Adora waits until Glimmer has checked the map Perfuma handed over once then twice, tucking it away into her pants pocket. "I'll be honest, I'm a bit shocked you didn't go with him. Peas in a pod and all."

"Not much of a city person. Too many people." Catra and Glimmer would be best friends. "Bow likes the convenience, but it's dangerous out there. My dad used to practically bolt down his pockets every time he went into town." Glimmer shifts, remaining slouching over her steed, one hand on the reins as they cruise along. She always seems to relaxed, even with the threat of declining finances around her, it sometimes makes Adora jealous. Adora was never great at doing anything besides standing on the edge of her toes, her brain on high alert.

Glimmer continues, telling Adora her father was from the city. Ran away the first opportunity he could manage, and met her mother working together on a ranch just outside town. His sister never left the big city of Mystacor. She'd grown herself into a successful and well-known businesswoman, always getting Glimmer's parents new contacts. Fully responsible for the stagecoach deal. Then the sudden spike of Crimson Waste gangsters freaked some of their associates out, leaving Glimmer and Bow to face the current mess staring them back. Today Bow will meet with some new people regarding livestock.

“Where did you run off to this morning? See anything interesting?” Glimmer perks up, straightening her posture. More interested in conversation now, she raises her eyebrows at Adora. “See anything weird?”

“If Sea Hawk counts as weird, yes.”

“Oh, he definitely counts.”

With the end of season approaching, the change in weather begins to flare up every single one of Adora’s past injuries. All the times she’s been shot, stabbed, punched, broken bones doing stupid things—they all surface at random times. Some days her recent wound gets jealous and has to yell louder than the rest, and she finds herself slathering her body in the remedy Perfuma gave her.

Yet, something about the changes motivates Adora to work harder. She finds herself in more of a panic. Time is passing, so fast it becomes cruel, and the fort has remained untouched by either her or Hordak. Almost every night she goes out there his associates are shooting wildly at the walls, hoping the solid stone will simply crumble to nothing and give them the answers they want. Adora fears the day his men get too close to the wall and start throwing dynamite over and inside. She needs to hurry. She needs to move faster, to accelerate to the final solution, but it won’t reveal itself to her. She works every windy morning, desperately holding onto Catra’s hat. Perhaps if she pushes herself enough the solution will grant her the right to learn its secrets, deeming her worthy.

In truth, all she really needs is to stop moving and take a step back. Sit down for more than two minutes. Her dream gravitates her to Adam’s old practice around the gang’s many camps. Days and days have passed since her grand trip with Glimmer and Bow, and Adora wonders how the new security protocols she set for their friends have been going. If they’re even following them. She brings the subject up in passing to Glimmer, and Glimmer happily reports production is way up for both. It used to be Adam’s job,

designing the right patrol numbers and routes to best protect everyone. Adora would help out, making sure every corner was tightly secured, but Adam was the first and final say. He would check in on everyone monthly, make sure they felt comfortable. See if they had any ideas. See if anything was really even working.

This morning's trip brought some relief to Adora. A perfect day for a peaceful ride. Perfuma reported overall better morale around the ranch, with less sightings of Crimson Waste goons. Then she gave Adora enough of the herbal remedies to keep her going through a continued lifetime of getting shot, punched, and breaking bones. Meanwhile Mermista was so grateful about Sea Hawk failing to light things on fire she offered Adora a fishing trip on the biggest boat Adora's ever seen in her life.

"I took some time off and visited Mermista and Perfuma. Thought I'd check in." Adora spares the minor details, such as finding Sea Hawk testing out his kicking accuracy by obliterating sand castles he'd made all across the shore.

Glimmer looks pleased about the perfect day of riding and seeing the sights. Given the weather today, she couldn't have picked a better time. The few times she's managed to venture this far north, she's lucked out on spring and summertime visits. If Hordak doesn't break into that fort first, Catra might freeze to death before they can see one another again.

Turning on the path, they're nearing their end goal. They're at the peak of the heat for the day, and Adora feels warm enough to sit around and picnic. Glimmer tells her, "I'm glad you took a day for yourself. you work really hard around here."

In all honesty Adora completely disagrees, given she's nowhere near her real objective after all this time, but she won't spoil the trip with an argument. Yet she manages, in doing so, to spoil the rest of the ride for herself, lost in her own spiraling brain.

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Growing up, Adora found attachment difficult. Not in the way Catra did. People came and went, in and out of their lives over and over, not much different from the expectation of the change of seasons. Catra was over it. Guarding her emotions, trusting everyone she knew in a loose way. Catra was always tough in that aspect, in some ways that often led to Adora questioning whether or not Catra actually cared for her. Of course when she asked those few times, Catra always called her an idiot. Meaning the answer was obvious: duh she cared.

Not caring. Adora tried it for years, and year after year she failed. She was always easily attached to those around her, fighting for her community with everything she had. Shadow Weaver always preached it, and she was ever the good and loyal soldier to carry the idea out. Even now Adora finds herself wanting to lay her life down for those who inhabit Bright Moon ranch, and she can hear Catra in the background telling her she's too old to be playing the pretend hero game.

Time to time, Catra included, everyone wondered what came of those who left willingly. How long they managed to survive on their own, how long it would be before they came crawling back begging Shadow Weaver for shelter and security. Every time, it was the same circle surrounding Adora. Lonnie. Rogelio. Kyle. Catra. Adam. Scorpia. They were the kids, the ones born into this life, thirsty but unsure of how to pursue another. It was always fantasy, never a reality. Then Adora found herself in a prison miles and miles away, to be separated for ten years.

Ten years away from her old gang, she stands on a doorstep in the middle of nowhere with a new associate. Dirt and nothingness for miles; they're closest to the Crimson Waste than either of them have bothered to venture before. Adora stares at a cactus a few feet away, studying it. So rarely has she encountered a plant that can also be used as a weapon. The door squeaks on its hinges as it tugs open inward, a giant woman staring back at them. Red gloves. Short ashen hair. Ten years, and Lynda hasn't changed a bit.

“Adora! You’re alive!”

“Scorpia—”

Then Adora finds herself almost two feet off the ground, her torso crushed to death with the strength of a bear.

Lynda, more familiar to Adora as Scorpia, immediately invites them in. Doesn’t even ask Glimmer’s name or why either of them are here. They’re brought to a small table in the small house, which appears to be in the middle of a makeover. Spare planks are everywhere, couches and shelves pushed away from splintering, faded wood. Adora watches Scorpia run around, trying to be a good host, unable to find anything for either of them to drink fresh tea out of. Most of all, Adora is trying to ignore Glimmer staring at her in question.

“I didn’t know you befriended strange women living in the middle of the desert.” Glimmer is teasing now. She’s not concerned with the familiarity between the two, or the fact Adora never mentioned her suspicion. Adora wonders how friendly she’ll be once she finds out who Adora really is. “You really are the coolest person we found dead on the side of the road.”

Something about that makes Adora want to laugh. She finally eyes Glimmer as Scorpia shuffles around behind them both. Windows are without glass, boarded up temporarily, but enough sunlight seeps in to highlight just how dusty this place is; specks are floating around everywhere. Adora tells her, “We grew up together. I also grew up with the people in the fort. Haven’t seen them in years.”

“Is that a nickname then? Scorpia? Do we have the right person?” Glimmer looks embarrassed almost, like she’s been mentally readying her business pitch for the wrong person all this time. Meanwhile her husband is in town doing real business. Adora is happy to relieve the worry on her face.

“Her name is Lynda. We all had nicknames growing up. Some of us used it, others didn’t. We decided ‘Lynda’ wasn’t threatening enough and gave her something tougher.”

Glimmer laughs, unknowing of the real context behind the statement. She’s probably painted them all up as cute little orphans—and maybe at some point they all were—so innocent and so small, unable to cause any sort of trouble or damage.

“We called her Scorpia,” Adora continues, “because she has terrible allergies. Her hands used to break out, so she’d put on these long red gloves. She’s still wearing them. There weren’t really any fingers in the gloves, just two points that separated. Those were her ‘pincers’. She also thrived in the heat; winter was hell for her. Desert creature.” Adora gestures, letting the rest of the picture paint itself as Scorpia trips over her own feet in the background.

Glimmer is grinning, amused. “You were a creative group. What was yours?”

Adora is grinning now, feeling nostalgic. Her lips pull back softly, and for a moment a pressure behind her skull disappears. “She-Ra. She-Ra and He-Man; me and my brother. We did all the heavy lifting.” She thinks to tell Glimmer Catra’s real name, but then she’d have to kill her. Legally. Mostly to protect from Catra’s wrath if she ever found out Adora was giving that information out.

“Scorpia was always tough,” Adora says again. A silence has passed them as Scorpia makes progress in her silverware hunt. “But most of all, she was always the nicest person around. Whatever she’s doing out here, you two will find an agreement. I’m sure of it. And she probably needs the social interaction, so there’s a bonus.”

In record deal-making time, certainly faster than the entire day Bow has planned meeting with people, Scorpia is on board. Glimmer hasn’t even finished her pitch before Scorpia says she’ll be happy to join forces. She mentions it’s lonely out here and

Adora grins smugly. Glimmer says something about Perfuma and Scorpia goes red in the face in a way Catra would most definitely tease Scorpia relentlessly for.

Next thing, they're outside. Scorpia wants Glimmer to know what she has to offer. Horses take them one or two miles out, to an intricate series of caves. Old and rusted mining equipment lays everywhere, caked with dirt and mud. A few of them have been set aside and cleaned, with some rust scraped off in a messy pattern. Scorpia mentions buying new gear once she actually starts turning a profit.

It took her quite a while to find this place. Scorpia does her best to keep secretive about who she and Adora really are around the third party stranger, though Scorpia was never good with the secrets and nearly spills it one or two times before Adora has to jump in or intentionally trip over something to change the subject. Adora gains new information: Scorpia learned somewhere along the line that Hordak killed her parents all the way out here to rob them. Shadow Weaver took her in as a result. She's been out here every day trying to restore her family's old mine. Crimson Waste goons don't bother her much, as the home looks abandoned anyhow. Adora mentally notes how little run-ins Scorpia had with the law; they would barely know who she is. This is the safest haven any of them would manage to find. Adora is happy for her.

Sundown approaches quickly now, and with the long ride back home Adora is hyper aware of how little time they have left before the sun finishes setting. They'll keep in touch. The more people from the old gang she can keep on her side, the better.

They're halfway out the door of the property when Scorpia relays information to Adora: an inventor. Someone worth meeting. Nearby. It's Glimmer's idea to head over, and Adora has little choice to continue on into the night.

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As the sun's shadow stretches over the dirt trails and the cacti and the curious scurrying animals of the deserts, Adora notices it more and more. Glimmer is suspicious of her. Or, more in character for Glimmer thus far, she's curious. She has questions, and Adora is in no way prepared to answer any of them in a way that won't end ugly. Hey, yeah! I'm a wanted criminal! I killed a lot of people! See you in the morning around all the people you care for and love!

Glimmer and Bow aren't like that. Still, Adora needs to start pulling more pages from Catra's book if she's going to survive. Go against her innocent little thoughts and feelings and see the truth in front of her: she's just as much a bandit as the Crimson Waste stragglers. Just to be safe, Adora elects to push Swift Wind a little harder and stay in front of Glimmer.

Despite the accelerated pace, they both arrive at the new point on Glimmer's map rather late into the night. This new location is poorly lit, like the home this person lives in is in similar shape to Scorpia's family home. Glimmer reveals the lamplight she travels with, and it illuminates some of the haunted-looking building. Adora is focused now on the item Scorpia gave her on the way out. A screwdriver. Not really sure what that's going to do here, but—

Something heavy falls, and someone makes a sound. On the left. Adora rushes over, in front of Glimmer, the lamplight, and the gorgeous rifle Glimmer's father once carried, and finds a creation of some sort. Ripped tarp is sprawled across the ground, and on it a small human engulfed by the largest mechanical monstrosity Adora has ever come across. She wonders if one of Catra's books has an answer for what this large device is, thin planks held together in the center of several horizontal rows of planks much much longer. The front portion of the machine mimics a windmill, with two smaller versions strung up on the largest horizontal plank closest to the front. The entire machine manages to balance itself on two simple wheels no larger than Swift Wind's hooves. Adora traces the trajectory of the person's fall back into the device, finding a seat of some sort in the middle of it all. Is this meant to be some sort of carriage?

Seeing as the person has fallen several feet downwards, Adora takes the chance and runs over to help. As well as prevent the possibility of startling this person—no telling what else they have on hand. Scorpia didn't mention them being dangerous, but then again Scorpia didn't mention the devilry Adora is running towards, either. She hears Glimmer trailing along, just as cautiously. Together, the pair finds an older woman, sporting purple shaded hair that drapes onto the ground even after she's made to stand. A mask of some sort covers her face, a belt of tools decorating her hip. The metal leaves her face, inspecting Adora for a moment before asking the question none of them were expecting:

"Do you have a screwdriver?"

"Um. Yes, actually."

When Adora fishes the tool from Scorpia out, this woman grabs it, squealing happily, and goes about her way. All Adora and Glimmer do is stare at one another.

"What the hell?" Glimmer whispers. Adora shrugs. "She just fell like ten feet onto her ass!"

Adora is still at a loss for words, so instead she simply shrugs again. Then she presses onward, persistent against this woman. Scorpia sent her here for a reason, and if nothing she's at least curious to know what the hell this giant machine is doing being built in the middle of nowhere next to a run down old house. The woman climbs upward back into the machine, completely ignoring the ladder she's presumably left out for herself. The most Adora can do is stand underneath it, feeling rather awkward. Glimmer teases her, and Adora looks at her pleadingly for mercy.

Here it goes. "Um, excuse me miss? Are you—are you Entrapta?"

A voice from the depths of the machine responds, confirming yes, this is Entrapta. Not much else. Just the sound of something being tightened into something else. Adora isn't really sure what to say next. She looks to Glimmer, but even Glimmer is rather unsure

why they're both here. Scorpia sent them here, and curiosity got the better of them at the late hour. This giant machine isn't relieving any of that curiosity, either.

Entrapta jumps out from the top of the device, this time landing safely, and heads inside the small building she might call home. Or a workshop. Or both. Adora and her buddy make eye contact before mutually agreeing to follow, scurrying on their feet before they're locked out. Entrapta doesn't say much. So Adora tries again.

"Scorpia sent us. I'm . . . not really sure why."

That simple statement perks Entrapta up. she brightens up behind her dirtied brown overalls, a tool flying out of her hand and further into what Adora assumes to be a kitchen. She can spot a cooking spit, but it's in terrible shape and the plates resting on a small table are portioned much too small to be considered a normal meal. Purple hair flies in a frenzy as Entrapta quickly makes her way closer to Adora, effectively raising her heart rate. "She sent you to help with my machine!"

"What does it do, exactly?" Glimmer asks. Entrapta eases off of Adora, excited more by Glimmer's question as she addresses the pair of them in the center of the room.

"Isn't it obvious?" Obviously it isn't, because neither of them can offer an answer or even conjure up a guess. Entrapta isn't fazed either way. "It's a flying machine!"

Flying machine. Is that why Scorpia sent Adora here? A way into the fort? No. How could she possibly know Adora's after the fort?

She can hear Adam's ghost teasing her now, relentlessly. *You are such a puppy dog for that girl! You would do anything for her! It's so gross! Oh man, you are so sappy!* Shut up Adam!

Adora has to believe this is the reason why. There isn't much left to Adora than Catra. Her community. That damn gang. That, or

it’s Scorpia’s way of telling her to get the hell out of this country before a noose finally manages to find her.

“A flying machine for what?” Genuinely, Glimmer is curious. She’s making that face she makes when she’s trying to get some juicy details of Adora’s super mysterious, super dull life out of her. One eyebrow raised, a mischievous grin to her face.

Entrapta blurts the word so loud, Adora jumps: “Science! Technological advancement! Man has spent so long staring up into the clouds, but has never been able to touch them! It’s finally time!” She disappears without warning, returning with a small picture frame. “I’m not alone in this. Of course I can figure it out, but it’s going to be an effort. I’ve been working on this for years. And then I met my lab partner, Hordak.”

The second the photo is flashed towards her, Adora’s heart stops. There’s no mistaking it. Hordak is the type of person who is unique, who looks unlike any other human in the entire world. His pale face, his sickly frame, that cane he’s had for years and years. Her stomach is plagued with the same feeling the first time she and Hordak reunited with one another: the feeling of doom and damnation. Entrapta continues to speak, but Adora can barely register the words. Hordak’s photo stares back at her, threatening her and reminding her how much time she does not have.

“Parts are difficult to come by. And test flights—Hordak doesn’t want to do the test flight himself. He’s not well enough. If I—”

“I can help you with all those.” Adora tugs her coat tighter around her frame, clenches her toes in her boots before she begins to back out of the shack. “I can do it. I’ll stay in touch. We should get going. It’s late.”

She barely waits for Glimmer before she’s hopping on Swift Wind, riding into the night.

It’s late now. The best course of action is to turn around and either camp out with Entrapta or spend the night with Scorpia.

The moonlight isn't kind, doesn't illuminate the trails back to the ranch in such a way as the sun, or even a fraction. Hooves follow Adora. Must be Glimmer. Then another. Another. Another, and two more. Adora feels a weapon rising, and pulls Swift Wind to a sudden halt before the gunshot fires where she was meant to be.

Crimson Waste goons. Glimmer is here too. Damn it, she should've been more careful! She should've listened to herself and turned back!

They're not as showy as the bullies at Bright Moon ranch. They're down to the point, hungrier, more desperate, more savage. Adora yells for Glimmer to get down, to take cover behind a large cactus sitting next to her slowing horse. Someone tries to fire in her direction, and Adora unholsters Adam's gun in a lightning flash, feeling the electricity burning down her forearms once the weapon fires. There's a small bit of force that can barely register as a "kick" from the weapon, and the man attempting to take down the head of Bright Moon ranch is silenced with a new bullet hole through his hand.

A few of the surrounding goons are shaken up. Others, not so much. Either way, Adora can't afford the delay. She fires off two more bullets into the next person, the one closest to her, taking out another. Another shoots at her, and she rounds Swift Wind quickly enough to miss the bullets. She grabs her rifle and sends the horse away, firing off another shot into the next opponent, who falls right off his own horse. The animal is startled, running off. Adora doesn't slow down. One more rifle shot, and there's only one person left to stand against her. The gangster with the hole in his hand decides to flee, leaving his friend behind. Adora gives him the choice. Stares at him patiently, letting him think. Ultimately, he's pulling his gun out, but not fast enough to beat her out.

She rushes back onto her horse, escorting Glimmer back home as quickly as possible. Saying as close to nothing as possible. Adora will need to pack up tonight. She's shown Glimmer too much. In the long few moments it will take to get to the ranch, Glimmer will

decipher her own version of the answer, and whatever that answer shall amount to, it will end in fear. Nothing can change the fact Adora just murdered five people in front of her rather skillfully and comfortably. It was easy, it was barely an effort, and it screams to the heavens just what person Adora is and just what life she's led. Doesn't matter. She can hit the road again and park herself at Scorpia's place. Help Entrapta. Break into the damn fort and get Catra before there is no Catra to get.

Right on cue, the second hooves hit the property, Glimmer is removing herself from her horse and shouting for Bow. She's forgotten her rifle on the horse, but Adora can't blame her; probably her first run-in with fostering an outlaw. Worse: she's bringing Bow outside. The literal last person on the planet Adora wants to oppose. She fiddles with the reins once in her hands before moving to tug them, to push her and Swift Wind onwards in their journey.

"Bow, it was the coolest fucking thing!"

That's never happened before. No, not once, not even in any of those novels Catra read about the outlaw cowboy did the kind ranch owner run out with her husband to talk about how cool the onslaught was. Has Glimmer been the crazy one all along?

She picked up a total stranger on the side of the road and gave them a home. Yes, she's insane.

"Adora! Tell him! It was so—"

"Nope!"

Adora hops right off Swift Wind, abandoning him in the road for now, grabbing the two owners of the property and dragging them inside their own home. Slamming the door and rushing them further inside. Adora doesn't bother with the shoes just yet. In fact, she doesn't even think about it. Glimmer and Bow are in her field of view, unarmed, excited to hear her wonderful gunslinger's

hero's song, and she wants to slap sense into the both of them. They're both insane!

"I pegged you as ex-military. A whole shootout with ten guys? Ex-military. I knew it!"

Adora feels hot and sweaty all of a sudden. Never was good at talking people out of things. If she was, half of her life wouldn't happen the way it did. "Bow. Well—it was *five* —anyway, no, that's —"

"She's a hero, Bow! It was so amazing!"

Then Bow formally asks Adora, "Ex-military? Bounty hunter?"

Adora bites her bottom lip, feeling one of her eyes twitch. "Sure. Bounty hunter, sure. Look, you have to stop. Both of you. Please. I'm not a hero. Okay? Please don't use that word for me." She sighs, finally able to grasp both their attention. Bow motions her to sit, and she refuses. "I am—I am not a good person. I'm nothing you think I am. I served time, and even that wasn't enough to get the whole country off my back. I've done bad things. Wrong things, evil things. I'm no hero. I was at that fort working with a man. He's a real bounty hunter. He wants the people on the inside. I was supposed to help him, because I am one of those people. But I couldn't do it. They're family, and I don't betray my family. Even if they're—even if they're e-evil, like me. Look, I'll try to be out of your hair as soon as possible. I—I will—I'm trying."

Stomping out on shaky legs, Adora throws some sort of apology behind her shoulders. The real two heroes in the room call after her, try to bring her back. Try to give her the self-love and self-acceptance speech. Heard it all before. Not interested.

Adora walks out into the night, not stopping until she can collapse into her own bed. She thinks of Adam before drifting away.

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Escape. Adora's never been good at it. Escapism was always Catra's thing, from books to stargazing to plain dozing off on lazy afternoons. After all this time alone, stuck by herself, Adora has learned her greatest flaw: she can never ever stop fucking thinking.

There's limited time for everything, and her injury decides to take advantage of the day's rain to really abuse Adora. Can't go anywhere. She needs to go anywhere, now that she's exposed her true self to Bow and Glimmer, but she's stuck with one arm pressed against her side, sitting alone in a quiet room. She has to get up. She has to move. The fort is waiting for her. Maybe she doesn't need Entrapta at all. Maybe the next time Hordak sends his men to attack the fort she can sneak in, with all the chaos going on.

Then what, after that?

Adora forces herself to hibernate for the rest of the afternoon, her consciousness wandering the depths about Catra. All the hours she sleeps, she conjures up an old memory. It was the single one time Adora managed to convince Catra to go fishing with her, solely because Catra owed her a gigantic favor. It was a miserable trip; Catra got seasick, Adam was pulled into the water by a giant fish, Adora lost her favorite knife, and the three ended up lost in the woods after they'd forgotten the location of their camp. Yet, the next day Adora finds herself deeply obligated to take up Mermista's offer to go fishing on one of the fancy boats. Might as well, before she disappears on the road again.

Salineas has the most gorgeous waters to offer, possibly in the entire world. Soft waves gently stir the boat, a lullaby against Adora's exhaustion. Mermista is talking about one of her books that Sea Hawk stole when Adora catches herself formally falling asleep, straightening herself out and stretching her shoulders until they pop with great satisfaction. Mermista is a true professional; she catches enough to fill a large bucket rather casually, barely wasting an effort the entire time. it's impressive, and Adora stares in awe before trying to up her game. She spends all day out here,

watching the sunset begin to paint the clear waters in gold and red, mixing together in an angry rush of beauty and perfection.

The sun is going to set. Adora is on the main road, the long stretch of beaten path going from one town to the next to the next, all of each greatly varying in size. Adora and Swift Wind aren't going anywhere in particular. The pair tread through the night, slowing for nothing. On and on they both ride, unsure of the destination until the destination finds them: Entrapta.

Again Adora finds herself standing before the massive machine made to gift man with flight, allowing a simple human to achieve beyond the impossible and kiss the stars. Entrapta is brilliant enough to send a person into the clouds, and Adora is unsure if she should be regarded as the greatest mind of this time or the craziest. Catra read a book about a man with a crazy mind, once. He would go on to become the greatest genius any of the First Ones could ever conjure up.

This era's craziest or smartest or both welcomes Adora as if they'd just spoken this morning and every morning before, as if they were the best friends this world ever knew. If more people were this easygoing maybe the old man would have less to rant about how this country is falling apart. Entrapta barely cares Adora is here, other than asking her to pass over a tool laying around by one of the machine's wheels.

"Say I do help you." Slightly extending her leg under her, Adora pushes herself up on her heel and delivers the tool to Entrapta. "With the—uh, whatever this is. You need someone to test it?"

Entrapta bursts out from the inside of the machine, effectively shaving two years off Adora's already short life. She's wide-eyed, crazy-haired, all around a god damn genius. "I would love someone to test it!"

Without care or even the slightest wonder of danger, Entrapta launches herself out of the machine, falling several feet once again to the ground. This time she lands a little more gracefully,

reaching for Adora's shoulders as she lists out the challenges ahead.

Parts. Lots and lots of parts. Her family has money, but it will quickly deplete the way the machine resigns to neediness. She mentions again she met a man many years ago on a delivery for this machine. Bleeding, shot on the side of the road. Dying. No one else around to stop for him. Entrapta stopped; something told her to stop. The man was brought back here, raised back to health by the woman Entrapta was paying at the time. A personal cook, of sorts, who would go on a trip on the path months later and disappear.

Hordak. Entrapta is the one who brought Hordak back to life. Her act of kindness in a way is the reason for all this, and in a way Adora will find a way to betray her; she's going to test the machine.

Adora is going to be Entrapta's errand girl, gathering everything she needs. Building the machine. Flying the machine. Stealing Catra from the fort and flying as far away from this place as possible. They'll soar so far, run away to a place which forgets all their troubles and all their ailments cursed upon them by this land.

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Bright Moon ranch assigns one last task to Adora before the next step in this new, massive, giant, annoying, terrible job she's been sucked into: packing up and leaving. Lined down the street, the residents of the ranch are waiting for her. Staring at her and Swift Wind as they trot along to the lonely shack in the corner of the main property. Glimmer and Bow's castle-house is still and tall in the background, watching her and every step she will carefully make from this point onwards.

No one is watching her from the windows of the castle, staring down hatefully with burning eyes. The co-owners of the ranch are waiting for Adora in her assigned and borrowed home, where her

things remain packed from where Adora threw them together this morning. A combination of moonlight and lamplight pours in from the street, slinking in through the half-shut boards Adora was careless with this morning. Bow's dark eyes shimmer in the lighting, bringing out a new color in his pupils. Softly he and Glimmer smile, and Adora feels the energy of a person in an intervention situation. If only fixing her life were so easy.

Completing the scenario, Glimmer and Bow motion her to sit. Adora refuses, feeling both cornered and suspicious. Then, even stranger, the strangest dream she's ever had, the door behind her opens and the other associates of Bright Moon ranch enter the room. They're all staring at Adora, and Adora feels foreign in her own skin. Should she run? Should she start waving her gun around and just run away forever?

Mermista and Sea Hawk. Frosta, that kid with the bear. Perfuma. No Scorpia. Adora looks them all over once before turning her questions towards Bow and Glimmer, who simply stare at her as if nothing is happening.

"We saw something," Glimmer says, and each syllable brings a nervous shock down Adora's burning hot spine. Her hands are sweaty, and she flexes her fingers against one another before forcing herself to still them. Glimmer pulls something out, placing it on the table, though Adora makes no effort to inspect it. Piece of paper. She doesn't have many guesses. "I kept in mind what you told us. You don't—you don't really seem like—"

"No one ever does." Adora configures the paper's contents in a simple glance. Hordak put a god damn bounty on her. Her eyes find her packed stuff. Leaving immediately is the best option for every person here. "I will be out of your hair, there's no reason to involve everyone in—"

"We don't care, Adora." Bow and his gentle voice stand, trying to meet Adora somewhere in the middle of the room despite the way she backs off. "You've done nothing but help out since you got here. You're all better and you're still here, helping us out. We

want to help you, too." Bow gestures around, including everyone in the room. "We all want to help."

"You've helped us, too," Mermista adds. Making sure to nod rather obviously to Sea Hawk, who is completely clueless to the fact.

"We wanted to do something for you, too." Perfuma steps closer into the room, standing closer to Glimmer and bow. One unit, together.

When Glimmer tells Adora, she can't believe her ears. It's just not possible. All these people, going out of their way for her. She's told them what kind of person she is. Every pair of eyes in the room has seen the wanted poster sitting on the table. They see the amount. They all see the value of getting someone like her off the good country roads and into a cold cell. None of them care. She thinks of Entrapta and decides folks this side of the country are all, each and every single individual one of them, certifiably insane.

"We want to buy out your bounty."

It will never work. Hordak is much crazier than these lot combined. He'll never let it happen. He'll never let her get away that easily for failing him. Somehow he found out Adora survived, or he's covering his bases, and he has no time and nothing to lose at this point. Something about the posting in itself is suspicious.

"You guys are silly." It's all Adora can say for now, and none of those words convey any of the million feelings in her chest.

"We can't cover all of it," Bow insists, successfully ignoring her upcoming protests, "but there's something out there. Something that can help. Her name is Huntara and she's a huge name in the Crimson Waste. Recently spotted. If you turn her in, it'll cover the remaining amount."

Huntara. Adora thinks she's heard this name before. Despite never being anywhere near the Crimson Waste until now. Turn her in for a heap of cash. It will be a large amount, a dangerous amount to

be carrying around. She'll need to spend it fast. Stash it somewhere. Invest in something. Someone. A machine.

A flying machine which desperately needs funding.

Chapter End Notes

> I know this chapter was pretty stagnant and whatnot, but honestly the point of this one was to be the boring introductory exposition chapter [party sound effects]. Next time has much much more in store (there may or may not include shenanigans with Huntara...)
>
> Should be up next month, hopefully on the right day lol. Definitely not as long as this one. Thank you so much for reading!

Ghosts, Haunting

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Periodically the saloon doors swing open, centimeters away from gracing one another, and each time Adora catches two images: new bar patrons, and the air itself boiling. Invisible steam erupts from the earth, a camouflage volcano plaguing the streets, the homes, the shops. Poor Swift Wind waits outside, roasting away in the sun. He'll be a well done steak soon. Truthfully, the only reason Adora bothered stopping in a bar as sketchy as this small town Crimson Waste dive was thanks to the weather. Bright Moon is too cold, the Crimson Waste is too hot—she can't catch a break!

Bright Moon. Hopefully her business isn't done here yet, but somehow Adora doubts it. She wouldn't allow any of them to lend their guns or their knowledge or wisdom—all of it too dangerous. Unfortunately Glimmer and Bow are persistent people. They settled for aiding Adora by tracking down Huntara's last known location: this exact bar she sits, right now. Bow and Glimmer are too charitable.

Perhaps if Adora had an entire team devoted to tracking Catra, she would've been able to avoid all this. Instead she'll marinate in this saloon, sipping on the same beer—a drink whose taste has long escaped her—and wait around for one of the most wanted people in the region. Bright Moon had given her one task this morning in doing so, specifically from the two stable hands called Netossa and Spinnerella, two kind women who packed a meal for her: don't die.

It's a simple task, not dying. Yet, Adora manages to somehow continuously bring it to the highest challenge on her list. Her eyes dart around the musty bar, and notes one or two light fixtures hanging from the ceiling manage to remain in actual proper function. Wood rots from the ground itself, splintering off into

some poor soul's boots. Luckily this isn't the type of crowd to care much for the concept. Adora briefly watches a pair of men competing in five finger filet, until one of the men chops a good chunk off his hand and screams to the high heavens. The sole bartender of this place, a tired looking man slouched against a small corner, pours the large man a shot and tells him to sleep the pain off. The Shadow Weaver remedy!

Blackjack. Liar's dice. All tempting, but Adora would rather sit back and watch. Last thing she needs is to fall into a gambling black hole and get shot or stabbed in a pointless bar fight. She was told by two women this morning to do the opposite; to not die. For now she'll sit here, watching, waiting for a miracle to cut her time spent in the heat outside by a huge fraction.

Said miracle rolls in about ten minutes past two in the afternoon, the peak of today's heat. Huntara this, Huntara that. Curse Huntara! She just happened to be poking around and looting in the same abandoned town, not too far from here! Damn you, Huntara! You're everywhere! You're exactly at *this* location!

Adora heads out without a second thought. She's afraid of that second thought. It might force her back into that seat. Even as she heads further west she finds little things to distract her aching gut from. Catra used to say the slightest change in weather would make Adora start shaking with blind anxiety. Adora blames her challenge from Netossa and Spinnerella.

Tumbleweeds rolling down the roads in dramatic wind. Snakes hissing to keep your distance. Jackrabbits, scurrying. Every detail of those books Catra used to read about Crimson Waste adventures carried some truth. Gigantic gun fights ending with the hero narrowly escaping is something Adora prays remains fictional. These books were so unfair as to mention the difficulty of not only riding full speed through boiling atmosphere, hot wind turning her face red, but the skill required to keep one's hat from flying right off their head. At one point Adora removes the article and sticks it against her chest with her free hand, a skill she's yet

to acquire after all this time stuck with Catra's favorite accessory. How fast will the item blow off once that flying machine takes off?

Secondly, she considers removing the heavy leather jacket strung across her shoulders, which only grows heavier and heavier the hotter and hotter the day becomes. Would someone down here truly bother to steal such a useless garment way out here, where even the sand is crying out for help? She feels her skin roasting, and with it she feels an irritable mood seeping into her clenched teeth. Why would anyone want to live in a place like this?

By the time Adora arrives in the western, abandoned town, she forgets the jacket conflict entirely. This place is so quiet, even the ghosts haunting it won't bother to make a peep. Broken glass half-shimmers in the various places it has scattered, the other halves caked with layers and layers of dust from churning sand. Bullet holes have cut through some of these buildings, and the dozens of bodies to be expected with them are left to rot in the sun and in the safety of unsafe shops. Few corpses have guns in hand. Most don't. None of them, Adora suspects, have been forgotten with anything of value. One guy is missing his whole outfit entirely, left to tan with flesh which will never bother to tan ever again.

Something about the unnatural carnage forces Adora to remove her notebook from Bow's gifted satchel and redraw the scene, immortalizing it for history books which won't bother to throw a care in the wind about any of the happenings here but for the death toll. Accurate numbers to show the rest of the country just how evil this part of the world is, and just how desperately this part of the world needs people like Hordak to act as lord and savior to lesser men. Among other choice words Catra might use.

Pen stops when Adora realizes she's sketching out an abandoned bank, left for anyone in the world to take whatever they please. She wonders who robbed it last. Every thief's biggest dream, bare for the taking now. Before returning her pen to the page, Adora peeks at the building one more time.

Just in time to dodge a literal bullet.

Some way, somehow, Adora manages to throw herself behind a sturdy part of the bank entrance's wall, her body mostly in the shade. Some sunlight highlights her red boots, creating a wonderful new color she's never seen in them. Unfortunate timing. From within, someone yells all the information she needs to continue forward:

"This is Huntara's turf! Get out!"

Two more gunshots follow, and Adora brings out her brother's golden revolver to shine in the sun next. Alive. She needs Huntara alive to get the fullest payout possible. Let the state hang her. Better her than Adora. She's left a box of ammo in her pocket since the moment she crossed into Crimson Waste grounds. Adora has the advantage here, even if her rifle is still with Swift Wind. The way Huntara is shooting—quickly, inhumanly quick the second she finds a piece of Adora's flesh sticking into the bank—this should be a short gunfight. Just wait her out. Return a few shots, keep her engaged.

The opposing weapon is reloaded rather loudly, and Adora takes her chance to turn the corner she's trapped in and unload a number of bullets close enough to scare Huntara. Time slows enough for Adora to take the opportunity to study her opponent. Tall woman. No, a *gigantic* woman. Huntara is a massive beast, big enough to slap that bear in Frosta's territory to death in a single blow. She's a character out of one of Catra's fantasy books, wide-framed, big-armed, scary looking in the face. It's likely her stare alone could destroy a man and even the man's remains with the tiniest of efforts. Briefly, Adora goes red in the face before returning to cover.

"If I turn her in, she might bite the poor lawmen's heads off and eat them whole," Adora mumbles. Then return fire greets her and she has to yank the rest of her foot she's sloppily left exposed back into her corner. Even more sloppy, she's realizing the box

stuffed into her pocket only has one or two bullets left. She grabbed the wrong box. Great!

Return fire? Shoot this woman a couple times in the legs and put her out of commission? Hit her with the flying machine? One bullet is lost to panic when Adora takes the chance, only to find Huntara was waiting for the opportunity to try and take her out. Narrowly she fails, and narrowly Adora might live to tell Catra about this whole endeavor. Coincidentally, it will also be the day Catra finally slaps some sense into her.

Last bullet. Last chance to steal the advantage and put an end to this. Adora waits for the noisy reload, pivoting the corner on the ball of her shoe in a blink. Huntara's upper portion of her torso is exposed. No legs. No time to move—Huntara has noticed her. Adora takes the shot, missing spectacularly when her bullet hits something else mere inches away from Huntara's shoulder. Adora retreats, feeling beyond the grade of loser.

Fake her out? Throw something in the bank? Call Swift Wind back? Is Huntara the type of person to shoot at a horse? Does Adora really want to be trapped in this place, her longtime companion killed in a silly gunfight? They're all too risky. There is no more line of defense. Eventually Huntara is going to figure her out.

Eventually Huntara will have to shoot again. Nothing, for almost two minutes now.

Adora pokes her head back into the bank. Huntara spots her, easily, immediately, raises her gun. Doesn't shoot. So far all she's done is shoot and shoot and shoot. That's when Adora decides not to move. Her opponent stares at her, looking to break a nervous sweat.

"Are we both out of ammo?" Adora asks.

"It would appear so." Huntara stands, tossing her pistol away like a worthless toy. "Come here, kid. Come on, I don't have time for

this."

Funny, Adora doesn't either. She takes the chance, entering the bank without any other line of self-defense. Adora was never good with knives, not like Catra. Won't even chance using one right now. She'll stand in the center of the large bank and its wood floors and brick walls, allowing Huntara to look her up and down once then twice before the woman comes to her decision, smiling in a way they might be friends.

"She-Ra. The kid wonder. The kid wonder is here to arrest me, huh? It's not traditional for bounty hunters to have bounties themselves, you know."

Not much of a surprise; Adora, Adam, and the rest of Shadow Weaver's gang were pretty popular. Namely when Adora was a teenager, bright and eager to destroy everything and anything for a meal. She'd passed by both Shadow Weaver and Catra's own wanted posters numerous times since entering the Crimson Waste, laughing to herself every time.

"You must be desperate, kid." Huntara leans against a kicked-over box, cracked open and looking rotted from extreme sun exposure; half this building has crumbled into nothing. "What does someone like you even know about bounty hunting? Shooting, for that matter?" Then Huntara laughs, finding her own levels of amusement in ways Adora can't hope to match. "I'm old enough to have a kid your age, you know that? Are *you* even old enough to have kids?"

"I do have a—" Adora bites her tongue so hard, so fast, she can taste the copper of her own blood. Her blood is boiling now; why can't Huntara just get on the horse and merrily make her way to the nearest hanging rope? "I'm here to take you in."

"You're not doing great so far. By the way, Outlaw 101: don't trust anyone. Notice how my gun is still out."

Suddenly, Adam's weapon feels heavy on Adora's hip. Either way, she holds her gaze with Huntara. Determined to win whatever this is. "Empty gun," she reminds the woman. "What makes you think I trust you?"

"You have a . . . Never mention family. Rookie."

"Go ahead!" Suddenly the ability to control her limbs escapes, both of her arms flying up in the air as her blood boils and she openly informs this total stranger and total bandit, "I don't even know where the damn kid is. You know more than I do—it would be a miracle. A miracle! I seriously doubt that child is even alive."

Adora wants to point her gun, to shoot Huntara, to assert herself and force this infamous outlaw to do her bidding. But she won't. She's not certain she can. Huntara is unbothered. She remains leaning against the abandoned box, in that same careless and uninterested way Catra always kept, more interested in the underside of her fingernails.

"That is a lot of baggage for one skinny kid." Huntara stands, bringing herself to her full and towering height. "Either way, you turn me in, it won't matter. I'm not the one calling the shots down here anymore. Notice my giant crew backing me up right now. Collect all the money you want, nothing will ever change here. Not unless you get down to the source."

Down to the source. Her bounty is right in front of her, the answer to placing herself by Catra's side once more, the answer to the two of them getting the hell away from everything forever and ever. Adora is thinking of all the wrong things right now, all the wrong priorities, and it's all the more reason to grab Adam's gun and beat herself to death. Bow and Glimmer saved her life. Perfuma gave her those herbs. Mermista gave her a place to let her mind wander. They don't deserve to live in fear. If she could make their lives a little easier . . .

Some part of her hates Huntara slightly less, hearing this. Curiosity, the same one who killed the cat, infects Adora next. The

dangerous question leaves her lips in a poisonous string of sounds, endangering her future and her loved one's future largely. "Who does?"

"He's a snake. A walking snake. Stole my crew, stole most of my money—and most of my ego—and made out like a bandit. I'm getting old, kid. He isn't. He has promises of adventure and plunder and excitement. It wasn't easy for them to leave me. Name's Tung Lashor."

Adora's hand shifts to her holster, resting comfortably. "What's stopping me from turning you both in?"

"One of Lashor's people shooting you in the head, probably. You can't navigate this place by yourself. few people can."

"But you can, is that right, ma'am?"

"It sure is."

Huntara is holding the firmer stare now, looking into Adora's eyes as she recalls the number of times she heard Tung Lashor's name uttered in that one bar alone. His posters plastered everywhere like free candy, graffiti scribbles across most of the flimsy sheets of dust-stained paper.

Unfortunately there's narrow margin to consider the pros and cons of going after someone else in place of her immediate and exposed target, when said target begins to do something as simple as walk away. She's decided her fate between the both of them, hoisting a bag of looted items over her broad shoulders and brushing past Adora, who is too small and too dumb to stop her. Guess they're doing this. They're going to team up. Or something.

"Besides," Huntara says, crossing into the road to a new building, "there is no one on this planet who can clean up that awful shooting technique you're walking around with. No wonder your specialty was castle rustling."

The infection spreads as Adora chases after Huntara, asking what she possibly means by that. No response. Huntara makes her way down the street, boots making a musical out of the scattered rocks between buildings. Adora's steps are less measured, rushing to close the space as Huntara takes giant leaps and bounds with her massive legs. Did Catra ever read about women who looked like they were able to lasso several different gods down to the Fright Zone and kill them each in one punch? Blindfolded? With one hand behind her back?

Gun shop. If one bad memory wasn't enough to turn Adora's stomach, the view plastered everywhere for the new duo will do the job: mangled corpses, some missing limbs, heads, faces torn apart, blood splattered one almost every possible surface. Each of the corpses is well dressed. A few appear to be poor, with dirtied shirts and ripped pants. Most of the well-dressed peoples' boots are missing. Pockets have been cut open in both pants and formal jackets. Employees and customers were killed the same, and a few people from the bank tried to run in here for help. Last line of defense. One or two of the bodies by the door were lawmen. All were killed and looted the same.

"Back in the day, we got the job done. Went in, took what we wanted, got out. No fuss. No law, that's for sure." Huntara approaches one of many cabinets positioned by the long walls, the fine wood painted a certain shade of blue to match the rest of the building's aesthetic. She pushes aside one of the corpses, mumbling something to them as they flop against the blistered floor. "Most importantly, not a single casualty. This? This is the devil's work. This isn't right."

Avoiding eye contact with any and every corpse surrounding, Adora has no choice but to pay her attention to Huntara, who turns to eye her more seriously.

"This is Tung Lashor's work. It's the work of a coward."

If Shadow Weaver ever made that move out here, Adora is convinced Huntara would be one of their shining stars. She would

fit right in. Growing up, there were only two real rules, other than the unspoken obvious not to mess with Shadow Weaver's things: no casualties of civilians or law, and no robbing those with less to give than them. Only rob the rich, and only abuse their wallets. Nothing else.

Rifling through a couple more cabinets, Huntara returns to the doorway Adora's boots are glued to. She tosses over a couple new boxes of ammo, brushing past her and declaring they'll be starting with someone she's been keeping her eye on for weeks now. It'll be much easier with a partner. Because that's what they are now, partners in crime. Being a good partner in crime, Adora follows loyally, not questioning a single thing about any of this.

Swift Wind follows them as Adora gently leads him herself, tugging him along. He appears to be staring at Huntara the way she tracks down whoever this person is meant to be, untrusting of her. Adora feels the same. But then, Huntara did get her some free ammo. Eager to save her own ass with this Tung Lashor side job, maybe. Once he's in, there will be a fresh bullet in Adora's back.

Everything leads back to the fort and the fact she was shot and left for dead at said fort: does she really, truly have any other choice?

"Are you a good tracker?" Huntara asks suddenly. She's knelt over a mud patch in the middle of wherever they are, feet away from a long-forgotten wagon. Even the vultures won't spare another second here.

"Half decent," Adora responds. Swift Wind snorts, almost in agreement, and she wants to turn around and revoke his apple privileges until the end of time. The answer brings Huntara to amusement, as well.

"At least she's honest. Come here. Look at this." Pointing to the earth, she asks Adora what person might belong to the shoe marks. What they might've been doing here.

“The indentations belong to a boot. The front portion is pointed. They’re more cosmetic than they are for riding; this person isn’t an outdoorsman. They were in the middle of the desert, so maybe they were lost?”

“Not bad. I wouldn’t say lost geographically. They’re a pony in a dog show; they don’t belong out here and they have no idea what to do with themselves.”

Adora looks at her new teacher. “Is this person someone you know personally? Who exactly are we looking for?” Huntara makes her answer which direction the person was headed. North. Wrong. Apparently it’s north with a slight eastern tilt.

“They were out here scavenging, by the way.” Huntara stands, returning to her towering stature over Adora’s puny frame. Adora returns to her horse’s side, grabbing his lead again. “He’s a city boy,” Huntara says to no one in particular. “He’s Tung Lashor’s city boy. He’s going to construct a bunch of false facts about his actions down here and bring his bounty down. He’s scared. The law is ready to send a whole force out here just to get him, he’s just that special.”

Lucky for Huntara, a young rookie idiot like Adora came down here instead, stupid and inexperienced and desperate for a payout. No wonder she’s being so pushy. She’ll be getting her worst nightmare out of here, and if she’s most lucky Adora will be too busy handling Tung Lashor to even notice her slipping away.

Finding the man isn’t too difficult. He’s as lost as Adora would be out here without a guide, roasting away in the hot sun. He’s not too defensive about Tung Lashor. He’s desperate for someone to put him out of his misery. It’s what Adora watches and waits for. Once the information is gone, then what? What will be Huntara’s next move? Will she commit the same cowardice as those she despises, or will she remember her roots from back in the day?

Nighttime falls, not the man. Huntara and Adora ride out somewhere safer, together on Swift Wind. They leave the man

behind with one of the boxes of ammo and a gun Huntara took just for him. She bids him good luck and a farewell that might belong to a colleague, or someone she's truly worried about.

-

"I want to do it. I want to run away."

She'd apologized, on and on and on until it became hard for the air to leave her lungs. Adam was dead, killed by paranoia. Justice would never hope to reach him, not in the way Adora craved. Not in the way she tried to force. She destroyed that town and it was her dirty little secret, her careful lock with a key she'd thrown far, far away.

Adam was gone. There was no changing it. He was gone forever, his presence a giant hole in the small group Adora would have to know as family, and covering up that giant hole was the most difficult thing any of them had ever attempted. Shadow Weaver didn't care, didn't bat an eye, and Adora was too much of a coward to run up to the woman and start demanding why she wouldn't bring herself down to spare a worry for one of her star children she claimed to love so much.

Life wasn't moving on. Adora couldn't complete any of her jobs, and Shadow Weaver couldn't hold back her temper on the matter. Adora had both of the man's prized guns, and they were the heaviest weight on her chest she'd ever felt. It was one thing to lose a member of the family. Happened numerous times and would happen numerous times more. But this man, he was her twin brother. Every step of her life, he was there. This was a pain she could barely grasp.

Finally, the pain brought out the truth to her: this is a miserable, horrible life no one should ever be forced to live.

They'd planned so smartly. Catra and her books, Catra and her smarts, Catra and her endless knowledge and endless ability to think. Of course she had a plan. A place to go. A time and

distraction when to leave, where in the camp to leave. All Adora had to do was follow. It was that simple. It was always that simple, and she was the simpleton too low on brain cells to commit the act. Get up and leave. Easy.

Not easy.

Catra's brain and Catra's plans would never predict the surprise snowstorm which blew in from quite literally nowhere. Desperately, the pair pushed and punished their horse through the weather. They needed shelter. A cave, a safe place to camp, anything. It was too dangerous to turn now, and for pride's sake neither was confident in the notion of turning around and simply quitting. The simplicity of quitting in itself was not simple enough. Hence the stubbornness embedded deep within Adora's genes.

Log cabin. Catra saw it first. With the winds attacking them both, Adora could barely see the inside of her own eyelids—it was a miracle sighting. A small, open patch of land surrounded by trees and a small wood fence. A stable big enough for their horse and what little they had shoved into saddlebags. Two more animals were on the property, a horse who likely called this place home, and a second. The second appeared out of place, confused. Impatient. These storms made desperation of the owner, anxiety of the beast. Catra borrowed one of Adam's revolvers, and Adora and her fresh wounds opted for her trusty rifle.

Adora's eyes weren't even in the door yet when Catra let off two shots, quickly downing the sole person inside. Intruder with the same idea. They'd made a scene of the cabin owners, having spilled their blood in large pools on the handmade floors. A sound erupted violently from another room somewhere else, and Catra immediately investigated. Adora immediately went to work disposing of bodies. Firstly, taking what she could off the initial intruder of lesser skill and lesser luck. Secondly, she removed the true owners and truly lesser lucky individuals outside, somewhere more respectful. She had picked a spot for later to bury them. For now she thanks their lifeless bodies for the shelter and apologized for what they'd lost.

The next few minutes Adora spent barricading the entrances to the cabin. Luckily she was smarter than the fool Catra just killed. Couches with handmade furs sewn into the chair backs. A hand carved table. The windows were already bolted shut with more wood from the trees surrounding this secret place, the last line between warmth and frostbite. An expert, Adora managed to get the fresh blood out of the floors. Mostly. If anything she could relocate one of the many rugs strung about this place.

All in all, the cabin was a solid location. Small space. Limited entrances. It was a completely self-sustained home, including a large outhouse and shower out back, a stove and a fireplace, numerous cabinets, and room set aside outside for skinning and cleaning game. The couple who lived here had the same idea as Catra. Adora had to hope for more than their closing fates.

Best of it all: Shadow Weaver had no idea where this place was.

Adora thought to celebrate with a shot of some of the good stuff these people kept around, until she looked around and realized Catra was nowhere to be seen. Next thing she's sprinting around the house, nearly knocking the first door she came into contact with off the hinges. Catra sat inside, holding something. Something small.

She'd sat herself on the ground in a small room with a small bed which appeared to be in the process of being built for a smaller person, and an even tinier completed bed next to it. A bed with bars—a crib. Adora easily spotted a rocking chair near the door she'd nearly taken out. A map leading to the nearest town was up on the wall, right above a changing station for a baby who would now remain an orphan thanks to a random asshole in the mountains caught in the wrong storm. Adora wonders if she and Catra were willing to go to such extremes tonight for shelter. Would they be able to kill that couple? Were they that desperate to win today? Is that really the way they were going to start their new lives free from Shadow Weaver, with senseless violence ignoring what few good things she'd taught them?

On Adora’s head sat Adam’s borrowed hat, which was soon removed in respect of the small human in Catra’s hands. The small human Catra sat on the floor with, staring at. There was nothing else in the world but this child.

“Come here, dummy.” Adora wasn’t sure when Catra began making eye contact with her. Turned out she was staring, as well. Her legs took her over, across the room, leaving the hat on one of the tables somewhere in this small person’s small world. Adora placed herself next to Catra, sitting on the ground with her legs straight in front of her. White covered her red boots in a painful chill, leaving her toes to suffer a great cold.

Catra’s head falls against Adora’s shoulder, and suddenly Adora was unable to bring herself to think of anything else. Catra was rarely affectionate like this. And when she was, Adora was ready to close her eyes and fall into the deepest sleep of her life.

Today she found she couldn't. This wasn’t a relaxed place they’d found themselves in. Danger might still lurk about. Other, poor souls also lost in this mountain’s rough storm could wander near them, lingering until they’d made themselves the newest residents. Two, they had no idea where they were. How long this storm would last. How much food they even had, and what game lives up here. They were both so underprepared for the world, it should have been the funniest joke in the world. Instead, it was a sharp terror that stabbed into Adora’s chest with a quick, repeated slash. And third, there was a baby sitting around in Catra’s arms.

“It’s a terrible idea,” Catra said out of the silence. “It’s a terrible, stupid, irresponsible idea.”

Adora thought to suggest moving out here in the middle of winter as well, but she knew better. The child rested right in Catra’s arms. It was bound to get addressed sooner or later. Rather sooner than later, before the three of them should fall hungry and one of them starts crying.

“We can’t do it,” Adora told her. “We’ll never survive.”

"I know. But—"

"It's a *baby* , Catra!" She was never this person. Catra was always, always the person with a plan. With something to go by, even when she seemed to have nothing at all. Was this the secret all along? Was she bullshitting her way through life this whole time? Was she always this good at making a new plan on the fly? Adora was too dumb and too blind to notice any of that?

Head leaves Adora's shoulder, and Adora prepares for the first argument of their new life. Was bound to happen sooner or later. "I won't bury a baby. Are you insane?"

"I'm trying to be practical." Most of all, trying to keep her voice and her aggression down. Before the child woke and made things even worse.

"Then I have news for you: practical was never our lifestyle. Never has been, and never will be." Catra glared at her for a moment, before sitting back again. Adora sat still, her spine slumped, keeping her eyes on the door. "At least until this storm blows over. We can't go anywhere anyway."

"Fair enough."

"I really hate you sometimes, I swear."

Adora became the one staring now, finding something deep within Catra's eyes. She grinned as she told Catra, "I love you too," and Catra scoffed before rolling her eyes and reluctantly mumbling how she somehow found it in her to love Adora as well.

Head returned to Adora's shoulder, and for some reason she felt the usual sleepiness suddenly. Then, as a few more moments passed, Adora found herself wanting to hold their new friend now. As temporary housemates, surely they should get to know one another. Temporarily.

The baby stirred in Adora's arms, sensing her uneasiness. Little eyes popped open, meeting with Adora's in the most dizzying

stare down of Adora's life. Bright blue eyes. "Eyes like Adam."

Curly, crazy, fizzy brown hair. Catra made herself more comfortable as she made her own observation, "If you and I could have one . . ."

In all honesty, it's the last thing Adora expected of Catra. To raise a child in the middle of nowhere. Yet, here in this moment, it made all the sense in the world, to give a child something neither of them ever had, only dreamed of. "We will never survive with a baby, Catra."

"I know. But how about we pretend it's possible?"

"This is stupid."

"I know." One of Catra's arms wrapped around Adora's, holding her close. Catra, always strategic, always so strict about logic and common sense and fighting stupid urges. Was she a hypocrite? Was the love of Adora's life a giant lying hypocrite?

Adora didn't move. She couldn't move, she thought, as her eyes looked down on this creature, this sacred creature she'd had the highest honor of holding. It was a cosmic, uncontrollable coincidence far from her hands of understanding which placed her here in this cabin on this exact day in this exact moment, placing her in the same time and place as this child in need. It makes so much sense, yet it makes absolutely no sense at all. This wasn't the plan. This wasn't the grand idea either of them had when they left the camp this morning, crazy and swift and desperate and excited to finally move on and be free.

The baby's eyes opened and she held her breath, trying desperately to keep from disturbing the child. The child looked up at her, staring. She couldn't move. She'll turn to stone forever, if this child so desires. Then there was a yawn, and the baby slipped back into sleep, comfortable enough to do so. Feeling safe, in her arms. This child trusted Adora. Adora kept this child safe from the

dangers of the world, from the dangers of strangers breaking into remote homes for shelter in the middle of a freak storm.

Damn it all to hell.

"Finn. It's the name Adam chose. Before he and Teela—"

"I love it." Catra squeezed her arm tighter, supporting Adora's grief for her brother. "Finn."

Adora leaned her head against Catra's, the two staring at Finn as they slipped away at their own pace, quiet and peaceful. The storm outside grew far from either of their minds, and even further the corpses waiting for attention outside.

She would not learn to love the child fully, without anxieties of her and Catra's survival, not until it was too late. As usual, Adora was too hesitant, too wrong, too scared, too late. She was a giant simpleton in such a small, small world.

Finn was too good for her anyway.

-

Morning greets Adora with the tender sounds of birds singing, and the sun shining gently in her eyes.

She wishes.

The Crimson Waste is as awful as ever, overcooking sand too unfortunate to get up and move. But it isn't the heat, it's a horrendous chewing sound and lips smacking loudly ultimately wakes Adora up. Huntara rips something charred apart with her teeth alone, hunched over a fire—as if the sun weren't powerful enough on its own out here—not missing a single piece of the animal. Another one is set aside, and Adora isn't sure if it's for her or because Huntara has giant bulging muscles that need to be taken care of. Not that Adora's noticed.

“You were busy sleep-yelling and sleep-fighting,” Huntara says, not bothering to turn around, “so I took the liberty of getting food.”

Adora forces herself upright into a sit now, squinting her eyes with what little protection her puny little tent provides. Hauling it has been easy. Sleeping in it not so much. She thinks to say some sort of apology to Huntara, something along the lines of how terrible she is at sleeping peacefully beyond the last ten years or so, but Huntara doesn’t wait for her.

“Besides, it would be more shooting lesson, less hunting game.”

“What is wrong with my shooting? I’m a good shot.” Adora scooches forward once, before joining Huntara by the fire. Taking the other kill before Huntara claims it.

Again, Huntara does not bother to look up, and something about it begins to infuriate Adora. Everything about Huntara seems to infuriate her. “You shoot like you’re in a panic.”

“Those two things tend to go hand in hand, yes.” Adora stares, snatching her share of the food away. Huntara finally glances at her, once briefly before turning away again. Adora sees beads of sweat dripping down the sides of her head where she’s shaved her hair to stubble.

“It means you have no confidence, kid. It’s why you’re on the run.”

That’s the answer. All of her problems, orphaned so young with nowhere else to go, working under Shadow Weaver’s gang just to eat something every night, watching her brother pass, losing her family—all because she has poor self-esteem. What a world!

“Show me something, then, if I’m so terrible.”

“You’re not terrible.” Regardless Huntara stands, snuffing out the fire and beginning to pack away both their things. “But someone like you should know better.”

Ain’t that the truth.

Camp is packed up in the span of a few short minutes, leaving Adora and her breakfast to trail behind Huntara. Swift Wind follows behind, loyally, probably more afraid of this place and its terrible energy more than any of them. Not far away from last night’s rest spot is a small patch of cacti, rabbits scurrying in the distance as curious birds watch them. Here Huntara stops them, tossing a new box of ammo at Adora.

Dirt kicks underneath massive boots as Huntara scurries around, setting up a firing range with the remains of someone’s camp. Scattered cans, forgotten beer bottles—anything will do. She tells Adora to show her how to shoot. It’s a simple notion, when so engraved into her life. It feels to Adora like a shrug of her shoulders to pull the revolver from her hip, pointing a death-bringer so shiny and expensive and taken care of at a set of innocent bottles and cans. Her wrist barely flinches when the bullet exits, flying out the chamber, through the barrel, shattering one of the discarded bottles.

Huntara laughs and tells her she’s wrong.

“Come on,” Adora says. “It hasn’t killed me yet.”

“Emphasis on yet. Your elbow is bent. There’s something going on with your posture—you are not tall enough to slouch—and you jump to that trigger way too fast.”

Adora feels her spine straightening out against her own command.

“Your accuracy is going to be off, and you’re going to waste more bullets. Pull a muscle maybe. You don’t think before you shoot, you just shoot. There’s always more to it than shooting the other guy in the head. Use your environment, get creative! Hell, maybe you don’t even have to shoot at all to win.”

“In these parts, I doubt it.” Adam’s revolver is tucked away, Adora’s way of showing her protests to whatever this violent tear-down of her one skill is supposed to be solving. “Why does this

mean so much to you? I've fought other gangs before. I've stepped on enemy turf and taken out everything that moved. This is just another guy and his set of buddies. Tung Lashor scares you that much?"

"Of course not! He's an idiot." From the cactus rendered a tiny desk plant compared to Huntara, scoffing breaks out. Then Huntara crosses over, staring Adora down the whole time. At least the eye contact is here now! "Everyone here in the Crimson Waste, kid, they're tough. They can take a hit. But they all fall the same. *You* should be nervous. Weren't you trying to get your kid back?"

Adora's heart stops. If the gun were still in her hand it would've fallen, shooting off in a new creative way Huntara might still manage to hate. Adora's ears ring fuzzy, as if an explosion has gone off right next to her, and she feels her face begin to turn red. "What did you just say?"

"The loud dream you had last night. That's what the money's for isn't it? Finn was the—"

"Huntara." Adora stares daggers into the woman, the best threat she can make to a woman twice her size. "This is thin ice you're on right now."

The child remains high on Adora's off-limits list. Don't talk about Finn. Don't think about Finn. Don't ever, ever dream about Finn. All three of these rules, broken just today alone. The Crimson Waste is hell for the living, and Adora wants out of here as quickly as possible. Even quicker than that, even.

All that time ago, fresh out of prison, Adora made a run for a mountain. Found Swift Wind along the way. Not a soul was home. The home was barely intact, itself. No trace of anyone. Now Huntara stands around, the real reason Adora has traveled to the Crimson Waste, staring her down and challenging her about her own family.

“If you want them back,” Huntara dares to say, “then you have to live. Now fix your damn elbow, kid.”

Adora pivots, shooting down one of the cans.

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If Swift Wind hadn’t stopped for her, the three of them would’ve gone marching right into the camp Huntara’s best buddy indicated. Adora feels distracted, and it’s the worst timing in the world. The one exact reason she never ever brings Finn’s existence into her radar. Adora considers postponing today’s raid for the sake of laying in the dirt somewhere and roasting to death. Huntara tells her to keep her head in the game before exiting Swift Wind and running off.

Neither of them manages to spot Tung Lashor. Not here. He could be further into the camp, maybe day napping in a tent, or they’ll go ahead and thin out the herd for later. Either solution brings Huntara to lighting a couple Molotov cocktails and throwing them into the center of the camp, beginning the shootout. Good thing a rookie like Adora just learned how to shoot!

Rifle finally leaves Swift Wind’s saddle. She’ll let Adam’s revolver sit this round out, given how many rounds she shot off this morning. Adora was always a rifle girl. Something about using Adam’s gun makes her feel lucky, protected. Hopefully she won’t need luck right now.

Posture, it turns out, is everything. A habit she didn’t realize she’d picked up reveals itself to have been haunting her, vastly improving every shot she makes with her long-time weapon. Adora takes out three people back-to-back and Huntara nods approvingly at her. Before chopping some poor guy’s head off and throwing another bottle somewhere. One half of the camp is burning to nothing, the other painted in fresh blood. It’s like that town Adora met Huntara in all over again.

All in all, the two have created a horror story-style slaughtering. Travelers will pass by and retreat with screams erupting from their throats, telling their children of this sight in the hopes of deterring them from a life like this. If only this life were as simple as a bad choice gone wrong. Adora looks around at it all, thanking every power in existence Finn will never see this camp.

No Tung Lashor, but Huntara chases down one last guy before he can get away. He's all screams — understandably — when he's tackled, and before anyone can say anything he's giving away the exact location of his boss. He's even giving away his own gun, his own money, anything and everything to keep himself safe. Huntara simply pats him on the head and watches him run away.

"Small town a few miles from here. I know the place. Nice town." Huntara wastes no time in crouching down, grabbing whatever these men have off their corpses. "I think most of the gang was here. Shouldn't be too much trouble now, I hope. Good shooting, kid."

"No criticisms?" Adora watches as Huntara unclips a gold pocket watch from one of the men, stuffing it away. Adora should get started on looting ammo before there's nothing left. A few shiny objects manage to make it into her satchel, as well. Jewelry, mostly. Catra's never been a fan, but it'll be funny to see the look on her face after all this time.

"I saved your vertebrae from popping out. You're welcome."

In truth, everything about the shootout felt better. There was a magical feeling in the rifle, like it suddenly had more power. Adora herself felt different, too, a strong wall against a manmade force; every time the gun exploded to life, her shoulder was strict and firm against the crazy animal in her hands. Truly, there is only one real way to test her improved skills: follow Huntara into town.

Just like most of the territories Adora has passed in the Waste, the town is small. Remote. Its best use is a stop for travelers smart enough not to live here. Its current use is a fun afternoon

activity for the biggest name in the Crimson Waste. Pillaging for no reason, Tung Lashor's people run around, building to building, slaughtering and filling saddlebags with whatever item might shine in the sunlight. The moment they spot Adora, the moment they spot Huntara, everyone stops. A man makes his way into the center of it all, waiting patiently for them to arrive.

Tall. He's a thin, bald, bony man with a long face and the ugliest bright red suit Adora has ever seen in her life. He smiles at Huntara, long, hideous teeth revealing their yellow presence in the bright day's light before disappearing behind chapped lips. Tung Lashor.

The man in charge stops the whole town and tells them to watch. This is a show to him. Then he greets Huntara like an old friend, and Huntara mumbles something about wringing his neck until he begs for the hanging rope. So much for speeches on respect and classiness.

"Rest of your boys are out of commission, Tung Lashor," Huntara says. She jumps right off of Swift Wind, hitting the ground with a satisfying thud. "Be a man and face me now. No more running."

"Alive," Adora hisses from her horse. "Ma'am, I need him alive." She doesn't get much of anything else the way things play out.

Both criminal royalty pull their guns without warning, apparently performing a silent duel. Huntara manages to shoot Tung Lashor first, a solid shot that takes a chunk of his hip off in an explosion of crimson. Then his men spring into action, raving mad and uncaring of the fairness of duels. Adora freezes. Then her brain shifts to autopilot, dumping rifle bullets into more bodies.

Tung Lashor starts to get away, and suddenly she's awake all over again. She hasn't dismounted her horse yet, and with a short warning to Huntara, she's off just as her target gets a horse of his own.

Town leaves them both quickly, disappearing into a cloud of dust in the distance. Tung Lashor won't be easy to lose out here, kicking up a cloud of his own which serves as the perfect marker. He has a healthy distance away from Adora, but Swift Wind wasn't misnamed. Her horse pushes and pushes himself with great loyalty, closing the gap in a matter of minutes. Better yet: her target is dumb enough to have forgotten his gun somewhere else. Everything is in Adora's favor, and she finds it difficult not to celebrate so early. When she finally makes it side-by-side to the man, she hits him with the butt of her rifle, successfully knocking him off the horse and onto the dirt.

Successfully securing funds for Entrapta's machine.

"Don't move." Adora towers over the man now, his borrowed horse fleeing the scene. "It's over, Tung Lashor. I'm taking you in." She hits him again, leaving him unconscious and leaving herself to turn in an easy bounty.

"You got him!" Huntara, the original bounty and original reason for coming all the way out here, manages to catch up on her own horse. Doesn't get off. Maybe she doesn't trust Adora anymore, at this point of the job. Maybe she's right not to. "You got the son of a bitch! Finally!"

The rifle returns to the saddle, but Adora doesn't let Huntara out of her sights. She hasn't made a decision yet. Could she even take Huntara in a fight if things take a turn for the worst? She goes ahead and asks the question, "Are you next, Huntara? Help me decide."

The woman is completely indifferent to the answer. This sight right here is all Huntara was interested in seeing, right from the beginning. Practically the first thing out of her mouth. "Makes no difference to me, kid. Either way I plan on watching this asshole swing."

"Make sure you wear a disguise." Adora drags Tung Lashor by his feet, lifting him onto Swift Wind in a quick toss once he's closer.

Her reflexes prepare her side to start screaming for mercy, but no screams ever present themselves. “I don’t think I’m interested in watching you swing.”

“If you ever are, you know where to find me.”

Mounting her horse again, Adora grins at Huntara. “Thank you for the lessons. Even if I hated them with a blistering passion.”

Huntara is already turning her new steed the opposite direction, probably planning on destroying the rest of the gang behind them both. “Go find your kid. Never, ever let them go.”

Then she rides off, back into the Wastes, weapon drawn eagerly, never to be seen by Adora ever again.

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Through everything, every step of the way since she left that prison, Adora’s greatest companion has been her horse and his unbreakable spirit. Bandits chase and shoot at them down the road and Swift Wind barely blinks, only focusing on the trail ahead. His speeds are impossible and Adora is convinced the animal could run forever the way he never gets tired. Now, she fears, with all the things she’s been hauling for Entrapta the last few days, Swift Wind is on the cusp of hating her guts for the rest of this life and into the next.

“You’re a work horse, buddy, this is what they do.”

Her steed complains, sighing at her as the cargo behind them both clutters with the road. Almost to Entrapta’s. Some days Scorpia is present as well, and she totally saves Adora’s life when it comes to heavy lifting. She’s tall, she’s muscular, and she’s never been shot. Mostly she wants to catch up, but Adora isn’t interested in catching up until Catra is physically by her side. Can’t get her hopes up for something that might not even happen.

Adora spends the last of her payout on food for Swift Wind. Some remains, but she’s planning on keeping it for the next inevitable

emergency. Entrapta keeps saying they're close to getting the plane, as she refers to the device, off the ground. It definitely looks more complete than when Adora and Glimmer first arrived here, the frame of the machine looking haunting and beyond foreign. Seeing it now, Adora thinks to compare the original version to a skinless bird.

The machine stands tall in its place, nose to the sun (thankfully much, much cooler than the sun causing a burning hell in the Crimson Waste) and its head high with confidence. Bulkier now is the tiny frame from before, the intricate designs underneath tucked away and protected from whatever harm should become the vessel at several hundred feet in the air. Even the wheels have their own protection now, solid metal frames covering the front portion from sparks on landing.

Entrapta tells them a test flight is in the near future, and Scorpia and Adora decide to take the day off in celebration. Scorpia spends the day running around making food and drinks, while both Adora and Swift Wind sit outside and lazily nod off. Someone calls Adora, and for once her immediate reaction isn't to jump up, guns at the ready. She simply tells them it's her day off.

They persist.

"Scorpia, we agreed—You're not Scorpia."

In front of her, the young freckled, familiar face of a teen who would want to follow in Adora's poor footsteps stares back at her. The teen rides on a small horse, either an overgrown pony or a sad, sad breed she's never heard of. The teen is from Bright Moon, which is far enough away to become an immediate concern that brings Adora to her feet.

"What are you doing here?" she asks. The pasty-face kid has no answer. They're blank in the face, as if waiting for Adora to say the right answer in this guessing game. "Where are your parents? You're really, really far from home."

“Bright Moon!” Suddenly the teen wakes up, already turning their horse back to where they came. “We got your letter. You said if we need anything—well, we—Bright Moon is under attack! A scary guy and his fancy friends are there!”

Adora gets on Swift Wind and hits the road without so much as looking back. How the hell could Hordak possibly know where Adora was? No one in Bright Moon knows about him—this can’t possibly be a trick of some sort. Why Bright Moon at all? Is he that desperate for new horses and new men?

From far, far in the distance Adora can easily spot thick clouds of smoke belching from the buildings she walked around every single day for weeks and weeks. The faces she passed all those days, burning inside, burning on the streets, their valuables turning to nothing. What little these people have is disappearing right in front of them, and it pushes Adora to stop sparing Swift Wind.

On the way in, Adora sees them: the three men she threatened on one of her first few nights here. She let them go. Now they’re sitting here, laughing about the chaos and the mayhem and the destruction they’ve caused. Behind them Adora finds the man in charge, surveying all the bloodshed. His men run around on their own purebred dolled-up horses, shooting everything that moves. Bright Moon patrols are doing their best, but ultimately they’re outnumbered.

Glimmer and Bow are easy to spot in the battle zone, taking cover behind what remains of one of the barns. Old wood has been shot through and discarded into the street like nothing. “I’m so sorry you guys.” Adora startles them, and gives little room for either of them to say anything. “He’s here for me.”

Bow finds a chance to try and stop her, but Adora talks right over him.

“I’m going to lead him away. A couple of his men might stay and make sure I didn’t come back. Drive them out of here—they don’t belong here.”

Then, without another word spoken, Adora rides for Hordak and the three men. She rides close to them, scaring the life out of them, stopping only to make eye contact with Hordak. Then she returns to the barns, where the fight is more lively, and she shoots Adam's revolver twice into the air.

"You want me? You want Adora Grayskull? You come get her!"

It's a whole new chase after that. Even Hordak is riding out, trying to beat Swift Wind's impossible hooves, but he's finding little luck. Some of the men start shooting in their direction, but neither Adora or her horse are swayed.

Swift Wind pushes himself without fail, all the way to a swampy area Adora guesses with ease is miles away from the ranch. It'll work. The area is stuffed to the brim with trees and shallow water, long grass which stems from said water and leaks onto the shore. Fishing boats are everywhere, if she can get to one. Take herself somewhere downstream and lay low. She jumps off of Swift Wind, telling him to flee. She'll find him later. She has to.

Hordak's men are slow to enter the area, Hordak himself even slower. Adora has plenty of time to slip into the depths of some of the trees here and watch them patrol, one by one, searching what they believe is everywhere for her. Hordak isn't shy enough to show his temper when every single one of his people comes up short in the end. They scrub the rest of this area, then move on to the next in the same desperate search.

It's the waiting game now to get to that boat, watching these men poke around and ultimately find nothing. Adora begins to circle around them, using the thick vegetation to keep hidden. Mostly they're gone now, but she's not willing to risk it. When she finally does run out, there's not much choice but to stay low and start running as fast as she can.

Adora is so focused on the people around her, she forgets to account for the fact she's in the woods, a place with fishing boats which should've ticked her off to other traps in the grass. She

steps on a loose rope, which tightens significantly around her ankle and hoists her into the air. She smacks into a thick tree completely upside-down, knocking herself out the moment she makes contact.

Chapter End Notes

I'm supposed to post every last Friday of the month... oopsie

Finn Finn Finn. I love you sm

Initially my plan for Finn was to be the child of Catra and Adam, after Catra cheated on Adora to piss her off. Comphet reasons were in there as well. But let’s be realistic—Catra would never ever cheat on Adora. Like ever

Thank you so much for reading! Next chapter will be up soon :D

You'll Be in My Heart

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Crunching. Something is crunching in the grass, in the extensive vegetation which passes from one end of this swamp seemingly planted in the middle of nowhere to the other. Briefly Adora thinks of a gentle stream and a fishing boat, then her brain shuts down all over again. Then everything reboots instantly, and suddenly the sound of that crunching brings Adora to a state of hyper alertness.

Not much she can do, as she's colliding with the ground below her within the next few seconds. Her left leg, strung up for who knows how long, buzzes miserably against the solidness most harshly of all. The limb feels as if it's vibrating uncontrollably, a dull pain as blood forces itself back into the leg. Adora hears grass crunching once again, and suddenly the leg is the least of her concerns. Tall grass has engulfed her person, obscuring most of her vision. It doesn't stop her from reaching for Adam's weapon and pointing it blindly into the air in frantic self-defense.

Again twigs crunch as this other person lunges forward to grab the weapon. Adora finds she was dumb enough to leave the safety off. She shifts her leg, shooting more dullness into her person as she loses focus on the fight over her own weapon. Easily, another hand from above grabs it, tossing it aside. Forget the damn leg—Adora throws her other arm upwards, relying on her fists next.

A figure grabs both of her hands, pinning her to the ground. Staring into her eyes. Adora can't mistake them. She's traveled long and far, here to there and there and there. Seen more than most people could ever imagine, write about, read about. She has never, ever met another soul on this planet with one blue eye and one yellow eye.

From above, Catra stares down on Adora. Long, pointed nails take care not to dig into the backs of her hands, and one leg is extra careful not to bump into Adora's static limb. Catra doesn't move. Doesn't say anything. Adora can't move. She's not certain she can say anything, either. If the words come out now, they'll all be jumbled up mumbles of nonsense. Adora feels the way an insane person might, sprawled in the swamp's grass, staring up at someone who probably doesn't exist in the first place.

"You big idiot," the ghost who can't possibly be real says. "Don't shoot me." Then Catra removes herself, pushing the gun, a set in which Catra herself carries the other half, back to Adora.

Catra sits back in the grass, so casually, so relaxed. Nothing has happened between them. They are as they once were, two kids sitting around on an adventure. The black fingerless gloves on her hands meet the muddy ground beneath her ripped jeans, bending at her elbows to support her upper body. Staring down at Adora, she's making a smug expression. Right now Adora's body feels too heavy to sit up and join her. For now she'll note the way the sunlight sneaks past the long tree branches blocking most of the sky, a perfect skylight finding Catra and targeting her eyes. Her pupils are illuminated, jumping two shades lighter than normal and shimmering like stars. Nothing blocks them, and Adora takes a moment to admire eyes which are normally hidden away from sunlight.

The hat. Adora forces herself upright, perhaps too quickly for her body and mind right now, flailing her limbs around in the grass until she locates it. In the limited sunlight, the red hat finds the air between both women, silently waiting for its owner. Solid, the accessory doesn't bother to do so much as flop around the way it dangles patiently in the air.

"You really shouldn't leave your stuff on the side of the road, you know," Adora says. "Someone might take it."

"And you really shouldn't wear hats." Catra reaches forward, and the way she retrieves her hat lets her hand grace the back of

Adora's. "Your hair looks violently abused. No, not a hat person at all. You used to haul around Adam's, before you left it on his gravestone. I thought maybe mine could help you, but nope. You are doomed, I'm afraid."

All Adora can do is laugh. She can't help it. Doesn't want to help it. She laughs and laughs, feeling some sort of drug entering her system as she floods with the giddiest feeling she's ever experienced in her life. Catra is right in front of her, making jokes, and she knows she can happily die right here in the grass, feeling the most content she's ever felt in her life.

Of the two, Catra is the first to stand up. She whistles and a demon from hell runs onto the scene, a decently-sized horse so dark he practically creates a void of his own. His eyes are completely demonic, to the point where simply gazing upon them sends a piercing anxiety throughout Adora's bones. Catra says they need to head out and mounts the monster without hesitation, heading out without waiting. Adora turns and finds Catra has managed to round up Swift Wind for her. Luckily he's always been quick, catching up to the demon horse in seconds.

"You and your big rides," Catra says. She looks over Swift Wind once Adora returns to her side, giving the horse a quick glance up and down. No doubt she's gotten a better look already, if she managed to find him and lead him back. "He's almost as big as the last one."

"Twice as fast," Adora tells her. Her eyes are still caught in Catra's, whether or not they're partially obscured now by the hat. The garment hangs low on Catra's head, hiding more than it should. Adora has every right to smack into one of these trees with tragically comedic timing, but Swift Wind is too smart and too unwilling.

Silence lingers for a long while, Adora not entirely sure what to say. She's not sure what she should be feeling, too; all she can really do in this moment is stare endlessly at Catra. Part of her can't believe the two of them are riding through these trees

together, a romantic walk from a romantic book where there is no single trouble in the world big enough to interfere with a single thing in any of their lives. What a concept.

“I had the perfect escape plan, you know.” Catra breaks the silence. She’s more focused on the trees, less on the fact Adora can’t stop staring at her like she’s the world’s biggest and shiniest pile of gold. Finally she tosses a look over Adora’s direction to ask, “What is with you and screwing up my escape plans?”

“Wow, I love you, too.” Adora manages another set of laughter, and nothing really follows after it. Nothing more than Catra smiling at her, before turning her attention back onto the path in front of them both. Almost out of the swamp now, back on the main road. The whole world is in front of them, with endless possibilities. They can go anywhere. Do anything.

There is only one thing Adora wants to do, and only one place Adora wants to go. She tries to approach it the smartest way possible.

“It was always a good plan, escaping. Up in that mountain. With Finn.”

Catra stops suddenly. Apparently Adora’s plan was not as smart as she’d hoped. Catra turns to her rather quickly, clearly fighting off some sort of panic in her face. “What are you trying to do with Shadow Weaver, anyway? You went all the way to the fort, to do what? You should’ve shot her right there. No one would’ve stopped you.”

There is no answer for Adora to produce. Of course it would’ve been easy to drag Shadow Weaver away. Threaten her. Scare the life out of the woman. Apparently it would’ve been easiest to shoot her, right there. Solve all the problems; kill Shadow Weaver and run away laughing with Catra. But it didn’t happen. Adora didn’t do it.

She’s not sure she could do something like that.

After everything, after all this time, Catra hasn't gotten dumber. Hasn't managed to stay the same. She's only gotten smarter and smarter over the years, and Adora shouldn't be surprised when she manages to read her mind.

"A person—if you can call her that—like Shadow Weaver doesn't deserve your gratitude, Adora. She never has. Never will. She's not our mother, and this was never her cute little orphanage where all the kids play and grow up and walk away peacefully. But I guess you're not the only one. Not like any of us have pulled the trigger yet."

"I don't want to see the others swing. I thought maybe if I could get her to care . . ." Adora stops herself. Of course it all sounds ridiculous when she says it out loud. Even worse, she's saying something stupid in front of the smartest person in the world. "Kyle is the only person who would be safe. I was."

Left hand gripping her demon's reins tightly, Catra calls Adora an idiot again. Before continuing onward. Adora somehow recognizes the nothingness they're faced with now: it's the road she took from Bright Moon into hiding.

"Catra." The pace stops again at the simple call of a name. "Bright Moon ranch. I need to go back. Make sure they're okay. Make sure Hordak is gone for good."

"Okay," Catra agrees, and it's all so surprisingly easy it makes Adora blink in disbelief. She had no argument at the ready, so maybe it's for the best this miracle is happening before her eyes. "Let's go to Bright Moon ranch."

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A mess. Bright Moon ranch is a scattered field of horses and patrols, more than Adora can count from the trees she hides. Catra sits with her—and it's the strangest feeling ever—trying to plot something. Easily, the both of them can pinpoint Hordak, even from here. He sits in the middle of the acquisition, keeping

an eye out. It's obvious Adora is going to return, painfully obvious, and he's using the greatest weapon ever known to man: patience.

"Crazy idea," Catra finally says. She doesn't point her attention to Adora, but keeps her eyes glued on the chaos in front of them. Hordak's men have completely taken over Bright Moon ranch. For the most part the residents appear to be okay. If they're lucky, so far all that's gone wrong is a giant annoyance.

Adora's attention doesn't leave the scene either. "I'm ready for it."

"We scare the shit out of them." Catra cringes at the idea, a careless messy field of chaos of her own. It's so unlike Catra's usual ideas, it makes Adora laugh.

After the laughter, the fear begins. The pair only have one rifle and one pair of cracked binoculars. It'll have to make do. Adora has never once in her life been a sniper, but then she never imagined she'd be shooting at a whole group of cultists run by Hordak, either. Nor did she ever picture being by Catra's side ever again. At least not in a realistic sense.

Make it seem like there's a lot of them, a lot more than two. Shoot, move, shoot, move. It's the best plan Catra has. It's the only plan either of them really has, so Adora gets right to work. She chips away at the border Hordak's men and their horses have created around the perimeter of the ranch, a security fence Adora couldn't hope to set up with the low numbers at the ranch. The first rider Adora tags falls right off his horse, whether it's out of fear or she's actually managed to hit the man from a long distance range. Doesn't matter. Catra directs her to the next tree, and the next best target. As fast as possible, Adora downs the next one. Moves on. Downs another.

Following the process manages to dwindle down the numbers and rattle those who remain. Hordak sends a small group to investigate the trees themselves, thin dead branches grazing the ground. Catra finds a new place and the two are off silently, leaving Hordak's men to search for nothing. Catra and Adora

settle in a new, identical spot, just in time to hear a storm of bullets blow in. Bright Moon forces, the very people Adora invested her time into, bust out from their homes, barns, and the small merchant's stand. Every single person is armed, and every single person burns with the same fiery determination in their eyes. One person in particular, the teen who would beg Adora to pass on some of her wisdom of a life unwise, personally manages to scare Hordak off.

The riders pour out in waves, and Adora jumps on the chance to shoot near some of their horses. A fair amount of the animals swerve and skid on their own feet, yelping out in fear. Many riders try, and many riders fail to calm their supposedly war-ready steeds, the horses losing control and leading each of them off the property in a storm of anxiety and terror. Simple ranchers chase behind them, a firestorm of rage and love. These people love one another, love their home, and nothing is going to stand in their way.

One last shot as the crowd clears out. Adora's rifle, an older weapon from years and years ago, bounces against the girdle of her shoulder. She holds her posture strongly, a solid wall against the roughness of the weapon and its anger. One final bullet launches out of the weapon, landing just behind Hordak's horse. The man turns, making direct eye contact with his forced and former associate. Adora makes herself tall, staring back at him. Then, so simply, she walks away.

On the ranch, as the residents pour back into their homes and back to their jobs and lives, Glimmer and Bow aren't difficult to spot. Both wait by the front of the small cabin Adora knew as home for weeks, seemingly waiting for her to pass them by. Adora doesn't even introduce Catra. Doesn't think to. Instead she falls into a wild tornado of apologies.

"I still have money left over. I want you guys to take it for repairs." Of course she's aware neither Glimmer or Bow will easily or happily take her money, but she has to make the offer. Both of them refuse at the same time, thoroughly frustrating her.

“Not necessary,” Bow tells her. Glimmer tells her she’s silly.

“I’m going to leave, then. I’ll make sure Hordak sees me. I know he’s still watching. I can handle him. I’m the only reason he was here, anyways.” By now Swift Wind and Catra’s demon horse Melog have caught up with them, waiting patiently mere paces away.

“You’re always welcome here, you know.” Glimmer doesn’t let her leave, not yet. “None of this changes anything.”

“I know. I’m sure I’ll be back. Someday.” One foot on the pale stirrup returns Adora to her massive horse, side by side with Catra. Adora finds herself nodding at Bow and Glimmer, what feels like one last time. “Sir. Missus. Thank you for everything.”

Adora feels Hordak’s eyes on her back, locked onto her with a death grip. Like she’d ever let him take her into the grave. She returns his staring one more time, before accelerating Swift Wind’s pace, following behind Catra’s lead. They’re not done yet. They won’t be done until death finds one or both of them.

“Those are the people that found you,” Catra says. Hordak’s looming threats don’t bother her, barely faze her. It should be a step that Adora works to achieve, but she can’t help but keep Hordak in the back of her mind. “I saw them on the main road.”

It’s self-explanatory, not inspiring Adora to ask further. There is no way Hordak dumped her body where anyone could find her. She was never confident Bow and Glimmer ventured all the way to the fort’s gates to scoop up a dead body and let her bum around for weeks, never asking her for anything. However, it’s enough to move her attention from Hordak’s direction and back to Catra. Catra, who focuses on the road in front of them. She leaves little effort in steering her horse; the animal follows the soft dirt road stretching for miles, unbothered by anything around him.

“Ripped a blank page out of the novella in my jacket pocket. It was a great read, before stupid Lonnie went bursting into the war

room like an idiot.” Rolling her eyes, Catra shakes her head. Adora feels a smile stretch across her own lips, a familiar feeling when she should find herself in Catra’s vicinity. Much more familiar than the last time they met.

“Sounds about right for you and Lonnie to still be at each other’s throats after all these years.” Adora tries to make herself relaxed on her own horse now, slouching in on herself, shoulders slumping forward.

Catra offers a brief and proud smirk. Pissing people off was always a golden skill of hers. “Some things never change.”

“They were kind to me. Bow and Glimmer. Real kind.” Swift Wind appears to be automatically following the road as well, when Adora realizes she’s not doing much to direct him. It gives Adora the freedom to offer Catra all the attention she has. “You know, after you shot me.”

Growing up, things were serious. Hordak’s father, ranting and raving about the First Ones. Hordak, sulking in his tent at the camp. Shadow Weaver shaking with nerves about finances. The air was always so unsteady, so full of surprises, so rarely full of laughter. Adora would listen in the middle of the night, when Catra was doing a bulk of her obsessive reading, waiting. Listening. Periodically, it would come: quiet laughter trying its best to be muffled away. In the middle of the day, between jobs, on particularly boring days, Adora would hear it in full. A complete sound at full volume, high pitched and lively and uncaring of that which surrounds her. Catra’s laugh has never ever failed to bring some sense of joy to Adora.

There’s a first for everything. When the woman bursts into her joyous screeching, Adora frowns. When the woman looks over once over to evaluate whether or not Adora is joking, Adora wants to push her off her horse. “It was rifle ammo, yes. The same ammo as Adam’s guns, yes. But it was an actual rifle. From far away. If I shot you from as close as I was, there is no earthly way

you would be walking right now." Again, she stops to laugh. "Come on, Adora."

Adora can't go anywhere. She's too busy going red in the face, far, far redder than the jacket around her shoulders or the hat on Catra's head.

"When was the last time I used a long arm? Everyone knows I hate those things. Your brother wanted to buy a fancy rifle and I talked him into the revolvers."

"You did, yeah." Adora looks forward. Her eye twitches as she begins to feel stupid.

"It was your old buddy Shadow Weaver. And then I dragged you back onto the main road." It's here Catra stops suddenly, rather conveniently, to look around. Her left arm raises, signaling Adora to stop and probably to shut up. "Okay," she says after a moment, eyebrows pointed in narrow focus, "double time. We need to get moving."

Reins slap against Melog, and Adora finds herself struggling to keep up as Catra tears through the dirt below, racing down the road. It's getting late, but they still have plenty of time before the sun checks out for the day. The road is wide and open, yet Adora has no time to ask Catra where the destination is before the road traveled begins to draw a crowd.

Trees won't save either of them now. The open road offers few of them, thin and losing life with the season. Catra spots a few boulders and main lines the both of them. Swift Wind scatters once Adora's boots hit the ground, and Catra tells her own horse to go home before running to cover as the first bullets fly in their direction. Home, like the damn horse ought to know where that is. It's no time before the shootout begins.

Chaos and violence break out in an instant, the final culmination of weeks and weeks of tension and hate. The man responsible for all of it is nowhere to be seen. It makes Adora's blood boil. He

pulled her out of her home. Made her his lapdog in the destruction of her family. Attacked the ranch just to get under her skin. Then again Hordak was never a fool; if he was here now she'd blow his head off into nothing. Instead she'll settle for his men.

Both of Adam Grayskull's revolvers are finally together once again, pulling their triggers almost simultaneously in a team effort. Adora's right hand grip and Catra's left hand grip bring the handguns closer than ever, accuracy and power anything but an issue. Some guys get too close, around this bullet-riddled boulder, and Catra gleefully releases her collection of knives one by one with a simple flick of her other wrist. Numbers dwindle. Knives fly out, bullets become empty shells. Riders fall off their horses, one by one, until finding a rider is an effort. Adora calls Swift Wind back, the work horse ready to get the hell out of here.

Catra is the one to jump on first, Adora stopping like a common fool to gather some of her discarded knives. She's left in the backseat, the job of gunner. No more alternating between revolver and rifle—Adora will keep the rifle and keep anyone and everyone far away from the pair of them. Catra remains hyper focused on the road, her eyes never leaving the trail in front of them. Occasionally she'll steer Swift Wind left and right, taking strange turns she doesn't appear to have planned in advance. At times she'll slow, looking around. Gathering resources before she continues on. She has a destination in mind, one she won't share in all this mess, and Adora hopes with everything she has it isn't the fort. After all this, she needs a quiet place with no one around for miles. Adora watches as a mountain in the distance grows bigger and bigger, closer and closer.

"You should've killed Shadow Weaver." Catra's voice is loud, traveling over the sound of Swift Wind's giant hooves slamming against the pavement. None of the Horde's fancy uniforms are visible right now, but Adora doesn't want to risk the chance. She won't relax, not just yet. "She didn't hesitate for you. Would've gotten Hordak the fuck off your back."

Nope, Adora's not sharing who her other assigned target was just yet.

"She used the same caliber as Adam, just to be doubly bitchy. Took it out some new guy's hands." Here, Catra shoots a look over her shoulder. She's grinning in a way full of humor, in a way that brings dread to Adora. "But you thought it was me."

The dread quickly doubles. Adora's face twists up into a sour expression, and she swears her face is getting hot. "Yes."

There's a small shake of the head when Catra says, "I love you, too."

More and more the mountain grows, and more and more Adora finds herself shivering once again. Her body seems to be the only thing she has left at times, and with all this weather-hopping she fears even her own skin might get up and leave her behind. Swift Wind soldiers on, probably feeling the same frustration with her. Swift Wind.

"Hey," Adora says, finally allowing her eyes to leave every possible angle around them, "can you pass me my horse back?" In a way, this is it. This is her vague way of asking where exactly they're going. So far, the fort is in the totally opposite direction. If this is the long way, she's not confident she'll survive it. The question in itself makes her want to smack herself in the back of the head, but she's certain Catra is about to do it for her.

"Can you stop crushing my ribs?" Catra tosses over her shoulder. Adora doesn't bother to loosen her grip, rather lets go completely, successfully and instantly freaking Catra out the way they're going full speed on a fast horse. "Hey, if you fall, I'm not fixing your broken neck!"

When Adora doesn't bother to place her arms back, Catra reaches blindly behind herself and slaps Adora's arms until they return. Happily, Adora jumps at the chance, "Well geez, I didn't realize

you were so touch deprived, Catra. I ain't been gone that long, have I now?"

"Oh wow, I wish you fell off the damn horse."

"Are you sure Melog will be okay, by the way?"

"Melog knows what to do." Right, because he's a horse. How silly of her to assume otherwise. "He's been here a million times."

There's her chance! Right out in the open! "Where is 'here', exactly?"

Chance fails when Catra goes silent. It was to be expected. It's the exact reason Adora didn't want to flat out ask the question. But then again, what were the chances of her successfully tricking Catra for information? Apparently she *has* been out forever.

"How was it? You mentioned a ranch." She's read Adora's mind, and Adora isn't surprised how it's a super power Catra has managed to acquire. It was only a matter of time. If not telepathy, her other super power hasn't managed to fizzle out after all this time: Adora can't be anything but honest with her.

"It was horrible. I stayed on the warden's good side as much as possible. Kissed his ass until I could taste it in the back of my throat. He let me out early, serve some community service to make up for it. He had a family ranch needed some tending. One of the workers there was this crazy old lady. Razz. She was nice enough."

Catra's head turns slightly again, trying as best as possible to face Adora in proper conversation. "Doesn't sound too bad. But then you've always been stubborn and tougher than a bull."

"Not the bad part. I am tough, and I sure am stubborn. I think that's where the hard part came from. I made a small profit from the ranch I was allowed to keep. I bought a bunch of journals, and I bought the newspaper from town almost every day. I looked everywhere, Catra. To the best of my ability. For Shadow Weaver,

her birth name, Hordak—you, most importantly—anything. I never saw anything. First thing I did was go back to the mountain. Our old cabin. It was cleaned out."

"I knew moving was a stupid ass idea." It's all Catra says for the rest of the ride. There isn't much desire from either of them to carry on this conversation right now, certainly not while sprinting on a horse and certainly not in the plummeting temperatures. Adora doesn't even care where they're going anymore. This is the place she's worked so hard to be, and she decides she's more than happy with it.

Land around them passes in a blur as Swift Wind lives up to his name, running faster than Catra appears to have anticipated. Sun still has some air time left. If they weren't going so fast Adora might pull out her journal and start drawing everything in sight. The landscape swaps from boring dirt nothingness—which somehow also manages to be a wonderful and beautiful sight—to narrow roads and thick crops of trees. Here, Catra begins to slow Swift Wind down, though the horse doesn't seem excited to do so. She pivots them all for the woods themselves, following absolutely no path, checking behind them before she expertly navigates them through the mess. Swift Wind is slowed nearly to a halt, something he's definitely not pleased about. Adora wonders when he became such a sprinting addict. Adora counts about a dozen similar looking trunks until she sees one marked off, high up. A thick branch covers half of the giant X someone has carved deeply. Catra stops them here, Adora's horse snorting about it.

"We should be safe here. It's probably the safest place in the world." There is no doubt Catra's checked these facts and statistics three times over. Catra doesn't turn at all now while she speaks, just stares ahead. Adora doesn't follow her eyes. Instead she follows the death grip Catra has on the reins, veins popping out of her left hand with her fingers fully flexed shut.

It's a huge, silent moment before Catra slowly moves them onward, escaping the trees for what Adora can only regard as a forgotten paradise; a lone cabin in the middle of all this chaos,

attached to a flowing pond and a small stable that Melog is already in. Adora has to squint to be sure—how did the horse know to come here? And how did he get here before they did? He just stares back at Adora like she's insane. She must be, if she's seeing self-driving horses.

"Only two people ever come here," Catra continues. She allows another big pause between her words, and Adora just sits here on the back of her own horse and soaks in it. Not exactly sure what else to say or do. Mostly she's afraid she's going to ruin whatever it is Catra's trying to tell her. The remaining parts of her person are afraid for a million different reasons at once. "Me," she stops again, making sure she has Adora's full attention, "and Finn."

There was a time in Adora's life, when she was much, much younger, in the early stages of learning to ride horses. Somehow Hordak was convinced to take up the task of training all the kids. He wasn't a special rider. Didn't have a special talent. Maybe Shadow Weaver was hoping and praying he'd get lost and never come back, and she was willing to sacrifice all the kids over it. Hordak decided to take them all through the hiking trails near their camp, in the midst of summer. He knew there were going to be snakes prowling, and he didn't tell anyone a thing. Adam didn't think of it. Catra didn't think of it, though she barely wanted to be there to be taught by Hordak of all people. Adora certainly didn't think of snakes. Eventually the horse she started out with spotted one, instantly broke into a rage of terror, and threw her off backwards. She won't forget the feeling of her spine meeting the dirt below, reverberating throughout her body, shaking every single one of her bones. Swearing all of her organs collapsed and imploded together at the same time. The only thing that hurt worse than that—in a physical sense—was being shot so many times.

Yet, none of these things can hope to stack against the feeling she holds in this moment. Suddenly the full and complete weight of ten years apart hits her all at once. No Catra for a decade. No gang. Not much of anything but dread and pure depression in itself. Ten years marinating in the mystery of whether or not the

child she and Catra took in was still alive. She's missed ten years of Finn's life.

She sees the child in the window from here, and right away Adora starts shaking like a leaf. She doesn't notice the fact Catra has dismounted the horse. Or the fact the horse is hitched in front of the house. Or the fact Catra's hand is outstretched, waiting for Adora to take and descend. Frozen in time, Adora forgets how to breathe. Her chest aches, pressing into itself, and her head feels heavy enough to fall right off and roll into the woods.

It's all she can think about, so it's all she can say. "I have not seen Finn in a very long time."

As always, Catra is quick. She knows what's coming, she knows Adora better than any living being on this earth despite what time has tried to do to them both, and she's ready to pounce on the defense. Her empty hand meets Adora's knee where she's still perched high in the air, watching a curly-haired child read a rather lengthy book. Alone. Finn is alone right now. "Hey, Finn never forgot you. I would never let them. Trust me. It won't be awkward, I promise you. Please Adora, please trust me."

She manages the effort of getting off the horse. It places about three hundred pounds onto her feet, which remain frozen on the front porch. The polar opposite of that horse before it bucked her off and ran onto the trails alone. Adora swears she can hear Hordak laughing and calling her a fool. She can hear Shadow Weaver as clear as ever, asking her why she's being such a coward. She wasn't raised this way.

"It'll be fine," Catra says again. From the door she waits for Adora to take those two steps and close the distance, and once Adora is close enough Catra outstretches her hand once again. A warm smile falls upon her lips, a sight Adora goes crazy staring at. "Come on."

Catra's hand is slender, no different from when Adora last saw her. A glove made of a thin layer of leather swallows most of her hand,

leaving her fingers free to the world. Her wrists are barely visible from underneath the black jacket which swallows the majority of Catra's torso. It won't do much for her once winter rolls in, namely in a place so close to the mountains which create a giant border for the countryside. Somewhere north in one of the giant formations is where Frosta and her people call home, likely unbothered by the temperatures freezing Adora's bones.

Staring at the hand beckoning to her, Adora has to force her eyes into Catra's. She knows her own eyes are blown wide right now, unsure how to blink and unsure how to return to a normal human size. Adora forces her hand forward, some part of her brain waking up again, and Catra finishes the rest. It's a firm grip she chooses, her long black nails digging softly into the skin on the back of Adora's hand.

With one huge breath for confidence, Adora allows Catra to lead her into the cabin. Catra is kind enough to leave her by the door to breathe. Breathing isn't as easy as it's made up to be.

This new cabin is in much better shape than the original they all lived in. Beneath Adora's boots, the wood appears to be newer in some places, slightly off-color. Repairs were done. Either the cabin faced difficult times with Catra and Finn in it, or Catra happened upon another beautiful home in the middle of perfect nowhere. Unlike their previous home, this one has decorations and nice-looking furniture. A fireplace burns and if Adora weren't so terrified of the universe right now she might sprint over there and put life back into her bones. Photos hang down the hall leading to the kitchen, which splits off into a large lounging area, another hall continuing ahead presumably for rooms. A ladder hangs at the end of the hall, leading somewhere above. The cabin didn't look too tall. Probably storage.

Adora finds pictures of herself on the wall. Photos she and Catra had done professionally when extra money was rolling in. Catra had some photos done of Finn, and Adora's eyes immediately dart away, as if not to spoil the child's current appearance. She's not sure she wants to know how big Finn is now. Most curiously:

someone has made perfect sketches of the family, framed and preserved. Catra can draw, though not in this level of detail. Finn is an artist?

Finn. One of Finn's mothers, the one more familiar to the child, goes into the lounge. Tells them to go to the door, not much else. Catra doesn't move. She waits at the end of this part of the hallway, crossing her arms. She's got a cheeky expression to her, like she knows Adora is two breaths from passing out and she wants to get a full view of it. She was always such a little shit, and it's always been one of Adora's favorite things about her.

Finn. The child stands next to their familiar mother, perhaps their only mother at this point, perfectly still in the hall. Adora can't move. She's been frozen, frozen right to the bone and she's a perfect candidate for hypothermia. If someone were to touch her right now she'd crumble to nothing on the perfectly repaired wood, the light brown shade of the floors reflecting off the candle light mounted to the walls and made into a chandelier in the middle of the house. Everything is so bright, everything is so perfect and wonderful and everything Adora's ever wanted, she can feel her soul detaching from her body and ascending, finding no other reason to stay on this earth any longer.

This is everything she's been fighting for. For ten years, this has been everything.

Everything stares back at her, tilting its curious and youthful little head at her. Finn has maintained a perfect circle of brown fluff which matches the last time Adora saw them, an exact copy of the wild mane on Catra's own head. Bright blue eyes, bright diamonds, an endless sea even the likes of someone with Mermista's skill could not manage to navigate, stare back at Adora. A pen drops from a small hand, clattering against a patterned rug on the floor. A little red bandana tied around Finn's neck—nothing Adora ever gave them, definitely something they picked up as they've grown over time—bounces up and down as bare feet clap against the sanded wood.

“Adora!”

A body so small, half Adora’s size, collides with her, somehow managing to nearly knock her off her feet. Finn is warm from the fire, and it seeps into the deepest crevices of Adora’s bones, bringing her back to the land of the living, bringing her back to this tall and strong figure Finn has depicted there on the walls. She forces her weak legs into a squat, placing one hand on the back of Finn’s head and holding them as tightly as possible. Medium-long hair, almost Adam’s length.

“Hi, Finn.”

Eventually, and unfortunately, Adora has to untuck her face from the child’s shoulder to breathe. Somehow she’s managed not to cry, but when she finds Finn’s face, her little Finn’s face, right within arm’s reach, she feels everything start to pool up. She grazes a thumb across their cheek, watching as something in their eyes starts to fog up. Then, with childish energy, Finn grabs her hand and starts leading Adora farther into the house, telling her she needs to get the tour. She hasn’t been here yet, and Finn tells her they want her to feel at home.

All those times Adora has pulled Swift Wind around by his reins, now she’s the one being led around by the hand. Adora finds the kitchen first, a wide space perfect for cooking anything and everything, complete with a small table resting in the corner. The counters are made of what she presumes are the same wood, finished with a soft red color. Not a dish can be found in the rather deep sink, and Finn immediately takes credit once Adora’s eyes move in that direction. Some larger cooking pots are resting on the floor against the wall at the edge of the counter, likely to be used over the wide fireplace. A large blue couch is placed in front of it, and between the couch and the fire is a mess of papers. Finn *is* the artist decorating the walls. They have Adora sit, showing her the entire portfolio.

The shading work in itself is incredible in each of the works. Horses running. A man standing at a creek, pole in hand. Catra

running around on Melog with her gun drawn, an absolute badass from one of those silly westerns she used to read. Adora finds the books as well, stacked on the couch and scattered around underneath the table. Light from outside has officially disappeared, the firelight popping the pictures to life in a new way. Adora finds a few portraits of herself, and something in her stomach relaxes. She's always had a presence here. She's always been here, even when she wasn't.

"I can show you more tomorrow!" Finn says. They start piling the mess together, trying to tidy up in a rather unorganized way. They grab the pile and tap it against the table, straightening out the pile before setting it aside in a corner. "It's getting late. And between you and me, Mama gets grumpy when it's too late."

All Catra can really do is glare at them as they run off to their room, giggling. Adora stays on the ground. The wound on her side periodically becomes irritated, especially on a day like today, but right now, in this moment, it's as if it never happened. All pain is completely gone, so far away she can barely remember it happening at all. All Adora can really do is become fascinated with the glare of the fireplace. Flames bounce here and there, up and down, sometimes diagonally and sometimes left to right. The fire isn't mad, isn't disturbed; it's a small energy of life and Adora cannot keep her eyes off of it. She's finally gotten her life back, and a thousand thoughts fly through her mind at the same time.

A hand meets her vision, asking her to rise to her feet. Catra leads her to the end of the hall, just before that ladder, and takes Adora to a bed she will forever call hers. Hers, and Catra's.

"You must be exhausted."

Adora wants clarification—from the day? From these past few weeks? From searching endlessly for ten years?

"From everything, to be more specific." Mind reading: Catra's greatest skill. She removes her black jacket, hanging it on a hook on the back of the door. Another empty hook waits, and Catra

wastes no time in walking over to retrieve Adora's fringe jacket. First she reaches inside, into the inside pockets, thoroughly freaking Adora out, and pulling out knives. Knives Adora gathered in the middle of an active shootout. All the rifling around finished, Catra smiles and thanks her before getting to work on removing her boots. The sight of them finally wakes up Adora's brain.

"Hey, what happened to the *very* strict no shoes in the house policy? I used to get yelled at for that!"

"You should get yelled at for that! All you do is track mud!" Catra kicks one of her boots off, flicking her foot and successfully hitting Adora in the shin with it. "Besides, today was a special occasion. But next time—next time I'll make you sleep outside. With Melog. And he snores."

"Oh, so do you." Catra rolls her eyes at the smug expression Adora makes. She takes the cue to remove her boots, not particularly muddy today, and places her jacket on the hook. Next to Catra's. All her stuff is next to Catra's, in the same room, in a safe, remote cabin. Their child is across the hall, safe and sleeping soundly.

Catra opens up a few drawers on Adora's side of the room, revealing some of her old clothes. "Please don't sleep in jeans," Catra tells her. "And yes, you have to wear pants. I'm not getting you another blanket!"

"I think I've gotten wimpy over the years," Adora admits. "Remember? I used to go outside in the snow with almost nothing on?"

"No one ever said there was a brain in there." Catra shucks her knives right off, placing one half of Adam's revolver on a dresser next to them. Adora mirrors the same. Then she puts everything back on, running outside to take all her stuff off of Swift Wind so he can have a relaxing night, too. One horse, pale as the sun, the other, dark as night. Catra has a handful of jokes about forgetfulness when she returns.

Catra waits for her, barely looking up from the book already in hand. Adora asks what it's about and Catra starts laughing incoherently until she can catch her breath and say it's about one man's life-changing journey in the Horde.

"Did Prime author that one?" Adora places her boots in the corner, already kicked off, and returns her coat next to Catra's. Clothes are removed rather quickly as she finds herself impatient to meet this new bed and drift into the deepest sleep of her life. More importantly: someone will be by her side.

Her entrance to the bed brings Catra to set the book aside, not placing any sort of marker in it. Always, she's had the skill of remembering the exact page and the exact paragraph she'd left off on. Useful, considering there weren't often times she was willfully pulled from the book in her hand. Adora feels every bone in her body relax at once, uncoiling themselves from where they've tightly constricted around her innocent spine, strangling exhaustion into her vertebrae, spreading into her organs. Everything instantly falls sore, imploding before completely relaxing. Catra shifts next to her, lying by her side. Adora flops onto her side. The two are face to face now, soft candlelight illuminating one another's features.

"Funny seeing you here." Catra's voice is soft. Sleepy. With her eyes closed she warns, "You should probably let your hair down, dummy."

Adora blinks slowly in response. Her brain is slowing to a stop, finding little purpose in functioning. Right now, in this place, she finds little reason to use it at all. "So Finn is an artist like me, huh?"

One hand squeezes hers. Catra grins.

"How did you find this place? It's beautiful." Adora feels her eyes close. She can't help it now.

"I had to compromise Finn." Adora's eyes shoot open. "Sorry. There was this new guy who fucked up a job before he got shot in the back. I think Rogelio was going to do it anyway, to be honest. We had to pack up and leave in a hurry. Too far from Finn. Shadow Weaver knows now."

Catra shifts, settling on her back now.

"Lonnie told me about it, actually. She went to rob some houses out here. This cabin was abandoned, had nothing in it."

"That's funny." Adora turns now, facing the ceiling as well. "I thought Lonnie hated your guts."

"She had some sympathy. She and Rogelio had lost a kid. Or I guess, Lonnie, Rogelio, and *Kyle* . How the fuck someone like Kyle gets two partners is beyond me."

"I would say he has a nice personality, but not really."

"He doesn't have any nice anything. At least it didn't kill Lonnie, though. Not like Teela." Catra's head turns, though Adora doesn't turn to meet her. Ceiling stays in focus. "Hey, I visited Adam's grave a few months ago. Every time it's your birthday, I take Finn out there. Hat never blew away."

Adora feels herself grinning a little. "Good. I tied that thing down with everything I had."

"I took Finn out here right away," Catra says. "Apparently I was appreciative of Lonnie. Bought some lumber. Fixed the place up. They helped, too. Melog hauled all the shit. You always said you wanted a coat hanger so I got you a damn coat hanger, you needy asshole."

"My coat appreciates it." Adora finally glances over, flashing some teeth. "Go on, tell me more about the house."

She falls asleep, hearing tales of hauling. Hard work lifting heavy planks. Teaching Finn the math behind the calculations. Teaching

Finn to use the tools. Building a home for their family, despite one member being far, far apart.

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"Come on, you big huge guy. Sit still." The chances of one of the biggest deer Adora had ever seen in her life? Showing up barely a mile from the cabin? What were the odds? Maybe Catra would look at this beast and forgive Adora for accidentally waking her up in the middle of the night. She'd always been a klutz.

The deer continued to pace around, nipping at tall strands of grass. Nowhere to be. No tired girls waiting for him back home. No hyperactive, newly-walking infants to chase after.

Rifle bucked back by the power of Adora's finger, kicking her solidly in the shoulder. It's a feeling she'd had years and years to get used to. It's the acquisition of her brother's much smaller gun she needed to balance herself out to. It shot like nothing, a toy with the same killing power as her rifle. Though, in this golden moment, not enough killing power to take down an entire deer. Her shot was perfectly placed, downing the animal in two quick fires. She ran over to the half-dead animal as quickly as possible to finish it off, to put it out of its misery, but someone else had beaten her to it. Then they so boldly exited the trees, pointing a weapon at her. Adora returned the same aggression, doing all the talking with the front of her oldest weapon.

Lonnie was on the other side of the gun, unamused. All Adora did was laugh and push her weapon down. Lonnie followed, mirroring the action. She never hopped onto the laughing train. Nothing about this crazy coincidence, running into each other in the middle of literal nowhere, brought even a tiny small to her lips. Frown. Nothing else.

"You're lucky I'm not the trigger happy type," Adora said. Anything to get them out of this strange, silent loop of staring.

“You guys have been gone a long while.” Lonnie placed her palm against her handgun, holding Adora’s eyes with unrelenting attention. “We could use your help back at camp.”

No way Lonnie was out here for a house call—the others were probably running out of food. Worse yet, hunting grounds altogether. Adora felt the panic set in. She hid her need to rub her fingers together from this person she’d grown up with, lest she be discovered a liar. Instead she decided to quietly sweat from a distance. “Catra and I wanted to get away. Go on a hunting trip. But the weather screwed us over. Catra got awful sick. Didn’t want to bring it back to camp.”

Lonnie had crossed her arms, thinking the concept over. “She *must* be sick if she’s being so thoughtful.” Forcefully, Adora wheezed out a laugh.

With no complications, Lonnie left the scene. Returned to camp. Promised not to say anything. With no complications, Adora dragged a large animal back to her home. The idea of that cabin remaining her home made her anxious. The camp was expecting them. Now someone knew where they were. Would Finn be able to survive a big move? Finn barely survived the rest of that storm. All of them did.

All sorts of people came and went from the camp. Double Trouble did it all the time. But Catra and Adora weren’t Double Trouble. They were certified, concrete members, two children who grew up in the gang with nowhere else to go. Big players in the day-to-day of the group’s functions.

Catra met Adora at the door, immediately calling her an idiot for dragging the animal by hand all this way instead of getting a horse. Finn ran around the open space of the cabin in the background, giggling.

Looking right at her, panting and gasping for breath, Adora told Catra, “You are so supportive. I love you.”

“I’m aware.” Catra squinted at her briefly, before her eyes fell on the deer again. “Damn, he’s big.”

“Hey! Say it back.” Of course in response Catra had tested Adora’s patience, silently staring back at her with a tilted head and a thinking expression. “Fine, I’ll just throw this deer back into the wilderness.”

“I do love you! More than anything or anyone else. But only because I’m hungry.”

Adora had looked into the house, finding her child just in time to watch them fall over and giggle even harder. “Haha, Finn, she loves me more.”

“It’s okay,” Catra says, ”Finn won’t remember this conversation. Would you like to take that deer out back now, or are you exhausted from the world’s worst idea?”

“About the deer, actually. Um, I, uh. I ran into someone.” There’s no cute way to word any of it. No big presentation. No big moment. Adora wasn’t shy with the truth, not in that moment. “I saw Lonnie.”

Immediately, Catra’s jaw clenched hard enough to break her abnormally sharp teeth. “Shit. Damn it. How did she know?”

“We both happened to pick the right deer. Sounds like they’re struggling.”

“Probably doing better than us. This is the first big score in how long?” Catra sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose. “What did she say?”

“Nothing much. I told her you were sick and we were on a hunting trip. She’ll see we’re left alone. But for how long?”

It brought in a new, upsetting reality: they were not surviving out here. They weren’t going to survive out here, not without a little help. This cabin was not going to be their forever home, as

beautiful and magical it was to live in the middle of nothing. Finn was only getting older. The older the child was going to get, the more they would need to pull together. Already, Finn's infant years were so miserable.

They took the first risk together. Left Finn in their repaired crib for a few hours. Select members didn't live in the camp, but dropped by every so often. None of the children so graciously raised by Shadow Weaver did. Now, not anymore. Catra and Adora lingered around camp, taking advantage of money-making opportunities as often as possible. As Finn grew, it became easier and easier. Shadow Weaver regarded them as disrespectful. For the first time in her life, Adora didn't care.

Yet, Adora found herself taking care of the camp. Gathering extra food. Contributing funds. Feeling guilty about leaving. It drove Catra crazy, and in turn boiled both of their blood. Catra finds a few honest jobs. Adora never tries.

"Why are you so hesitant?" Catra had asked her loudly one night. "You don't owe her anything. Stop helping her, Adora. You've always done this. She doesn't own you anymore. It's the three of us now, no one else."

She couldn't see the true purpose of the child, and it nearly destroyed everything. They were young, broke, and stupid. Catra told her she was being noble and valorant to the wrong cause, and they didn't speak for weeks. Through it all, Adora could not admit once she did not want the child.

But damn did Finn make her nervous.

A real job fell into Adora's lap. Money started pouring in. Repairs and upgrades were poured into the house. Finn was only growing and growing, getting into mischief and trouble. Something about all of it was the greatest feeling of Adora's life. Shadow Weaver finally escaped her, the absence of the woman as effective as a clear mind after extended sobriety. She'd visit the camp on occasion, never leaving a dime.

“We can’t get married without clearing our bounties first, you know that.” Catra faced Adora in bed that night, staring into her eyes, and Adora started right back. “There is no way I’m doing a little fake marriage, either. It shouldn’t be a secret.”

It became a big, shiny fantasy, though not new to either of them. Being married. Being at peace, together and alone. Shadow Weaver proposed a plan to rob a train passing through town. The payout would be hefty enough to save them all.

Catra showed Adora a bigger plan: rob Shadow Weaver’s personal stash, the big pile of money she’d sat on for years. The “emergency fund”, the stash that never existed, the buried box that was none of anyone’s business. The last thing either of them suspected was to be surrounded by the law already on the gang’s tail from a failed job. Hordak’s lungs yelled louder than anyone thought was possible. He was the one who messed the job up. Shadow Weaver’s gun shut him up. The scene blew up in a foggy instant.

“Forget the money!” Catra had told her. For the first time in her life, Adora didn’t listen.

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Adora wakes, listening.

“Finn, you’d better not be by that door again.”

Eyes don’t open yet. Adora reaches over, curious at the low volume of Catra’s voice, and finds she’s alone in the bed. She succumbs to the real world, opening her eyes. The clock overhead says 10AM. She slept for twelve hours?

“Mama,” Finn whines, “what if she’s lonely in there?” Adora considers she’ll never be lonely ever again, and grins.

“Oh, is this chocolate on the counter for me?”

Quiet, smaller, lower-impact feet skid across the floor, disappearing from the hall. The shadow Finn has made underneath the door is gone, and Adora opens her ears. Her grin fades as her muscles relax, though it does not disappear. “Hey! Those are for Adora! And so is breakfast!”

Food. Adora practically jumps out of bed, forgetting her boots and happily forgetting her coat on the door. The cabin is warm despite this new region and elevation they’ve landed now, stable and safe and pleasant. Outside the room Adora finds Catra, fully dressed for the day and already halfway through last night’s book. Finn goes ear-to-ear in a bright grin, excitedly telling Adora about all the food they made and the chocolates Catra brought in from town a few days ago.

“Be careful Finn,” Catra says. “Adora is scrawny, but she’s also a black hole. It’s genetic, I think.”

Adora doesn’t mind the teasing. But she does remember the gang member they held briefly, one who would refuse what few meals the group brought in because they were worried about their “figure”. Adam used to steal their untouched meals, happily. Finn’s massive feast of eggs, bacon, and a giant pile of hash browns disappears before all of their eyes, and from the couch Catra snickers to herself. Finn is in awe, as if Adora had just done the most impressive thing ever.

The couch is the second most comfortable thing Adora’s ever been on, secondary only to the bed down the hall. “What’s the plan for today, forest people?” The moment she asks the question Finn is excitedly running to their room, saying they need their journal. Adora turns to Catra.

Catra places the novel in her hands aside, next to an empty glass on a small table hugging the couch. Both her feet are resting on the table, careful not to interfere with the items Finn set aside last night. “I’ve had something brewing for a while now. It won’t sound foreign to you.” Catra’s eyes reflect in the fire in front of

them both. Flames in a blue eye, flames in a yellow eye. “Shadow Weaver’s stash.”

“So a long while, then.” Adora swings one of her feet onto the table as well, but not without accidentally bumping her toes on the underside of the furniture. “There is no way she’s still hauling around that little box. You know what, I take that back, it’s Shadow Weaver. How can you be sure it’ll work this time?”

“Everyone hates her. Well, *openly* now. I just need everyone to turn around for a second. I think I know exactly when to do it.” She turns to Adora, looking at her now. “Catch a boat from Salineas or somewhere.”

Instantly, Adora bursts into laughter. There’s nothing in this world Catra hates more than water, and she doesn’t need to do so much as point this fact out for Catra to understand the humor.

“Anything to get the hell out of the Fright Zone, okay?” Catra says. “You’re such an asshole!”

“Yeah, but you love it.”

Catra shakes her head, but she finally joins in on the laughter. Can’t fight it anymore. After a moment she says again, “I do have to go see Shadow Weaver today, though. Stay on her good side before I shove a knife into it. I could use your help with all the planning. I saw you scouting the fort out every night.”

“What, and you couldn’t bring me a blanket? I’ll come up with something.”

Finn comes running back into the room with great timing, a rather large notebook over their head as they run down the hall. “Journal!”

They look so amped up, Catra starts frowning when she has to deliver the news. The most she can do when Finn’s face turns upside-down is offer something. More chocolate. Whatever else they want.

“It’s okay,” Finn says. “I’ll see you later.”

“Hey, but you have Adora now!” Catra is kneeling with the child now, placing one of her hands against Finn’s shoulder. “I’ll be back in a couple days, okay?”

The notebook looks even bigger in the child’s small hands now, held in front of them. “Okay.”

It’s a swift exit from here. Catra has her things packed already. She’s never been stupid, never been anything near average. She tries to leave quickly, before feelings and emotions can get in the way of the grand plan. Some time is spared when she stops by Adora, who finds herself by the door. “I really wanted to spend the day with you today. I’m sorry.”

“Don’t worry about it.” Adora grabs Catra’s hat off one of the hooks by the door, placing it on Catra’s head for her. “We’ll have more days.”

Catra leaves, practically forcing her mind not to change. On the couch, head bowed into the giant notebook, sits Finn. Just Adora and Finn now. thank the stars the child is overly welcoming of Adora. She’s not sure what she’d do if things were about to get awkward. Probably run outside and chase after Catra. Instead she makes her way in the opposite direction, joining Finn. A two-column list of items decorates the page, almost stretching from top to bottom of the extended lines. Some cartoony doodles are scattered around the space.

Learn to ride | learn to fish

Go camping | See a bear!

“What’s that there?” Adora asks. Luckily Finn is about as shy as Catra. They flop backwards, tilting the notebook closer in Adora’s

direction for her to see. Part of the book is in Adora's lap, and she supports it with one of her free hands.

"My book. These are all things I want to do. Mama always says no. It's not safe yet. It's never safe yet. Sometimes we go into town together. Mama says I don't need any of this, but I want to learn. I want to be like the both of you!"

Nope, no way Adora wants Finn to turn into her or Catra. Still . . .

"I read about all these things, but it's not the same. What's it like riding a horse, Adora?"

One more time, her eyes go over the list. Simple things. See the ocean, pet a dog. Finn is never away from this cabin, and the mere idea of such a thing makes Adora want to storm into the camp right now and shoot down Shadow Weaver for herself. Finn's life was supposed to be different. She takes the child's book, reading the list over once more.

"Finn, we can do this now. While your mama's out. Let's do it." Finn was never bothered to break out, to rebel, to go do their own thing when Catra said no. Must be Adora's child. They perk up, shooting their spine into a perfect posture with shoulders rolled back.

"Really?" they ask, and Adora can't help her smile.

"Go pack a bag. Finn, let's go camping!"

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In retrospect, going so far away was a good idea. Somewhere warmer. Somewhere a little more open, for the horse lessons. Adora knows of a hunting grounds near here she once frequented with her brother, a place she will now share with her child. Unfortunately, this place she has chosen to stuff ten years away into a massive montage of catching up is rather far from the cabin. If something happens, if Catra needs either of them, she

won’t know where they are. Not like Swift Wind can sprout wings and fly back to the cabin.

Everything will be fine. Everything will be fine.

Everything better fucking be fine.

“Look at that bird! He’s massive!”

One of the arms wrapped around Adora’s torso leaves her person, pointing above. An eagle sours overhead, its wide wingspan driving them through the air at high speeds. Adora sees the animal dive into the woods and wonders if they’ll run into it later. Maybe they can all have lunch or something.

“Excuse me,” Adora says over her shoulder, “didn’t I tell you to hang on?”

“I am hanging on! I’m strong. I’m not gonna fly away!”

“If you say so.” Adora pushes the horse forward, galloping at a light pace. Swift Wind seems to be enjoying the weather. That, or he’s extremely impatient and was cooped up all night. “Anywhere you want to stop and make camp for the night, world’s strongest human?”

“Hmm.” There is no response. Adora glances behind herself, watching Finn’s head on a swivel. The land she’s returned to is just the way she remembers: bright green grass, almost avocado shaded; tall trees hugging a small den for many to stop and rest for the night; deer and rabbits, roaming freely until they shyly move on elsewhere; the sun, bright and warm and protective. Some of the vegetation is trimmed down, probably snacked on by one of the wildlife here. The closer to the trees, the shorter the length. No one really travels around here anymore. There aren’t many towns around this area, nothing to see and no reason to be out here. The animals are a little bolder, perhaps a little tougher, but ultimately less trusting. None should come near Adora or Finn. Some might venture out far from the trees, but any signs of

something as strange as two random humans should be scary enough.

Silence, then humming. Finn thinks long and hard about the location, a child of education and strategy and backup plans and the overall live-saving importance of intelligence instilled within them. Catra's child. They want something perfect, or something close to it. Something smart, something both safe and useful. Finn makes a decision, extending their small limb past Adora's figure, pointing out into the distance.

"Riiiight there."

Some rocks rest near the area, making for a flatter surface. The buzzed grass here interferes more with the stubborn earth. Plenty of sunlight, but not too much; some of the trees block off direct contact, shading a spot into an almost complete and perfect circle. Approaching closer, Adora can hear water trickling nearby. Not a bad choice.

"Okay, Finn, we got our spot." She pulls Swift Wind near the area, dismounting once the rocks click underneath the horse's hooves. "Did you narrow your list down? What do you want to do first?" Of course Adora would love to ride them all the way out to Salineas to see the ocean, but it just won't work with the time they have. Luckily, they will have plenty more chances in the future to get it done. There's nothing she can do about Finn wanting to be eight feet tall, either. She helps the child off the horse, carefully lifting them until their feet rest with Swift Wind's hooves against the solid and sturdy rock.

"I think I can cross off half the list already!" They grab the book out of Adora's satchel from Bow, crossing off two or three things. "I want to fish, camp, learn how to ride, and hunt. Ride first?"

Adora runs the items through her head. Ride first, hunt for the rest of the day. Camp tonight. Fish tomorrow morning and then head home. Maybe let Finn take the reins on the way back for a bit. She's carefully marked the map in her satchel where they

need to go, though the easiest thing in the world is to ride for the giant mountain in the distance. Hopefully Catra doesn't get back early and have a heart attack. Why didn't Adora think to leave a note or something?

"We can ride first," she says. Let's unpack all our stuff. There doesn't seem to be anyone here, but we won't be going too far."

Swift Wind waits patiently. Once the lessons are done and the hunting begins, Adora will reload all the stuff. Swift Wind is an expert with hunting. Helping Adora's only child learn how to ride? Questionable. Hasn't happened with the same frequency. Or at all. Swift Wind is rarely handled by other people, and a nasty knot ties itself into Adora's stomach at the thought. He seemed okay with the stable hands at Bright Moon. Netossa said he was great. Said he was patient. Maybe things will work out.

Either way, Adora tries her best to mask her fear, from both the parties she's traveled with. Finn is hoisted back up onto the horse, high and tall. Their legs just barely reach the stirrups, needing to point their toes far out to do so. Adora re-adjusts. She takes Swift Wind's lead, walking them all out somewhere a little more open. Mostly, she wants to ask her steed not to murder Finn.

"Please be careful with my child, Swifty. Please trust them." Twice she pats the animal, then she moves on to the next step: step one.

First comes the safety talk. Posture. The importance of staying calm. Luckily there won't be many dangers out here—too cold for snakes or any other hidden predators—and no one else lingers around. If they were, they would've shown themselves by now. Trust Swift Wind. Let Swift Wind return the trust. Easy on the reins. Don't use the saddle horn for balance.

"In fact, let's keep hands on the reins at all times, huh? And make sure you—"

Finn laughs. "You're nervous, Mom."

In itself, the word makes Adora's heart race. She's a mom. She's here, with her child. She's spending the day with her child, riding around on her horse in a field she practically grew up in. Everything about this moment is so crazy, so magical, so strange and weird and wonderful, it brings her lips to a wide grin. Her eyes squint slightly from the power of the sun as she looks up at Finn. "Are you ready, kid?"

Enthusiastically, Finn nods. Adora takes the biggest breath of her life. Of everything she's done, everyone she's shot and everyone who's shot back, of everything she's seen and done and run away from, this is the single most frightening thing in her life.

"Okay." Another breath. "Okay, let's get started."

All in all, things get off to a smooth start. Swift Wind carries Finn well. Down the circular grass arena they go, easy and evenly paced. Swift Wind is essentially pretending to be a show horse at this point, tall and poised and pretty and elegant. It's like he knows the importance of all this, and in a way he's showing off to impress Adora. Almost like he wants this.

With every step, Adora walks alongside the two. She's reached the point where she's ready to rip off her jacket and possibly her shirt, feeling her forehead start to soak itself. Eventually the time comes when she needs to allow Finn to go alone, to show her trust and build their confidence, and every second of it makes her sweat fifty thousand times harder. Finn rides off into the distance, touching the other end of the trees. The main road is a ways off, a targeted distance one would have to dedicate their time to. No one will cross paths with them, scare them suddenly, knock them off the road. Everything about this space is safe, yet it's the most terrified Adora's ever felt in her life.

Finn comes riding back with the biggest smile on their face, and everything about this giant, huge, horrifying risk reveals itself to be worth it.

“Did you see that!” They yell. Swift Wind looks so damn smug Adora wants to smack him on his side after all this grief. “I did it! I did it!” Then Finn imitates the same expression and Adora’s ready to yell and walk away after all this trouble. “And you were afraid.”

“I’ll turn us around, keep that up.”

“You should’ve seen your face, Mom!”

Again, the simple, three-letter word. Pauses the world in front of her. All Adora can do in response is smile like she’s gotten the best news in the world, and maybe she truly has. She motions Finn to guide the horse closer, helping them down. She hands the reins over as well, letting Finn walk the animal back to their stuff.

“Getting late.” Adora points out into the distance, right at the sun. “See how it’s sinking already? Means it’s about time for food.”

In true fashion as Adora’s child, Finn perks up.

The woods bring in a new realm, a new world, a new perspective. Adora’s been here dozens and dozens of times over the years, and each time she swears she’s being transported to another world. Sunlight filters in, sunbeams playing peek-a-boo with every step. Unfortunately, when it begins to set, neither of them can catch the view. Finn is more interested in the animals, anyhow. The secret behind the dinners they eat, the food they prepare. Finn spends a great amount of time asking about the ingredients in Adora’s breakfast, and Adora can’t keep up with the science behind them.

“Did you know there’s people out there who don’t eat meat at all?” they ask. Adora points back to the ground, asking them to help track the deer taunting them for several minutes now. Little feet scatter as they declare, “Oh! Oh, this way! He went this way! But isn’t it silly? People who won’t eat it.”

“Some foods make people sick,” Adora tries to explain. Though the thought of refusing any type of food registers through her brain as someone rather bold. “Milk makes your mama sick. Fish

used to make your Uncle Adam sick, even if he loved to fish. And your mama used to eat it in front of him to tease him."

Adora motions Finn to lower their body, crouching into cover. She points at the deer, watching Finn's eyes light up. The next set of instructions come: stay low, stay quiet. Don't scare the game away, unless starving is on the agenda. Patience is key. Most importantly: respect the animal.

"You kill fast, and if you miss, you put it out of its misery, as fast as possible." Adora makes sure Finn is watching her and paying attention. The child nods, hesitantly. Thinking over the risks and the pleasures of survival. Adora turns in the grass, keeping her feet steady against the ground. The leather of her boot bends stubbornly with her toes, a giant wrinkle blooming in the material.

Rifle kicks into her shoulder with a familiar, angry force. Finn is fascinated by the sound, a weapon with so much power in the palm of a simple human's hands. The power launches forward, taking a life away in a swift motion. Nature places Adora's hands on the carcass, dragging it back out into the open.

"Hey," Adora tells Finn, "go get Swift Wind and meet me out there. You holler if you need any help, alright?"

Finn is off, quickly, without an answer. Adora can see them hop onto the horse with the biggest smile on their face, navigating the animal through the trees. She'll let the two of them mess around. She's capable of dragging the carcass on her own.

Though by the time Adora returns to the temporary camp, she's sweating enough to find regret within herself. Then she notes the way Swift Wind seems to admire her child, and suddenly everything was worth it. "Ready to set up the camp? Get the tents, let's pitch 'em. I'll get a fire started for our friend here."

Gear rattles. Fire crackles. Adora doesn't think to grab Finn when she starts skinning the deer, and by the time she's done she's found a disappointed face staring back at her. Tents get put on

hold. Adora cooks the meal together with Finn, tucking away what she knows they both won't eat tonight. They'll bring the meat back home for Catra. Cleaning the meat. Stopping in the stream nearby to fully wash everything off, before setting it over the fire. Finn rotates the food over the heat, layering it evenly. Parts of the deer meat turn out crisp, a little charred. Yet each bite is rich and juicy, forcing Adora to salivate like a wild animal.

Before either of them are aware of the fact, the fire in front of them has stolen the spotlight. The sun is resting for the night, substituted with an artificial placeholder. It's a bit of a disappointment teaching Finn to pitch a tent in near darkness, digging around for tools with uncertainty. Then Adora remembers something wonderful: they can both do this again sometime.

For now the two will lay under what stars poke out from the open front flap, staring into the great beyond above. Adora's always wanted to go up there. From time to time she wonders if Adam got the chance to stand among the burning lights before he moved on to the next life.

"Hey, if you sleep for twelve hours again on our super awesome trip, I'll murder you."

Adora starts laughing. "Must be nice to have endless energy," she says. Finn calls her old. "That's why I'm teaching you, kid; one day I'll be an old lady and you'll be the one doing all the hunting."

"How did you even learn all this?" Finn flips onto their side, fully facing Adora. "You know how to ride and camp and hunt and do everything!"

"I don't know about *everything* . It's all a part of life, Finn."

"Then how come I never learned?"

It's best to avoid the subject entirely. Not an easy way to bring up Shadow Weaver and the law and the million other dangers in the world out to get people like Adora and Catra. "I came out here once, Finn, a long time ago. I was with your Uncle Adam. We

were lost. We didn't know what to do. We thought we were going to die out here."

"I thought there was a whole group of you?" Finn sits upright now, ready to hear the tale. Adora doesn't move at all. Too comfortable.

"Sometimes we'd split up to do different jobs. Make some extra money. Adam and I got into some trouble, and we ran as fast and far as we could. Ended up here, hiding in the trees. There is nothing out here. No towns, barely even a road, certainly no traders or other people. Couple houses. We didn't have a map. It was too late to navigate, anyhow. I knew how to make a fire. I'd read about it in one of Catra's books. It took an hour and a half, but we got it going. By morning, we were starving. Didn't have any food. Barely any bullets. Neither of us knew how to hunt, and a rusty old knife was our best bet otherwise."

Adora finally turns her head, staring up at Finn. Holding eye contact.

"We didn't grow up fair, Finn. Everything, every day, was a challenge. Every second of it was a survival situation. All this stuff —your mama doesn't want you to have to worry about it."

Naturally, the child pouts. "But I should learn, too."

"I know. But you're learning now. I'm here, to teach you."

The child returns to Adora's side, placing their body underneath the blankets Adora hauled over. "Will we ever live in a place like this? I hate being inside all day; I love outside so much."

Adora looks away. She could never tell a lie, especially not to someone she holds so dear. She could never blurt out promises she couldn't keep, either, and she feels herself sinking in dread. "You'll get there."

It's the safest response. The most honest and probable one. Finn will have a better life. Finn will be allowed to be free, nothing

holding them down with violent resistance. Nothing will ever threaten to crush their back with a thousand tons of weight, popping their muscles like zits and snapping their bones like brittle twigs in the grass. Finn will have a better life, and Adora will do anything in this world to see such a future realized.

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Everything. Catra would absolutely hate every single thing about this. The rushing stream, feeding into a greater body of water below. Two feet, sinking in water warmed by the sun. Catra was always quick to steal whatever catch Adora managed, but she was always a brick wall about actually going to catch some of those fish herself. Finn sits peacefully next to Adora, kicking their toes in the water.

Two collapsible fishing poles leave Adora's satchel. Swift Wind waits behind them both, packed and ready to go. This is the finale to the trip, and this is something Adora has longed to do for as long as she can remember. Though things are different without Mermista's expert skill and casual advice. Adam was never a good fisherman, but he was always good company. Also terrible company, considering Adora never caught anything when Adam was along.

"Is that a piece of cheese?" Finn asks. "How long have we had cheese!"

"Hey, this is bait. The trick is to stick a little something on the end of the rod there. Entice the fish to bite. When you feel that bite, that pull against your stick, you start heaving. Pull that line back as fast as you can."

"What happens if I never get a bite? Does that mean the fish don't like cheese?"

"No." Adora finds herself laughing; she can't help it. "Sometimes the fish are smart. They'll take the cheese without us even knowing."

“Well that’s not nice.” Finn grabs the smaller of the two rods, eagerly grasping the pole in hand.

“Let’s get started. Hold the line up, just like this. Good. Now whip it back, just a little bit—not too fast. Now use those muscles and throw it as far into the water as you can.”

The line casts out in front of Adora, long and narrow. Finn’s hugs the right a bit, landing with a quiet rippling to the water.

“And now we wait?” It’s so unlike a child. Adora was nothing like Finn. Not patient. She was on to the next task, back to back to back, all the while looking over her shoulder for Shadow Weaver’s eyes and Shadow Weaver’s approval. Finn doesn’t care about any of that. They’re calm. Content. Excited. A child.

“Now we wait,” Adora tells them. “You can sit on the edge, there. Dip your toes back in. I’ll stand for a bit.”

Finn is careful. Eyes on the line. Pink sticks out the edge of their lips, a tongue pointing downward. Carefully they lower their body to the ground, bending perfectly at the knee, scooting legs out onto the floor. They tell Adora they don’t want to scare the fish.

“You’re silly,” Adora says. “Don’t worry, they can’t hear you. Nothing to be afraid of.”

“Adora, why’s Mama so afraid of Shadow Weaver?”

The question is so sudden, she feels as if she’s been thrown in another swamp trap. Pulled by her knees, the joint itself screaming in pain as she slams quickly into a tree. The tree scrapes her face, scarring her skin. What the fuck Finn.

Cornering her into the difficult stuff. Must be Catra’s child. With big eyes Finn stares up at Adora, pleading. Catra has fought with everything she has to keep Finn and Shadow Weaver as separate as possible. Yet, the woman still finds a way to haunt all of them evenly. Finn doesn’t even know what any of this is.

“Mama doesn’t want me to do any of these things. I want to! They’re not dangerous . . . is she scared? All I do is hide all day, Adora.”

Word choice will be everything. Whatever Adora says, it will impact Finn forever. Not for a second does she consider using anything but the truth. Her line pulls, but she ignores it to eye her child. “It isn’t safe. To wander around. Um, Shadow Weaver isn’t the best person, Finn. She’s bad. Dangerous. She’s—she’s a bad person, Finn.”

“Then why didn’t I learn all this stuff already? To protect myself, I mean.” They’re pouting, but staring Adora down intensely. Stuck on that question.

“Your mama just wants you to be safe. And nothing like the either of us. She means well.”

“It isn’t fair.”

“Hey. We have plenty of time now.” Adora pokes them in their stomach with the end of her pole, gaining a small laugh. Finn turns, facing the lake.

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“Big ass deer. What's the occasion?” Then Catra’s face goes completely blank with disbelief. “What did you two break?”

“Hunting trip,” Adora tells her. “Thought we needed some time in nature.” Not true. Adora is actually quite sick of nature at the moment, with all its up-and-down weather patterns changing at a moment’s notice rather unfairly. She wonders when her body will give up on her, cursing her existence.

“Is that why Finn’s sleeping like you hit them with a brick?”

On the couch rests a small body, bunched up in two layers of blankets. One foot pokes out, and the two times Adora has tried to cover it, she looks over to find the damn limb out again. Teeth

play peek-a-boo as Finn snores rather loudly, lips spread apart in front of the crackling fireplace.

"That is your child," Catra says again. Proudly, Adora smiles. "I have news of my noble venture to screw Shadow Weaver without fucking everyone else in the process. Because I'm so heroic and thoughtful."

"They don't deserve being left in the wind," Adora agrees. "What happened?"

"Bad shit, mostly. You know, same old story. Tung Lashor is gone—nice job by the way, fuck that guy—and it's left a massive rift. Him being gone is creating chaos. Like the natural balance of order has been disrupted, and hey, maybe it has."

"Oops." Adora feels one side of her cheek twitch in a violent cringe, feeling somewhat guilty.

"Still, fuck that guy." Finally Catra sits with Adora at the table. "We had a big bank to hit, and some other band of losers was there already. That sort of thing; low ranking low lives sticking their noses in where the big players belong. Hordak's getting pissy, big surprise. Bolder and bolder, he's getting."

"No time and nothing to lose." Asshole. The last thing any of them needed was this, and here it is!

"Which means we're on the same clock. It's time I told you Shadow Weaver's big, grand scheme: she's found that family's big stupid treasure."

Years and years, mumbling about some family. They stole from her. It was her wages, her right, blah blah blah. Knowing Shadow Weaver, it's all probably bull. The fact the money is real at all is what shocks Adora.

"It's been *acquired* —her words—by a nearby family. A family she's hated for years. The late owners of Bright Moon ranch."

Adora might fall out of her seat. Stand up, start yelling. Dare to call Catra a liar. But it all makes so much sense. Such a beautiful area, haunted and tormented by endless waves of bandits. The boldest assholes from all the way down in the Crimson Waste travel all the way up there, hitting nothing else on the way. If the family should own a huge heap of treasure, rumor or not, the big players like Shadow Weaver might find themselves in the mix of smart minds and scattered assholes.

Weirdly enough, the news isn't what shocks Adora. Nothing about Glimmer sitting on some massive family treasure moves her. The fact Glimmer invited her at all, a stranger with guns and scars and secrets, onto her land—that's the strange part. When Adora told her the truth, she basically didn't care. Needed to get rid of Huntara, technically Tung Lashor, for security purposes. To help Adora.

Why send Adora on a big job like that when she's supposedly loaded with money? How is it she's struggling, if she's loaded with heaps and piles of fantasy pirate booty? She wonders how generous Glimmer really is.

Something isn't adding up here.

Catra grins. She carries an expression most would reference as evil. There's evil behind those mismatched eyes, something brewing, something boiling, and if it were anyone in the world but Catra, Adora might feel her nerves buzzing. Instead, she is perfectly calm, perfectly fine, as she's told, "As it so happens, I have a plan."

Slowly Catra's expression falls neutral, shifting into something else. There's a reason beyond the both of them for all this, and the real danger of it all lies behind Catra's mismatched pupils.

"The others will be okay. Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle—they're all ready to get out. Scorpia got out a while ago. Everything in front of us is finally going wrong. Everything people like us deserve is finally happening, and Shadow Weaver is going insane. Killing Hordak's

men and hanging them on trees by the road. Beating them bloody and sending them back to Hordak half dead. Brutalizing their horses. Crazy bitch.” Catra sighs, pressing her fingers together and staring at the ground. Then she admits something Adora was convinced she’d never hear from Catra’s mouth: “She’s scary and she needs to go down.”

Leaning forward, on the edge of her heels, Adora nods.

Chapter End Notes

oof my ovaries

Right now Adora and Finn are in the fun catch up phase! Then the real world stuff hits and I'll scream into the void, nice nice

This little number is officially more than halfway done! Thank you so much for reading!!

Damnation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I really don't like this." Surveying the area, Adora wonders when the vision in front of her will collapse into blurred, fuzzy nonsense. Something about seeing the ranch decorated in bullet holes and scorched earth makes her want to burst into tears. She did this. The only reason Hordak even considered this place is because she overstayed her welcome. Should've left at the first chance. Should've stayed with Entrapta or Scorpia. Something, anything.

Adora and the person responsible for her ever coming here stand at the end of the road, looking onto the distant property. From here, some things are clear to see, such as the aftermath of fire bottles and the unleashed rage and frustrations of a dying man. Catra and her demon horse wait patiently, a few inches shorter than Adora. Finn is somewhere far, far in the distance, tucked away in a perfect fairy tale cabin in the middle of fairy tale nowhere.

The demon from hell snorts as Catra shifts around in her saddle. Her hat is returned to its true owner now, looking dusty underneath the sun. Catra's curls poke out in such a fitted and rehearsed way, the only way one's hair would act after years and years crushed underneath heavy leather. Sideways the hat turns as Catra looks on Adora. "You care about them."

"They saved my life," she responds simply. Because, simply, it's exactly what this place did. Bow and Glimmer, performing the most selfless act anyone could out in a place like this. Every corner is riddled with danger and bandits, and they still went out of their way and asked for nothing in return. What did Adora do to repay them? Set up tiny security against the massive amount of danger she flooded into this place.

A place riddled with treasures, apparently. Next to her, Catra sighs, probably thinking something along the lines of the same thing: nice people running with things they don't deserve. Things they don't understand, for that manner.

"This is the nicest way to do this. It's a hard job."

"I'm worried. What if—"

"The plan will work." Immediately, with eyebrows raised, Adora eyes Catra, not able to miss her in the bright afternoon sun.

"Like the last plan?" she asks. Catra's expression remains neutral, in that way she always manages to do. Adora gets the most of the expressions Catra is capable of and willing to make, but in times like these she's aware of herself. Almost defensively she composes herself, a simple but measured way of showing her strength, her stubbornness, and her accelerated wits all at once. Most importantly: her ability not to give a shit.

"It will work." Onward Catra pushes, impatient. Adora follows, successfully falling for Catra's leadership and overall dominance. "We need to hurry. She's moving fast, and we need to be faster."

Once they cross closer to the property and closer to the defenses Adora would spend time distracting herself setting up, the full celebrity treatment breaks out. Either for the horse or for the outlaw who almost got them all killed, Adora is unsure. Likely for the horse. Someone immediately goes and grabs Bow and Glimmer from wherever it is they're working on the ranch today. Things change so often around here, Adora can't really wager a guess. Probably property restoration.

Neither of the two stop. Adora barely says anything to anyone, and doesn't plan on waiting around for Bow and Glimmer, no matter what she's told. No, she doesn't want to sit down for a drink. No, she doesn't want to see this person and that person, and she certainly doesn't want to see the new shipment of guns. She wants to have a private chat in that giant house at the end of

the road, and she'll continue to push onward. It's for the greater good of everyone.

In the corner of her eye Adora catches Catra's wandering pupils, no matter how hard Catra tries to fight it. She's always been the more curious of the two, and despite her talent hiding what's really going on inside, it's painfully obvious. It's where she got her nickname from, right from the mouth of Shadow Weaver herself. Curiosity killed the cat.

"That's where I stayed." Adora points at the wonderful, pathetic-looking little house, grinning wide. Catra can't help but share in the feeling of sudden, anxious giddiness. The house might soon cease to exist as a whole, and Adora is happy not only to see it one last time but to show Catra the place she stayed. The place Catra sent her to recover. The place she lived on.

Great white panels of great wood greet them both in a flash. Catra dismounts with her head cocked upward, staring the building down. Adora expects her to say something about the strangeness of not being here to rob it, but she says nothing. All she really does is look over at Adora and nod approvingly. There's money in this place, for sure.

Two familiar faces leave the porch to greet Adora, and Adora returns those faces inside. A third person is here, staring at her like she's crazy, and this third person is completely correct. Glimmer is looking at her with a portion of the same strangeness, but she's willfully giving Adora the benefit of the doubt. Bow is one hundred percent on that side, already bringing Adora and Catra somewhere further inside. Neither of them have ever been stupid; they know the urgency of this visit. The third person trails along, and once the group finally reaches a set of chairs and confirmed privacy, Glimmer briefly introduces them as Castaspella. Her aunt; her late father's businesswoman sister from the city.

"She's here helping us out."

“I’m really sorry about that.” Adora won’t let either of them speak, whether they’ve finally come to their senses to cuss her or are ready to foolishly continue to give her the privilege of their trust. “And I’m really sorry about what I’m going to ask you in a few minutes.”

Another brief introduction, this time for Catra. Adora flicks her hand in the general direction of her greatest ally, formally introducing her to her perhaps temporary ones. Not sure on the timeline for the alignment just yet. Could be extended for the next few minutes only, and nothing after that. “She’s the reason you guys found me on the road. She’s the reason I went to go see Entrapta. She’s the reason I bothered with Huntara and Tung Lashor in the Crimson Waste. She’s the reason I’m alive, at all. And she’s the owner of that hat.”

All important information. All of it, the most important detail to Catra’s person. Can’t miss the hat. It sags low on her head, her silent way of asking not to be remembered, a rather fashionable mask to frame her face without touching it at all.

“Shadow Weaver,” Catra says briefly and simply, her calm way of crunching the clock. “You know her name. If not, just think of her as the biggest bitch in the west. She’s coming here. She knows you’re sitting on a giant treasure.”

The next set of expressions are curious. Bow, already biting his nails in worry, looking over to Glimmer for either trust or leadership. Glimmer, breaking a sweat and removing her slouch defensively. Aunt Castaspella, twisting her face in a hateful way. She is the one Catra hones in on.

“One of you knows her name.” Catra grins from underneath her hat-shield, her arms crossed and her sharp teeth flashing. “Or you think we’re about to rob you stupid blind.”

“We’re not,” Adora says rather quickly.

“Shadow Weaver.” Castaspella lunges forward in her seat in a way which appears most uncomfortable, her lower back supporting her slouching upper back. One hand falls flimsy over the side of the large chair she’s sitting in, a fancy piece of work sitting in an even fancier home. Purple and pink banners hang from the windows, a curtain filtering the sun into a new shade best representing Glimmer’s family. Castaspella’s other hand scoots her more forward in the chair, pushing one side of her body higher than the other. She looks like a towel someone draped over the back of the chair. “I was wondering when she’d come back here.”

Glimmer eyes her aunt, before turning her attention to Bow. He glares back, ultimately bringing her to a lengthy sigh. Unlike her aunt she remains in the back of the chair, trying her best to remain relaxed. “She—There is no—” Glimmer takes another breath, looking up at the ceiling before returning her attention properly on Adora. “My parents are no more. My dad knew Shadow Weaver, many years ago. She was working in the same town he and Aunt Casta grew up in. She tried to be an influence on him, but once things turned around work-wise she did a full one-eighty.”

“Or revealed her true self,” Catra says. Glimmer’s aunt seems to agree.

“Dad’s parents made out with a lot of money when things fell apart there; they left just in time. Shadow Weaver did not. She and a few other workers.”

“Hordak,” Adora mumbles. The word is between her and Catra, and Catra catches onto it with an easy nod.

“The thing is—” Glimmer looks up at the ceiling once more, before her hands reach her face. They cover both her cheeks and her eyes, before she removes them and takes on a dreadful expression. “I, um. There is—there is no more money. She can come down here and ransack the entire mansion. There is not a dime left of his money. They died suddenly, because of her, and I had no idea what I was doing. If it weren’t for all that money to

fall back on, this place wouldn't exist. That money, Aunt Casta, and Bow are the only reason this ranch is still here. If I was rolling around in money, I wouldn't have sent you all the way out to the Crimson Waste, either. I would've helped you."

Closes that loop. Adora can't find any reason not to believe her, because frankly she can't find any reason for Glimmer to lie. She's never presented herself as anything but selfless. But then people are strange, strange and sudden, and Adora's never been the master at reading them. The person to her right, however . . .

Luckily the person to her right eyes Glimmer back with great consideration, and maybe even a hint of the same trust and belief. Enough to let her neutral expression break free for a mere few moments.

"We're not here about the treasure," Adora says. Time crunch. "We're about Shadow Weaver. She doesn't know any of that. And she doesn't care. She really will tear this place apart before she believes a breath from your lungs."

"I believe that," Castaspella says, resentfully.

"She's crazy," Catra says. "She is a crazy asshole, but we need your help in making her less and less of one. but you won't like *how* ."

Adora can feel her face twisting into itself. As she speaks the next set of words, she cringes miserably. "We need you to let Shadow Weaver attack Bright Moon ranch. Just long enough for us to rob her blind—her gang is about to disband. If she has nothing to promise them, they'll all go their separate ways. We'll come back and help you, if you want."

For the next few, long moments, Glimmer and Bow glare at one another. Neither makes a face negative or positive. The most either of them does is from Bow, clenching his jaw. The two appear to be speaking silently, perhaps directly into one another's

brains, because once they break contact Bow looks back on Adora, then Catra, then Adora again.

"We'll be ready," Bow says. Glimmer nods in the background, looking somewhere else. "But you shouldn't stay. Get—"

"I want to help you. She's a rough person, and—"

"Get to safety," Bow insists. The tone of his voice reminds Adora that his biceps are large enough to crush her skull. Doesn't bother her. Still, Bow is defensive. Strong. He's stubborn for the first time Adora's known him, holding his ground solidly. "We'll take care of it."

"It's perfect revenge for my parents." Glimmer is looking at Adora now, and now she dares to smile. It seems as if a loaded weight of grief and stress is lifting from Glimmer right before Adora's eyes. "Go rob the hell out of her, Adora Grayskull."

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Finn will be fine. Over and over. Finn will be fine. They'll be fine, Adora, let's get moving! One hunting trip and now Finn's supposed to be the survivalist expert. Finn is going with them, on the road, out into the open, out near Shadow Weaver, and Adora is supposed to be calm about it.

"We can't run back home. Focus up."

She wants more than one camping trip. Catra is smart enough, as always, to take Finn onto her horse. To ride down the mountain, to force Adora out of her foolish doubts. They're escaping. All of them are escaping, today, and something as silly as a bad feeling in Adora's stomach isn't going to erase decades of work. Get to the fort. Unearth the stash. Ride east. Far east.

Empty. The place is totally empty. It terrifies Adora. She watched every individual occupying this place leave, one by one, but she swears one remains to breathe down her neck. Where is Hordak? Why is this place so quiet? Why is this so damn easy?

Seven feet into the earth. Finn is somewhere in the distance, watching on. In the dirt Adora finds the chest is as big as her torso and three times as heavy. The feeling should be a delight. So much money it's too heavy to carry. It should be the dream, the highest point of her life, the greatest heist she's ever performed. Everything about it feels wrong, and her heart leaps out of her body before jumping back in. In and out, bruising her skin and driving her mad with worry. They'll run after this. Load it up and run. Leave the cabin behind. Build a new home. Forget this life. Never look back.

There is no need to look back. When the pair of them surface back into the world, everything they need to know is in front of them. No one backs the woman up. In fact, the crowd behind Shadow Weaver and her gun look rather bored. They stand baited with anticipation. They stand, desperate to see what comes next, and desperately clenching to a reality in which freedom consumes them. They're all high on the images Catra and Adora have chased for years.

Something about Shadow Weaver's rifle sitting inches from Adora's face calms her.

"I was wondering why Hordak was waiting for us at the ranch." Gleaming under the sun, the dark rifle doesn't lose its grip on her. One pair of sharp eyes manages to hold Adora more sharply despite the mask hiding them from the world. "A diversion. I would expect nothing less from Micah's child; he was never anything but intelligent. At least we'll all have the pleasure of dying here, together."

"Like one happy fucking family," Catra says. Adora allows herself exactly two moments: one to admire Catra's unrelenting hatred for Shadow Weaver, another to call Glimmer a genius. Glimmer managed to pit both Adora's enemies together and leave them to their silly warfare and rage. Not bad.

Those two moments are all she can afford for now. Before the rifle can shoot, before anyone on either side can drop their

threats, hooves begin to echo. Dozens and dozens of them, together as one unit.

Hordak is here.

Feet begin to scramble, less as one and more as many; it's every man for himself. Catra jumps at the chance to yank the rifle from Shadow Weaver's hands and throw it elsewhere.

"Finn. I got it."

And for once, without argument, Catra leaves Adora. The stakes are too high. Adora fucked everything up for that chest, years ago. Not today. Today it won't ruin anything, whether or not she takes it with her this time.

Strongly, solidly on one pair of two old red boots, Adora holds her ground. She's tougher than Shadow Weaver. Faster. Just as capable of danger. She hates this woman for everything. Every single thing in her life is Shadow Weaver's fault, and she should step forward and rip the woman apart. This woman who took her in, clothed her, fed her, raised her to be destructive and violent and unforgiving.

Adora could never reflect what this woman wants and what this woman has become.

"You should run," Adora tells her. She stands with her shoulders squared, an impenetrable wall. "You won, Shadow Weaver. You scared him, you broke him. He has no time left. He doesn't want to see you hang anymore, he just wants to see you dead. Just get __"

"This is war, Adora." Under the mask, a scarred woman's expression twitches. Years and years working in a mine, only to be left with empty potential and a painful memory of it all on her skin. "Don't you understand that?"

"You're bringing everyone down with you. You *have* to see that!"

“My child. My ungrateful, selfish child.” Shadow Weaver begins to step towards her, into her space. Adora should keep the chest in mind, but all her brain can catch is the hand raising into the air from her guardian's side. Suddenly she’s a child, frozen and hot in the face and scared. Her hands shake miserably as Shadow Weaver approaches her. “You have learned nothing.”

Then she walks off, stepping into the chaos around them as guns begin to unload. Adora follows after a measured second, forgetting the massive treasure behind her.

She can’t locate Catra. Finn isn’t on a horse. They’re on their feet, a small pair of boots kicking up dirt. Running for Swift Wind. They were on Melog. Where is Melog?

“Catra!”

A large black horse with bloody eyes runs off. In a sea of purebred chaos, Adora can barely place him among the other stallions. Her eyes start scanning around. Swift Wind spots Finn and begins running towards them, loyal and trying his best to help.

Adora sees her. Catra is tackled to the ground on Hordak’s watch, desperately fighting as she’s dragged off. They failed. They came after this stupid chest again, and again they failed.

“Your child will not survive.”

Something sobers Adora’s panic with the simplicity of a poke. Something pokes her, deep on her healed, not-shot-and-in-the-dirt side. Her arm shoots backwards, grabbing the bony hand responsible.

“Consider this my last lesson to you, child. I spared him, and it will be everyone’s doom. You lost your faith. Look at this. Both of you—you and Hordak—you caused this.”

The next sequence happens in such a way Adora finds herself reflecting on it all, unsure what really happened and what didn’t

happen. She considers all that time around Catra's fantasy books has begun seeping into her brain, warping her idea of reality.

Swift Wind in her vision one moment. Shadow Weaver the next, and Adora's fist plows into the woman's skin, uppercutting the underside of the woman's jaw in a quick hooking motion, breaking a portion of her mask. A sharpness blows through Adora as well, but she hears her child's voice and forgets all about it. Then she's staring at the back of Finn's curly hair, gun in hand. She shoots someone, and behind her someone is shot separately. Briefly, her head turns and finds Hordak, inches from Shadow Weaver's corpse.

He stares at Adora, and the world blurs around her as Swift Wind picks up speed. Trees swim into her vision. The fort is gone, far away. Briefly she feels her boots hitting the earth, scooting Finn into the passenger's seat as she takes over to the sound of rushing hooves.

West. They're going somewhere west. Adora keeps pushing. Periodically, almost out of her control, her arm opposite to her burning side—an awful and familiar feeling she never wished to experience again—pushes upward and aims a block of metal. It shoots, gently pushing her arm upward with great consideration. One by one, each blob trying to cross her and Finn's paths disappears. Finn's grip remains tight, secure around Adora's torso. Adora can feel the child laughing as they turn their head, looking around. She can't. Adora can barely lift her head.

She has to keep going.

"Adora! Adora, we did it! We lost them!" Finn laughs joyously, shifting around to be extra sure of their, of late, depleting luck.

Swift Wind shifts as Adora suddenly pulls his reins to the side. Losing her balance . . .

"Take that, you stupid coppers!" The small voice echoes in her mind, bouncing violently around in her skull.

“Finn . . .” She starts to lean, so drastically two smaller hands have to fly to her sides to keep her upright. Mostly they serve as a wakeup call: she needs to wake up.

“Adora?”

It’s no use. Adora can’t wake up. Finn tries hard, yanking hard at her sides, but Adora falls completely over and crashes onto the earth below. The blood leaking from her side splatters, painting crimson against the brown dust.

“Adora!”

Swift Wind stops immediately, and she hears Finn’s feet land much more gracefully than hers. Shaking her, trying to force her heavy eyes open. Adora tries—oh, how she *tries* —but her body won’t cooperate. It's no different from a stubborn horse, too set in its way to understand what’s truly going on. The danger that lurks. How desperately she needs to get up. Finn shakes her by the shoulders, shouting her name, but she can’t get up for them. She’s not the big strong hero Finn thinks she is right now, paralyzed and bloodied and waiting for death.

Adora manages one half of Bright Moon’s name before darkness overcomes her, swallowing her whole. Shadow Weaver’s final lesson leaves her paralyzed against the dirt, formally abandoning her child once more.

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“Bright. Bright, Bright, Bright. Um—oh! Bright Moon! Bright Moon Ranch! Adora? Is that—” Finn’s eyes search desperately, but there’s nothing. “Mom? Please?”

No. No way is Adora dying today. She’s going to be old and grumpy before she’s allowed to go anywhere, even if Finn has to drag her—

“That’s it!”

Small problem. Can't exactly tie Adora to the back of a horse and drag her against the dirt can they?

They wish Catra was here.

The thought brings renewed strength. Shelter. Adora says shelter can go a long way. Finn grabs some bandages off of Swift Wind's saddlebags—thankful Adora is always prepared—and cleans out the injury before wrapping it. Clean cut through her side. Another scar on the other side. Quite a few others. How many times has Adora danced with death?

How many times does she have left?

They grab Adora by her shoulders, hoisting her up with all their might. If Swift Wind wasn't so tall, they could drape Adora on the horse and be out of here. Instead, they drag Adora through the deserts on the edge of the Waste, hiding away from the main road and behind a small hill. Giving Adora a bed roll to lie on for the night.

Adora's rifle is heavy in Finn's hands, shiny against the campfire. Polished. In good shape. Finn wonders why Adora never taught them how to shoot. Catra said it wasn't a skill they should need. But Catra said that about fishing and Adora went ahead and taught them that.

Finn thinks about those scars. Shadow Weaver. Catra and Adora are afraid. They think Finn's going to fall into this life. They remember what Adora told them on the fishing trip and have to laugh, because it's too late; look what's happened. They look at Adora, checking her pulse for the millionth time in the last ten minutes.

"It's my turn to protect you and Mama," Finn says. The living corpse doesn't respond, lost in a deep slumber. "I'll do whatever it takes."

Nightfall doesn't give Finn much to work with. They start a fire, though in tonight's warmer temperatures, even at night, there's

barely any need. Mostly, they're looking for comfort. The ambient crackling noise of the flames keeps their mind centered as the ideas flow. Notebook in hand, Finn starts jotting down ideas. Dragging Adora on the back of the horse is still an option, though it falls lowest on the list. Then they get up and try the immediate thoughts: getting Swift Wind to lay all the way down. Lifting Adora up, who is deceptively heavy. Finn accidentally drops Adora's head against the ground, but she doesn't wake back up.

Finn wildly fears Adora has run out of time and checks her pulse again. Slow. They're on a limited clock. No telling what's going on with Catra, but Finn prefers to focus on one parent at a time right now.

A low-bearing carriage passes them by on the road, riding rather slowly. The back of the wagon is nearly scraping the ground, and is mostly empty. Driver must be on the way home from a delivery. In the middle of the night. Alone.

Rifle fires. Finn tries their best insults and their best threats to shake the driver. They remain hidden behind a large, lopsided cactus, deepening their voice to sound older. Tougher. Scarier. This is a cute little game where they're pretending to be an outlaw like their parents, and nothing more. Nothing dangerous. Certainly nothing where they could lose their life! In unfortunate reality, this driver is a seasoned expert. The Crimson Waste doesn't bother them, and the people in it bother them less. The older gentleman roughly returns three shots, and one nearly scrapes past Finn's shoes where they poke out from the desert plant. They curse, and Catra isn't here to pretend to be upset by it.

Turning from cover, a new bullet nearly graces Finn again. The driver leaves his vehicle and Finn's heart starts racing. They're totally pinned here. This person definitely won't be willing to sit down and talk now—a strategy Catra always preferred to stick with and would kill Finn over personally, right now—and he's not slowing down. Boots crunch against dead twigs as he approaches closer, and with every step Finn finds thinking and breathing calmly to be more and more difficult. There's no way out of this.

They haven’t shot before. Only luck would find them alive after sticking out of cover again.

Two gunshots sound. They’re from somewhere else, and the gun sounds different entirely. The man was using something large, a wide pistol with lots of power. It boomed into the night, echoing throughout the Wastes in a familiar sound. The new weapon is much quieter, much better on the ears. It shoots faster, twice in a row with little time in between. Less cursing, too. Finn pokes their head out once more, inching out by the second, trying to locate this new person in the night. Her hair is half-brown from being soaked in the dirt for hours, and one hand crosses her upper body, clutching her side. Adora stares back at Finn, finding them easily under the moon, and she looks anything but proud of Finn’s spur-of-the-moment, genius planning. A flawless plan with a number of ugly flaws.

“What is wrong with you, Finn? You could’ve gotten shot!”

Their grand argument: “But I didn’t!” Yep. Catra’s child. And just like Catra’s child, they’ll try to turn the subject to something else. “Hey, you shouldn’t be—”

“I’m fine. Now—” And right on cue, Adora falls to her knees, staring at the ground for several moments before completely passing out again. Finn just stares, regarding her as stubborn. To be honest, it’s all her fault Finn is like this, pushing their efforts through the late night desert, shooting at strangers, trying to save Adora with what few skills they have. All Adora’s fault.

They walk over, flipping Adora on her back once more. By her shoulders, Adora is dragged off to the carriage. It sits perfectly patient on the road, and with a rough hoist Finn manages to get half of Adora’s torso up there. They jump onto the wagon, dragging her the rest of the way.

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“C’yra.”

The name makes Catra laugh. Not in a hysterical way. More of an amused way, like it's the silly nickname she's been using all her life and not her actual name chosen by a couple people she'll never meet.

From the back of the stone prison cell she looks up at Hordak, catching a glimpse of his miserable face in the dim lighting. There is barely anything to look at him with and yet he still manages to look disgusting, ghastly, and two steps into his grave. "Rat face," she greets him.

Her boots remain discarded at her heels, and before Hordak can say another word Catra picks one up and chucks it at the bars of the cell, successfully getting him to jump. He was always an easy scare, and it makes her laugh even harder than before.

"I never expected you to beg for your life," Hordak says, straightening out his ridiculous suit. "I never expected you to be humble, or have even a shred of decency. You are just as I imagined: a bandit sitting around waiting to die, laughing about how sad your life was."

"Like your life was any fucking happier, you creep." Catra throws the other boot for emphasis, and as a bonus watches steam blow out from Hordak's unnaturally pointy bat ears. "At least my death will be fast. I won't die in my own bed, choking on my own blood wondering what the hell went wrong. Watch me swing. Laugh about it all you want. It doesn't change anything."

Hordak regards her, staring into the darkness and finding two different eyes in the nothingness. Then, Catra flashes him a bright smile. It makes Hordak upset enough to force him away, ruining his moment to gloat and make her feel bad. Shadow Weaver is dead. Nothing in this moment will make her frown.

It's the next few moments Catra dreads with a silent anxiety.

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When the pink glow of color swims into her field of vision, Adora feels her lips curl into a smile. It's a dumb smile and she knows it, unfairly joyous and giddy despite the fact she once again feels ready to move into the afterlife. She can see Glimmer shaking her head in disapproval, and it makes Adora want to start giggling like a child.

"We have to stop meeting like this."

Without hesitation Glimmer responds, "Please. You're a nightmare, you know."

All of her surroundings are familiar as Adora moves her eyes about, stretching her brain so she can wake up faster. Swift Wind's saddle against the wall by the door. The small table, littered with her stuff, her notebook poking out her satchel from Bow. Only this time some of Finn's items are here, too.

"Is Finn okay?"

"Finn is okay," Bow answers first. Glimmer nods along in the background. He's standing closer to the bed, ready for the moment Adora decides to do the next stupid thing, and the thought of doing something stupid and sudden forces her to sit upright. Not bothering to learn her lesson from the previous time.

Her side aches familiarly as she forces herself upright, waving Bow off with a simple raise of her hand. He doesn't look happy about it, but nevertheless he obeys her wish and watches as she chokes down the urge to vomit her guts out. Adora's head swims, also familiar, as her body adjusts to once again rising from the grave. Oh, how history repeats itself. It's the definition of insanity, Catra would say, doing the same stupid thing over and over again, waiting for a different turn out.

"Catra didn't shoot me," Adora says quietly. "It was Shadow Weaver. It was always Shadow Weaver." Then she looks up at Bow and Glimmer, happy to catch their faces as she tells them,

“Shadow Weaver is dead; she’s no more. Hordak killed her when she retreated to the fort. Only now Catra’s in trouble.”

“You are really bad at sitting still,” Bow tells her. There’s an amusement to his eyes, watching her perform her insanity over and over and over. Adora dares to regard him as a friend, watching protectively as she does stupid shit, ready to help her when she falls. “So no more Shadow Weaver? What about her gang? Er, your old gang, I guess.”

“They’ll all filter out. They’re all about as done with this life as I am.” Adora forces her head to turn, finding Glimmer and her pink hair again. “She’ll never bother your family again, ma’am,” she says, and Glimmer looks ready to start bursting into tears of joy. If someone like Shadow Weaver famously fails to rob this place, others will likely turn away as well. In all honesty, Adora might join Glimmer.

A world without Shadow Weaver in it.

“She wouldn’t happen to be the one who stabbed you too, would she?” Glimmer asks. A laugh forces itself out of her, perhaps in the stead of the tears which threaten her face. Adora nods in response and Glimmer starts laughing fully. “And I thought she hated my dad.”

“She’s fun,” Adora agrees. Then she breaks the moment by forcing herself up to her feet, somehow managing to catch her balance as she takes her entire body by surprise. Bow lunges forward, nervous for her. He *looks* nervous, anyway. “I need to see Finn.”

“Let me get them for you, then.” Bow knows the suggestion is foolish. He gives up in record time, “They’re at one of the ponds at the end of the ranch. Northern exit. Please don’t fall on your butt.”

“I won’t! I’ll fall on my face, like a professional.”

Unlike the last time, the last dance with all this pain and general punishment of her general nonsense, the sunlight greets Adora

warmly. It's a beautiful day today. She's grabbed and tucked Adam's pistol into her back pocket, paranoia overtaking her senses. Who knows, maybe Shadow Weaver's ghost will be waiting somewhere for her?

No ghosts. All Adora finds is Swift Wind, briefly, and her feet dragging across the dirt. Bow and Glimmer haven't followed her yet. Maybe they want her to flounder around before helping her when she falls onto her face, as a lesson. A lesson she stubbornly won't learn. Neither of them has left the little house at all, and Adora knows they're silently celebrating the death of Shadow Weaver. She'll gladly leave them to it.

Her boots kick along as a small human blurs into her vision. With each step they become more and more fine, and with each step Adora sees Finn's hair is completely different. The impersonation of Catra's perfectly crazy curls is totally gone. In fact half of Finn's hair is gone, one side of their head completely shaved off. All the brown is gone as well, no longer matching Catra in any way. The hair is bleached blond now, nearly the same shade as Adam's.

The blond hair is the thing that throws Adora for a spin. Finn was already somehow a perfect combination of both her and Catra—now the resemblance is uncanny. The new look has transformed their face, pointing out more of the less obvious features that confirms yes, somehow this child abandoned in a mountain cabin in the middle of nowhere manages to look like a perfect clone of Catra and Adora. It should make Adora laugh. It's so insane, she wants to laugh about it. Instead, "Now you've got the outlaw life down, kid. Changing up your look and all."

Briefly, Finn pauses. They've noticed her, and they fall serious. Not turning. After a second they lift their head over the water where they've been staring at their reflection, at their freshly done makeover, and stare out over the pond. A small family of ducks trails around in the water. The youngest of the batch shakes its head around, splashing around and creating a tiny wave. Finn is so stuck on the ducks, they won't turn and look at Adora, not even after she struggles past her body to kneel with Finn.

“Hey,” Adora says, quiet, not wanting to disturb those ducks. “Thank you, Finn.”

They try to keep on this serious act, but Adora spots that smile before it’s killed off. They should be proud. They were faced with impossible odds, an impossible turn on an impossible plan, and managed to get all the way out here. They took care of Adora, and they faced off against a stranger. As much as Adora dislikes that part.

“You’re my hero, kiddo.”

Opposite effect. Nothing Adora wants—Finn frowns again, upset. They’re so quiet—so very oddly, out-of-character quiet—it starts to send poison into Adora’s veins. There’s something wrong here, and she has no idea what to do. All she knows is every awkward feeling about this moment is everything she was anticipating when Catra first took her into that cabin. Finn should hate her. She screwed up. She was gone for years. Catra told her to leave the money all those years ago, and it took her somewhere unfairly far away for an unfair amount of time. She’s missed everything in Finn’s life, and Finn welcomed her with wide arms and a big smile. At a loss, Adora stares out over the pond, pained in a different way.

So Finn takes the lead, facing Adora at last. So stern, so serious, so upset, Adora doesn’t know what to do about it. At least when Catra’s upset, she’s experienced in handling that. “How come Mama never taught me things? I *just* learned how to ride. How to fish. How to camp. How to survive! All she taught me was how to read and hide.”

Adora doesn’t really know how to respond to that. The first time they’d talked about this, her heart was burning in her chest. Now she feels nothing, and she’s worried she’s somehow stopped caring. She’s worried she knows she isn’t anything good for this child, and again it begins to pain her in a different way. Do they want the real answer, or something easy? Does *she* want to give them the easy answer, or the truth?

“How come you did it, Adora? Why couldn’t she show me? I’m not an idiot.” They’re starting to become more upset, more and more by the second, each one that passes growing tears around their blue eyes. Finn looks so much like Catra when they’re upset, it’s unreal. “Where have you even been all this time, Adora?”

Adora kneels closer, one knee soaking in the grass. One hand reaches for Finn’s shoulder, but the child slaps her away. Then they begin slapping Adora’s chest, crying fully now. Staring at her, making sure she knows this pain.

She knows.

“Where the hell have you been!” They slap Adora’s face now, watching as she just takes it. Sitting here in the stupid green grass, chewing her lip with uncertainty. “We needed you! Where have you been! Why didn’t you help Mama sooner?”

Their hands finally stop, and Adora jumps at the chance to pull them in close. Her hands are so much bigger. Much stronger. Much rougher. Much more experienced in this sort of thing, but she’s gentle. Her hands are soft against Finn’s small back, comforting. Finn wants to stay here and drift to sleep.

“I’m sorry.” Adora buries her face into Finn’s shoulder, abnormally weak and small, begging Finn for some kind of strength. “I’m so sorry, Finn.”

Finn holds Adora back, so tiny against her giant back. She’s so much like those fictional cowboys Finn’s read about, sturdy and stable and strong and ready to take down ten thousand men. Finn holds tight, probably trying to crush Adora, to hurt Adora the way she’s hurt them, but there’s no luck. Sturdy, strong, stable.

Adora separates them, her hand cradling the back of the child’s head. Gently, like Finn will snap or shatter in her grasp. There’s a pain in her eyes Finn’s never seen before. Not even after Adora was stabbed.

“My sweet baby,” Adora says. “I never wanted to leave you behind.”

Finn is silent again, waiting for the entire tale before judgment can be bestowed upon Adora.

“Catra and I—we were gonna run away. We saved money. I took honest jobs for the first time in my life. Then it all fell apart. We were dumb—I was dumb. We never wanted you to have this life, Finn. Not in a million years. You were supposed to be one of them city kids. Learning in a schoolhouse. Playing with all the other kids. Not locked up in a cabin for most of your life.”

Adora sighs, a shaky breath leaving her as she strokes the sides of Finn’s cheeks. Finn lets her.

“She sent you away to keep you safe, from all this anger and pain and revenge. The only safety from this life is to leave it. And leaving this life . . . leaving this life is hard. The whole country wants us both dead. Bounty hunters.” Adora pauses, feeling a pain through her heart, thinking of her brother. “Angry townsfolk.”

Finn sniffles, and Adora wipes the fresh tears as they fall from Finn’s eyes. Just like hers. Just like Adam’s. “Is that why you didn’t come back?”

“No.” Adora shakes her head, her hands strong on Finn’s doubtful shoulders. “No, kiddo.”

“Then why?”

So Adora tells them. The big job. How she screwed up, how she failed. Her arrest. Taking care of those fields on community work, searching mindlessly in what little free time she had. Any and every lead. Countless pennies spent on the paperboy. The feeling of going insane, for ten long years of failure. Hordak roping her back into this life, Shadow Weaver shooting her like a dog. Bright Moon. Adam. Catra, Catra, Catra . . .

“I thought about you every single day, Finn. You and your mama. So much that it *hurt* . You could stab me ten more times, and it wouldn’t hurt as much.”

Adora grabs Finn’s hand, the child towering over her.

“Loss *hurts* , Finn. We never wanted you to have this life. I watched my brother die. Many of my friends. I watched Catra as they took me away, and a part of me—it *died* inside. The last thing I wanted to do was leave you.”

Finn is quiet for a while, their blue eyes searching around. Searching for questions, answers, comfort—Adora will provide whatever it is they want.

“You’re not my mom,” Finn says quietly. “But it feels like it. I like that feeling.” There’s a pause, a long pause, as Finn thinks some more.

It’s a long time before the next question is asked.

“Adora, do you love me?”

Adora surges forward, this time nearly rushing Finn with the might of her embrace. Their head rests between her neck and shoulder, finding comfort. The type of deep-rooted comfort one can only feel underneath the skin; a mother’s comfort.

“I love you, Finn. More than anything in the world.”

“Do you love my Mama?”

Finn feels Adora’s voice, vibrating through their skin, “I have loved your mama since before I learned what love is; I have loved her forever, and I will love her for evermore.”

Adora separates the two of them again. The warmth leaves Finn in a raging winter storm’s might. Silently, she’s telling them they need to get moving. Catra is out there. Catra needs them. Finn thinks it’ll be easier to sit here forever, forgetting they have all

these things to deal with. All these things their mothers never wanted for them, haunting them all in a horrifying violence.

A moment passes them. The ducks in the water move on, down the pond and on with their little lives. Adora looks away, the one thinking things over, now. Then she silently agrees with herself, reaching in her back pocket and bringing a long-nosed, golden, highly valuable weapon into view.

"This was your Uncle Adam's gun. He worked hard to get it. He took care of those guns, and those guns now take care of me and your mama. I'm going to need your help. She needs us. She needs us both. Understand?"

Adora offers the weapon, patiently waiting for Finn to accept it. Gently, the child takes the weapon, sealing their fate into the very life their mothers prayed against. Life is a funny, funny, cruel, odd game, Finn thinks.

"I understand." They follow Adora back onto the property, the next lesson on Adora's endless list ready for session.

The gun is heavy in Finn's hand. The people Adora's killed with this thing, no one can count. All those scars across Adora's torso.

This is a miserable life of suffering.

They hold on tightly to Adora, ready to brave this path. They'll do anything to get Catra back, and they're not alone. Adora isn't alone. It's a nice feeling, having a partner in crime. Maybe that's why Adora and Catra stuck around one another for so long.

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact! This is the first chapter I completed for this story! Bunch of my favorite scenes are in this one alone.

One more chapter in this little journey left. Thank you so much for reading!

Unshaken

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Hey, can I try one of those?”

Adora chuckles to herself, losing her focus briefly enough to nearly topple over the bottle she carefully places. Bright Moon has its own number of handmade shooting ranges scattered about, and plenty of spare bottles and crates, but Adora wants this moment. She wants to be selfish, to steal every possible quiet moment with her child before the next danger threatens her life. Next time she might not be so lucky. She almost wants to share a drink now with Finn to see the look on their face when the bitterness of the beer hits their tongue.

Instead she turns to her child, placing a promise in the both of them. “Some other time. When you’re grown, maybe? Nice try though. Besides, beer and guns—they never mix.”

“Fine.” Finn giggles quietly, standing away from the crate and the targets. Adora sets a fair number of empty beer bottles evenly apart, scattering a few extras in the space behind the crate. Her own rifle is slung across her shoulder. It’s not the weapon Finn will be using.

Adam spent weeks saving up for his revolvers. He had all the plans pre-arranged, all the parts drawn out. (None of which he drew of course, because he was no artist.) Pearl handle with a gold finish. Adora thought it was the ugliest design—too many bright colors on top of one another. Catra told Adam a dark wood handle would look better, but he wouldn’t budge. Now Adora and Catra are stuck with the pair they’ve split, carrying the ugly pistols with all the pride in the world. They shine so beautifully, Adora knows her brother was beyond proud of them. She presents her half of the pair to the world, passing the weapon off to her child.

“It’s not a toy, okay?” Goosebumps prickle across her skin. She feels like she’s going to start sobbing, and she doesn’t know why. Finn is looking back at her with full attentiveness, no jokes. Adam’s weapon in hand. “You—you gotta respect the weapon. It can kill anyone, including you. Having this thing doesn’t make you cool, and it ain’t gonna make you strong. It makes you a threat, one other people will take seriously. Being a threat doesn’t make you a hero neither. All the power is in the weapon. We’re just people.”

Finn nods, looking nervous now. Honestly, Adora prefers the nerves over excitement. Not like they’re about to do something fun with this thing.

“When you point this weapon, Finn, you mean it. Even if you’re funnin’ around—this gun kills what it points at.”

“Not a toy,” Finn repeats, and Adora nods sternly.

“Not a toy,” she repeats as well. She tells Finn more about the weapon as she fastens Adam’s old holster to their waist. Gun barely has a kick. How to reload it. The importance of the safety, and where it even is. How important it is to oil and clean. Shooting stance.

And then, narrowing the list, Adora finds herself at the final part of the lesson: shooting the weapon.

The thought makes her take a massive, shaky sigh. No bullets in the gun, not yet. Adora shows Finn again how to hold the weapon, making sure their hands are stable. *Then* the bullets make an appearance. Adora makes the first shot in a movement she’s practiced and rehearsed and performed dozens of hundreds of times without a second thought. Today, right here, suddenly she’s conscious about everything. She remembers Huntara’s lectures in the Wastes, straightening out her spine to be a good example for her child. Her shoulder blades squeeze together in preparation, and the gun spits out almost nothing for her to fight against.

Carefully, as if the gun were the heaviest rock from the deepest depths in the ocean, Adora places both hands on it, wrapping each finger around every crevice possible, laying it into Finn's hands as if it would crush them otherwise. She watches Finn take up the same stance, kneeling next to them to help them aim. Adam was always a cheater and had a pronged sight added to the end of the long barrel.

One hand remains on Finn's back as they prep their first ever shot on one of the bottles. One remains destroyed from Adora's demonstration.

A kick barely registers from the weapon, but it's enough for a young beginner like Finn to become rattled, before laughing from the adrenaline. They hit nothing, but the power of the weapon pulses through Finn's veins. They eyeball Adora, grinning before preparing to take the next shot. Her hand doesn't leave their back.

Aiming tips and tricks. Adora doesn't help Finn, rather wants to see how they do on their own. First shot misses again. Second hits the neck of the beer bottle in the center of the group, shattering the upper portion of the glass. Clearly holding back, Finn excitedly starts laughing. Adora can't help but smile; it's contagious.

She's not sure if she wishes Catra were here to see this, given the context and the circumstances. It's everything the both of them didn't want for Finn. Suddenly the sound of Finn's laughter makes Adora nervous, terrified even, and she forces herself to sit through a couple more shots before taking Finn into town rather quickly. They'll continue tomorrow, she tells them. Right now, for the sake of her own sanity, Adora needs a massive distraction.

Growing up, Catra preached education. Knowledge is the most powerful weapon in the universe. Knowledge, as well as experience. When they were young, she talked and talked of travel. Then they lived life on the run and sitting around in a cabin felt more appealing. Hand in hand, Adora takes Finn down the

street, showing them the place that kept her alive. Showing them the place that brought them all back together.

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"Lurking again. Is my face really that pretty?" Catra leans forward, her shoulders rounding into her collarbone, her neck curving vertically. The hair on the back of her head shifts to the side, choosing one over the other. "I'm taken. And she'll beat your dying old ass into the ground."

In the dark Hordak lurks, perfectly mocking a common bat. His ears are unnaturally pointy, eyes shining darkly in the nothingness. He looks pathetic, overall. "I have different plans for Adora," he says. His voice is a mumble and difficult to hear, like he's afraid to make the threat at all.

"No you don't," Catra laughs. She allows herself the feeling of immense joy, the gut-aching pain of a good joke. Her shoulders falling more and more into itself as she lets herself go.

Then she sits tall, becoming serious.

Staring Hordak down, she informs him, "You are so full of shit."

And Hordak coughs in response, his lungs too cluttered to allow them the chance of even attempting to make himself look better. He continues to linger, for reasons Catra can't possibly place as guilt or longing. There's no way he feels bad about this. He never liked any of them, especially not Catra. Not the way she was always neck-and-neck with his father. Not the way he let Adora fall off her first horse on her first real ride, smashing against the earth without mercy. He would have them all killed, he would go so far as to comb the reaches of the world to pit Catra's own *person* against her, tearing the two apart in the name of his petty revenge. In his quest he's become mad, almost as mad as Shadow Weaver, and Catra will never forgive him or his corpse.

In this moment, looking up at the man she grew up next to, she decides to let him have it. "You were made from nothing. All of

you, you were just like us. Prime was a leader down in those mines; he inspired and he led. Then he turns around and wastes his time with this cult nonsense, horrifying travelers, scaring them away like they've chosen to live here in this shithole of a country. Shadow Weaver—she was an outsider. She didn't belong. But she taught in that mining town. Everyone loved her. You, Hordak, you were supposed to be better. You were supposed to learn. But you didn't. None of you did. You became deranged, violent, greedy, downright fucking insane. That family didn't owe her anything. It's not her fault the whole town fell apart."

Hordak stares back at her, dead silent. Not like Catra plans on letting him talk, anyhow.

"She killed her own student. She killed her own student, and his wife, and you helped her do it. You deranged psychopath. You didn't care until your old, crazy ass father finally lost his mind and got himself killed. *That's* when you stepped in. You almost died. She shot you, and you had to claw your way back to survival. Yet you were such a massive ass I can't even feel sorry for you. Imagine that. Your life sucked as much as the rest of ours and I can't manage to feel sorry for you."

Still nothing. Not so much as a cough.

"Go ahead and hang me, Hordak. Torture Adora, kill her slowly. It won't make a difference. You already killed Shadow Weaver, and it hasn't changed anything. At the end of the day, even over her and everything she's ever done, you've still managed to morph into the worst of us all. Congratulations."

Hordak considers Catra, staring at her blankly for several long moments. Then he turns, walking away and solidifying his decision forever.

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One simple comment from Bow sticks Adora's eyes on her child. Predictably, Finn wanders rather frantically around the giant study

of the ranch's big mansion, excitedly going from book to book to book. About a dozen or so are cracked open at the same time, waiting around to be read on a big space on the ground. The sight makes Glimmer laugh quietly to herself. On top of regarding them as brave, Bow adds how Finn is educated.

"They get it from their mother. Other mother, I mean." Adora takes her eyes off Finn, facing her friends in the other end of the room now. "All I did was teach them how to be hidden away and how to shoot animals."

Bow shrugs, apparently finding no fault in any of that. "I never expected you to show up with a kid, that's for sure."

"I didn't think I still had a kid, to be honest." Adora keeps her voice down, far away from the range of Finn's hearing. She watches as Bow's soft face molds into a frown. Then her eyes fall on the sympathetic look on Glimmer's face.

"They really do love you," Glimmer says. "There's no more Shadow Weaver to haunt you all, at least."

"That's just the thing." Adora sighs, feeling no tension release in her chest despite her deepest hopes. "Hordak grabbed Catra. She'll swing soon, if she hasn't already. I've been keeping my eye on the papers, and nothing yet."

"We saw that," Glimmer says again, "and we're ready to help."

"What we're not ready for is the argument you're about to give us about fixing everything yourself like a big hero," Bow adds. Adora tries to brush him off, but he's so damn accurate about it all she can't block the words from entering her ears.

"We already made a plan. Just give us until tomorrow night, and we'll have everyone gathered. They want to help, Adora! Let us help you."

She doesn't bother to respond, not right away. Adora's eyes fall on Finn, as they attempt to read two different fantasy books at the

same time. They rest on their elbows, stomach kissing the patterned carpet below, two feet kicking backwards in the air as their head swivels back and forth. Two hands find their way, grazing the back of both her own wrists, and Adora is broken out of her stare for two of the friendliest faces she's ever come across in her life.

Adora eyes them both, soaking in their faith into her own skin and her own veins, experiencing the rare feeling for herself.

"Okay. I'll let you help me."

The two look back on her, grinning widely, spreading their faith, trusting their wanted outlaw friend blindly.

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Of everything, of all the time passed since Hordak approached Adora, of all the places she's found herself in for whatever amount of time each, Adora is happy to find consistency in Bright Moon. Same clear view of the bright, glowing moon every night. The town goes dead quiet at a certain time, the same time every day, when every soul in this place retires for the night and falls into a blissful slumber. Come morning the birds will chirp and the sun will blind everything on the land equipped with functioning eyeballs. Most of all, Adora is happy to know this place is still rude temperatures of cold. For whatever reason this land hates her, and for whatever reason it wants her to freeze maliciously.

But it's not the reason she rushes out from the cabin so quickly. Saddle cupped in both hands, new injury burning rather loudly and aggressively, she half drags, half carries her personal effects out to the stables. Swift Wind isn't allowed to argue with her. Just sit there and mentally prepare himself to run from danger for what she hopes will be the final time for them both. Adora is rushing towards retirement tonight—be it by death or by freedom.

Then something is thrown at the back of her head and all images of peace and freedom and sunshines and her entire family safe

from harm disappears. She’s hesitant as she turns to face the assaulter. Her stomach turns and her chest chokes her further when she finds Finn staring back at her.

“You keep saying you never left by choice. You keep saying they took you away and you were clawing the ground with your nails.” Finn reaches into their pocket, swiftly chucking another stone at Adora’s shoulders. Their half-shaved head of hair swings around easily with the motion. “How am I supposed to believe that now?”

“Finn, this isn’t—”

“She concerns me too! Don’t group me with these guys. I’m not your friend, Adora, I’m your kid!”

“I know that. It—you’re more important to me, and I can't—”

“I want to help too! She’s my *mom* , Adora. You don’t own Catra.” Stubbornly, so much like Catra, Finn brushes past Adora and makes their way for the saddle. They’ve practiced by now, and by now they’re able to jump onto the horse with ease. What Adora doesn’t clock is the fact her thief-raised child has managed to take Adam’s revolver without fuss.

“Not bad.” Adora *has* to say something about it. Then, secondly, she has to sigh. Her chest remains as tight as before, as she considers all this nonsense she’s heard about breathing exercises and breathing in general seem to bring no real changes to the constant knot sitting on her lungs. One of her hands clenches into a fist, before unclenching with her immediate thought: “Finn, what if we can’t do this? Then we lose, all over again. Worse than ever before.”

“Then don’t lose, duh.” It’s so forward, so matter-of-fact, Adora feels like an idiot for even bringing it up. Finn makes it sound like the simplest thing in the world, untangling all the worry and all the stress Adora has been silly enough to allow herself to collect all these years. With Catra’s voice in their throat, eyes deadlocked on Adora, Finn asks, “Are you coming or what?”

Finn is tough now. On the trail, where the lonely nothingness will eventually reach a bustling, lively, crowded city, Finn offers nothing. No long talks about books or other things stuck in their mind. No observations about weird things and weird people on the road. Not even a pre-game pep talk to further Adora's confidence, something she's lacking horrifically in at the moment. Finn is quiet, just as scared, and Adora has to step up as the leader of the two.

Adora uses the simplest of things. Forcing her posture higher, despite the dreaded need to fold in on herself and disappear into a ball of nothing. Her back is strong, solid. Her head focused on the road ahead, eyes locked in. When they hit the city several faces find hers, often in way of greeting, and she finds herself above them. She doesn't stop, not to acknowledge the kindness or the rudeness. Eyes stare at her all in all, curious. Nervous. Her anxiety spreads no different from a virus, infecting those around her with a rapid speed and a minimal chance of resolution. There is only one resolution today, and Adora is confident nothing about it will leave this place with smiley faces and big family feasts.

"I need a favor from you, Finn." Adora's tone is serious. Commanding. She's the adult here, the parent Finn never missed, the adult Finn always had and always needed. A day has not passed, and Adora is granted with all the authority nature can grant her. Finn sits up behind her, suddenly awake. The holster they've taken from Adora's waist on the trip over jingles quietly. "You will hang back today. Shoot from afar. Keep me covered. If anything happens, you run. You run as far away as you can and you don't bother to turn back."

Suddenly the horse is stopped, somewhat off to the side of the road. Adora dismounts her beast, grabbing her rifle and stuffing extra ammo into her pocket without much thought. She taps on the saddle, allowing Finn to scoot forward before finishing out her instructions for today.

"He is your horse now, do you understand? You use him to get to safety. He is your horse now, and you will not use him to save

anyone else. You will not sacrifice yourself for me or Catra. Do you understand me, Finn?”

Hesitantly, after several minutes, the child nods their head.

From here, Adora begins walking down the road, rifle in hand.

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Every novel Catra has come across mentions the same few things about the big city: the upper class walking the earth with pursed lips and high heads; the working class, barely able to afford a smile and a decent suit; those who remain, painted underneath everyone else, stealing and threatening to get through every day, or most days, with so little as a bite of food. Those in need are painted as villains, while those above need are committing the crimes. These towns are always regarded as peaceful besides these points, ambient city life and rapid but slowed horse hooves clopping around stone-paved walkways. While theft lurks in the night, a sense of safety could be achieved and a full night’s sleep easy to come by. Catra laughs at the concept of a big place like this expected to be drenched in silence and ambience, and now, stuck in a city overnight, she’s found some unfortunate truth in it all. The countryside was supposed to be the quiet retreat, not this walking prison!

Then the gunfire and the mayhem and the chaos and the shouting and the hatred breaks out, and Catra finds herself relaxing into her borrowed cot. It feels more honest, more in character. Shadow Weaver used to say big cities were a walking, living bomb, and Catra always found it was the one ounce of truth the woman held.

“Hope you burn forever,” Catra mumbles to herself, sing-song and giggles. She closes her eyes and takes in what might be her last time hearing what feels most familiar to her in this life she’s regretfully led: violence and gunfire.

Whatever's going on, it's nearby. She hears Hordak yelling at select people every once in a while, his voice echoing gravely down the halls. Followed with a coughing fit almost as loud as the pleasant city life outside. Poor Hordak. He must be stressed. What a poor, poor man. Catra laughs even harder to herself at the prospect of his day going awry. Hell, maybe he'll be so distraught as to postpone her hanging beyond tomorrow afternoon.

In a few moments' time Hordak begins frantically wandering around the halls, his head checking the windows periodically. When new shots fire he moves closer, sometimes breaking into cells and pushing prisoners aside. He never bothers with Catra's cell, because he's aware she wouldn't hesitate to jump him. Catra's favorite part about all the chaos is the fact Hordak is breaking into coughing fits more often than she's recorded in her time here. Maybe he'll drop dead tonight, right here. He can barely cuss his own men out before cutting himself off.

Everything stops, and Hordak disappears. All it takes is a few seconds for the free entertainment to be cancelled, and with a sigh Catra accepts it as her last night of fun. Whoever caused all this commotion, they have her thanks. She'll take it to the grave with fond memory of the miserable life of endless excitement she's known for three short decades. Some aftermath kicks in after a long silence, right here in these halls. The troublemaker lives—for now. Catra remains neutral to it as shuffling and kicking and cursing erupt in the hall.

Catra's cell door is opened, and she finds she's in the opportunity to thank this person who refused to give her a silent night. She turns away from the wall she faces, a wide grin erupting onto her freckled face. Then she catches the person in front of her, Hordak's eyes bearing down on the two of them, and all smiles are forgotten forever. Hordak walks away silently, satisfied with himself and the marital argument that's about to burst to life.

The blonde sits kneeling against the dusty stone, her head bowed in shame. They've confiscated her red jacket and her red boots, leaving her just as bare as the other prisoners in here.

Desperately Catra's prayed for a silent moment with Adora, begging the gods, begging the universe, wondering for years and years if there's even any faith worth holding onto. Yet she could never let go, despite the silliness she felt at her long-term failed hopes. Now Adora sits before her, and Catra wants to beat her half to death.

"You are such a god damn idiot," she tells the love of her life. "Damn it Adora, what is wrong with you?"

Slowly Adora tilts her head upward on her own, finding Catra's eyes in the dark. Suddenly Catra feels empty without her hat weighing down on her head. It's only ever off when the two are together, exposing their hidden sides to one another for no one else to see. Not in a rather open set of cells in a long hallway. She can feel eyes on them both, but her focus remains on Adora as the idiot opens her bloodied mouth to report, "My ribs really hurt."

Slowly Catra rolls her eyes. Then the gears in her head switch swiftly, grabbing Adora off the ground harshly and forcing her onto the cot. "Shot? Stabbed?"

Adora's thumb passes over her own bottom lip, trying to clot where something broke the skin. Either a fist or the butt end of a rifle. Catra helps her onto her back. "Yes and yes. Just not today."

She's trying to be a smart ass and Catra wants to bloody the other side of her lip. All she offers instead is another roll of the eyes before taking the space next to Adora, forcefully scooting her aside. "Well luckily they won't hurt you for long."

"Tomorrow they'll hang us?" She waits for Catra's nod before returning her attention to the nothingness on the ceiling. "Great. I'm really sorry Catra, I fucked it all up again."

"No you didn't. You never did." In response Adora is silent, and Catra knows for a fact, without an effort of thought into it, Adora doesn't agree. She doesn't agree, and she won't initiate the argument about it because she's set in her decision and her

feelings. Not worth it. The both of them only have so much time left now to worry about wrong and right. “Finn?”

Without hesitation Adora squints her eyes, pained at the concept of messing that up, too. She didn’t of course, but she’ll haunt herself for it otherwise. “I never asked Glimmer,” she says, eyes clamped shut, “but I’m certain they’ll have a home at the ranch. I really tried, Catra. I really tried to be better for that kid, I swear. I can’t—”

“I know. You love Finn, I don’t need you to prove it.”

“I was so ready to throw them out.” Adora looks at Catra with strong eyes, ready to argue. Catra has no interest in arguing right now, despite her skill for it.

“You were young, Adora. Young and scared. We were kids.”

“So is Finn.” Adora’s eyes return to the ceiling, content with the blank space bearing down on them both. Oddly, it’s satisfying to look up and find dead nothing. Catra misses the stars, but this is soothing in its own way. “Um, by the way, they sort of redid their hair? Chopped half of it and changed the color. I think it looks cool.”

“Which color?”

“Blond. Like mine. Like Adam.” Adora’s right shoulder flinches in surprise when Catra rests her head against it, though it reacts like no stranger. Adora’s arm reaches out, pulling Catra closer, securing the both of them warmly together in the darkness. Outside the sun is beginning to set, amplifying the feeling.

“I knew we should’ve kept our child away from your pink friend the second I saw her.” Catra feels the soft flexing of Adora’s torso as she laughs. “Now they’re really destined to be an outlaw. They’ve got the disguise thing down already.”

“But no family treasure to obsess over for decades of their life.” Adora’s chest puffs out slightly, before deflating. “I can’t believe

Shadow Weaver attacked the ranch. Well, I can, but . . . you know. I just—she threw everything away. Everything all of us ever were, everything we all could've been. We all could've gotten out of this life years ago if she just let it go. Instead she spent her time and effort terrorizing Micah's family."

"It wasn't always so obsessive," Catra says. "Just these last few years. She finally managed to track down Micah and we were stuck at the fort from that moment on. I think she was almost ready to walk away. Like when we were younger—I think she was ready to walk away then, too. At least it's all over. She got what she deserved."

"Nothing and a shallow grave," Adora agrees.

Catra is the one sighing, next. The concept hits her with the force of a bag of bricks. "Just like us. In the end, in a way, she still fucking wins."

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When the world rolls back in, bringing sore bones and heavy muscles, Adora finds the sun has still yet to rise. Can't sleep. Won't matter soon, anyway—she'll be sleeping forever in a few hours. Finn crosses her mind several times. No new entries in this place, and she doubts Hordak wouldn't come on over to brag about killing her child, especially with the way he's always hated Catra. And vice versa.

One last time, her busted lip throbbing, her ribs aching, her heart full from the person next to her, Adora's eyes latch themselves onto the window above. The minutes pass as the sun carries itself in, shining over the land and pronouncing another day. For some, life resumes. Continues. Carries on, and will carry on and on into the future. For others, it's the morning of the end; everything is ending now and Adora takes in every ounce of this moment. She becomes drunk on the feeling of Catra next to her, and for the first time in a long time feels the long-standing pain in her chest soothe itself away.

Catra wakes in time, and the way she immediately looks up into Adora's eyes makes Adora want to drift back into a peaceful slumber. Instead the pair remain here, silent, eyes to the ceiling above and the light which flashes inward. They hear the boots marching in at the same time, equal, rushed pacing, and they turn to one another. Catra and Adora kiss one another one last time, before they are dragged away.

The stage is set, and thanks to the woman who raised the both of them, the audience stretches far and wide. Catra and Adora have become famous in their lifetimes, gathering a loyal base of haters who fear them and people like them with every last breath. Adora feels Catra's eyes on her as the rope is fitted. As Hordak makes his speech. All Adora can do is stare out into the crowd. Is this really all she did with her one existence? It's all she could've done? This is the hardest she tried? Dozens and dozens of strangers she's never met, hissing her name and calling for her end?

" . . . And so be it, by the powers invested into our justice system by those who came before us, I sentence Adora Grayskull to death by hanging." Hordak finishes his speech as quickly as possible. Catra's will be next, meaning he's purposefully making her watch Adora's corpse swing around in her final moments of existence. He always was an ass. He probably had lengthier, harsher plans for Adora given the way she screwed up his initial plans, but he's settling for this. It all ends the same, anyway.

Hordak himself makes his way for the front of the stage, to the simple set of levers. They have the power to take life away, and he hobbles over with no care in the world. Slowly his cane presses against the sturdy wood, one leg messily dragging after the other. He's so close to death. He's so weak. This will likely be the last thing Hordak does before finally passing away, marking the end of Shadow Weaver's merry little band of thieves. The rest of them will fall into obscurity, disappearing among the masses, blending like snakes in grass. Not a single one of them will end up here.

Adora turns her head to the left, just as Hordak places his shaky hands onto the mechanism. She eyes Catra for the last time as she quickly tells her, “I love you.”

And quicker in response, Catra rushes to tell Adora, “I love you, too.”

It’s less than a second for it to happen. The ground disappears, never existing, and Adora’s neck is decompressed in such an extreme way. On the bright side, she’ll finally be rid of all that muscle tightness. On the other hand, she’s swinging her feet around, biting her teeth through her cheeks as she silently struggles. In the end she’s decided to remain stubborn. Hordak will get no show from her, no begging, no signs of pain. All he’ll get is her squinted eyes, the vein popping out from the side of her skull, and the last bit of effort she’ll ever exchange in her life. The hands tied behind her back go so far as to poke nails into one another to keep the show away from Hordak’s ailing eyes.

The other half of the second it's taken to kill Adora is spent, time playing a funny game as she finds herself falling. The crowd shrieks and begins to shuffle around as the finer sounds in Adora’s ears are blurred out for an excessive ringing. Her head is hot as circulation returns. Someone rushes underneath the stage with her, cutting her hands free. Her fair skin is an irritated red, deep burns forging their way into her. She rips the rope around her neck off, expecting the same patterns to make themselves present. Then she turns to her savior, or the next person she’s about to owe her life to.

She finds Bow, handing Adora her own rifle. Then he somehow manages to grant her another blessing: “Glimmer is getting Catra out. We need to hurry. We have the rest of your stuff and Catra’s horse. Let’s go!”

Adora barely registers, as she runs through a crowd of shrieks, curses, gunfire, and desperate commands from the law, that Bow is fully disguised. Skin covered at all angles. Knit mask hiding his face. She exits the underside of the stage and sees Glimmer is the

same, all her unique hair tied up and hidden, a bandana hiding the lower end of her face. Catra is already boarding Melog, Adam's revolver in hand, and pulls Adora on. Then they all start riding.

Several sounds of guns fire in the distance. The law is distracted fighting other forces as Catra follows Bow and Glimmer to a predetermined location. Bright Moon is here. Probably their other associates, such as Mermista and Perfuma, as well. These thoughtful idiots are going to get themselves killed and Adora doesn't know what to do with herself. Other than promise them all anything and everything they could ever hope or dream for.

Regrouping occurs in an abandoned warehouse in the middle of the city, out of the way from anything notable or major. Mermista and Perfuma are waiting here, and close by Adora sees a smaller person riding on Swift Wind in their direction. But she and Catra are distracted with their own personal effects, when Perfuma presents them. Adora's coat and boots. Bow's gifted leather satchel. Boxes and boxes of extra ammo. Catra's black jacket. Catra's hat. And finally, the pair's child comes rushing in. Finn barely gives Swift Wind time to stop before they're jumping off, engulfing both their parents in a giant hug.

"Are you okay?" Both parents ask at the same time, and Finn brushes everything here off like it's nothing. Catra's hand rubs the side of Finn's head they've shaved, skittering over buzzed hairs. Everything is parted to one side.

"You look half decent as a blond," Catra says. "Maybe I'll forgive you."

"Hey, I shot Adora's noose!" they say, tucking the revolver in their hands away. "Where's my credit for that?"

"It's true," Glimmer says. She pokes her head out into the street, before returning inside. Bow closes the only entrance to the warehouse, a large sliding barn door which bolts down from the inside. "Like a professional."

The news makes Catra laugh, because it took Adora years to shoot even at a beginner's level. According to Huntara, she was never good at all. Adora told the story last night and Catra laughed loud enough to wake everyone up. Then, after a blessed moment of joy, Catra makes herself fall serious. Back into the game. "What's the plan from here?"

"There's still a few of our people outside," Bow says. He begins walking over, though his attention remains on that door. "But they'll only buy us so much time. Castaspella knows someone, Adora. Someone in the papers. They can clear both of your names; put the blame on Shadow Weaver and Hordak."

"Which feels more accurate," Glimmer adds on. Seamlessly, as always with these two. "You guys just need to get somewhere far. Quickly. Without a trace, so Hordak can't try to stop us; it'll take some time but it's doable."

"Time is something Hordak doesn't have, I think." Adora feels stupid even pointing it out. Whether or not Hordak's in the picture, the law will always remember them and the hatred Hordak has stirred towards them. Someone will simply take his place and resume play. "But I—I know someone who can help. We can be out of here in a blink. No public transportation or anything."

"Entrapta?" Glimmer asks. Adora nods.

"Entrapta. How long should we be away?"

"I would give it a few months. Try to contact us, if you can. We'll go from there. But you have to get moving."

Adora can't. Not yet. First she has to take the opportunity to hold both Bow and Glimmer close, threatening to crush their bones to nothing with her immense appreciation. She speaks the words to them, but they don't feel right. Words can't express everything they've done for her and everything she owes them. She rides away with her family, averting her eyes from the road. With

Catra's hands on Melog's reins, and Finn trustworthy with Swift Wind, Adora can waste the time looking back on them. She convinces herself it will be the last time Glimmer and Bow will be in her sights, so she soaks in the moment as best as possible. When things quiet down enough, she'll take the time to sketch them out. She never, ever wants to forget the pair of them.

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Catra says nothing, and it surprises Adora. She's in front, so Adora can't see her face, but there's no doubt she's taking in all this land with endless wonder. There is nothing out here but desert, and a small distance away is Scorpia's family mine as well as her home. In the daylight, Entrapta's "science shack", as Scorpia would call it, looks abandoned. Sad. Half destroyed and full of no hope for any of them. Adora knows better, but she can't help but feel nervous.

The flying machine finally falls into view, and Catra is set back by it. Melog slows when she accidentally pulls on the reins, and next to them Finn's jaw has fallen open. All of it brings some satisfaction to Adora's lips.

"What," she says, giddy, "did you think I sat around after Shadow Weaver shot me?"

As expected, Entrapta barely pays the new visitors any time or attention. They're simply on her property now. Cool. She initiates conversation with Adora as normal as usual, getting right into business. She's pushy without realizing it, and Adora is grateful. "Perfect timing! You're just in time for the test flight."

Visibly, the words "test" and "flight" next to one another make Catra nervous. Understandably. But Adora trusts Entrapta. "We can get going whenever you're ready, Entrapta."

Entrapta is ready, and her readiness brings a mountain of information. How the controls console works in the inside, an intricate set of pulleys and levers. They don't have to circle around

and land the plane—she wants them to fly somewhere far and bring it back later. Just report in with a letter. Adora doesn't know how to tell Entrapta this was the plan she was going to do anyhow. Then Entrapta mentions how she wishes Hordak were here to see all this, and Adora's heart stops. She tries to catch Catra in the corner of her eye, and finds she's keeping her reservations. Her neutrality. Thank the heavens.

"I calculate by now his disease would've taken over his immune system, or he's dangerously close." Entrapta sounds sad, but she doesn't look fazed at all. "No matter! I want to make this flight in his honor."

"Be a shame if it didn't work." It's the only passive-aggressive thing Catra says on the matter, and Entrapta doesn't really catch it. If she did, they'd all be performing one last heist today.

"What about the horses?" Finn asks. It's a good point. A very, very good point Adora hadn't thought about. She can't in good conscience leave Swift Wind behind. Not after everything they've been through together. She wonders if Entrapta is looking to adopt—

"I can look after your horses!" The new voice, the familiar voice, enters the scene from the remains of the rusted up house Entrapta inhabits. Scorpia. Catra goes wide-eyed, her breaths changing with a sense of relief. Scorpia walks over, looking directly at Catra as she adds, "I owe you a favor anyway."

"Thank you," Catra tells her. Scorpia plays it off like it's nothing. Like Catra didn't free her from the life they're all trying to run away from right now.

"No worries. You guys should get going."

A giant, hand-written manual is shoved into Adora's hands. How to repair the plane. What to do if anything malfunctions. In the back of the book: the best places to hide out in. Adora's eyes meet Scorpia's, and find the woman nodding at her. Then she

places one of her gloved hands against Adora's back, pushing her towards freedom. Adora boards last, looking on her associates one last time. It's just like with Glimmer and Bow; she doesn't wish to forget any of them or any of this.

Then she sits in the first seat of the machine, everyone tightly packed together, and she conducts Entrapta's experiment.

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"Doing okay back there?"

"Next time we're going to the library. We're spending family time at the library."

"At least we didn't go with the boat, Mama!"

Catra cringes. She's several feet away, sprawled against the solid earth, far away from the cliff's edge, a book in hand. Right now the words on those pages are probably saving her life. Finn wanted to go fishing—was Adora supposed to say no?

The three sit high above the water, where a fall flows somewhere close by and feeds into the lake below. If Adora were evil she would jump over the edge and into the water, forcing her family in after her. But Catra would one hundred percent murder her. Maybe next time, when they all get stuck among stacks and stacks of books, Adora will decide to be obnoxious there. Bonus: Catra can't yell at her in the library. Meaning Adora can push her buttons as hard as possible.

"Are you sure you don't want to cast a line?" Adora asks. "Just cast it and sit back there? Justify all the catch you're going to steal from me anyway?"

"Go to hell, Adora."

Argument can't be taken much from here, when a large fish starts roughly tugging on Finn's line. They struggle against the force, digging their feet into the earth, kicking up dust. Their parted hair

begins bouncing around, and Adora takes a moment to notice how long the shaved side of their hair has managed to grow these past months. Time for a new cut, maybe. Adora notes Catra getting up in the background to watch, as Adora makes her way over to make sure Finn doesn't fly over the cliff for real. She supports Finn as they fight against the fish below, heaving the monster all the way up.

"Not bad," Catra says. The fish has to weigh in the double digits. Maybe ten to thirteen pounds by itself. "You know what we should do? We should take it home and cook it. Before it goes bad!" Then Catra is off without another word, pushing through the tall grass behind them all.

"That's your mama's way of saying she's terrified. It doesn't happen often, but it's always hilarious."

Swift Wind and Melog wait in the distance, best friends for life after their stressful train ride over here. Adora still can't believe Scorpia won't let her pay her back. She paid for the horses, rode all the way over here, and brought the plane back to Entrapta. All with a smile on her face. The most Catra and Adora could offer was their help once her mines opened back up. Still pending. Adora doubts she'll ever reach out for the help. She was raised by Shadow Weaver, after all.

It's a short ride back into town. The gun store Adora works at isn't expecting her today, and today she plans on blasting past town without stopping by. Today is a family day. She's not interested in anything else. Catra doesn't bother with the book store, either. They have a fish to cook, she claims. Grinning, because she enjoys family time just the same. Adora makes a brief stop at the post office. Mostly to check the bounty board. Clear for now. Clear for a few weeks. Didn't even have to threaten anyone.

Once she spotted herself on that board, and only once has she had to remove the page and destroy the evidence. It never came back, but she still nervous-checks the board from time to time.

She grabs the mail in her and Catra's name and runs home as quickly as possible. Fish to cook!

In the middle of the countryside, open and free of trees, exposed to 24/7 sunlight, is the cabin. Swift Wind and Melog are left to their large stables, though they could roam the closed property and not find boredom in their adventuring. Swift Wind will spend some extra time walking around before turning in for the night. Finn might take him riding out once more for the night before bed. There isn't much to worry about out here, and Adora has learned to barely stress the late night travel. Finn will start their studies soon anyhow—might as well let them have some fun.

"Hey, Adora." She turns from the porch, eyes turning from the horses to Catra in the doorway. "There's a letter. From Bright Moon ranch."

"We're clear? I didn't see anything in the papers."

"Let's see." Catra waves the letter, before disappearing inside. Adora chases her, a familiar feeling, tailing behind her until they both reach the couch in the middle of the home. A fire waits for them both, though it isn't cold enough out to be concerned for one. Finn remains outside, chasing Swift Wind around with an apple. Adora doesn't plan on calling them in.

Adora can't take the letter. She makes Catra hold onto it, staring at her nervously. The status of their entire future, everything they've been hiding away from and dreaming of, is within that piece of paper. "Ready?"

Catra looks up at her, the same nerves infecting her system. "Nope." Regardless she opens the letter, Bright Moon's official sigil burned in wax, keeping the page folded unto itself. Adora leans closer to Catra and reads with her.

The house falls silent.

"It worked."

“They believed it.”

There is no newspaper report, not yet. Those few who double-take every time they see Catra and Adora are in for a surprise. Tomorrow and every day of the following week the papers will tell the tale, the giant conspiracy of Shadow Weaver and her greed for the treasure of Bright Moon ranch. They will learn of Hordak’s quest to capture her, and they will learn of his past deeds. He was a man with a vendetta, not a law man, and Shadow Weaver was a greedy woman, not a poor person out of a job. Adora will be hailed as the one to protect the ranch from the forces at hand, going so far as to travel all the way to the dangerous Wastes to rid the area of other greed. Catra will be remembered as the one to speak out against Shadow Weaver, the one who desperately tried to destroy the fiend from the inside, to free all those she would hold under her rank forcefully.

“It’s a little more dramatic than I would word it,” Catra says, amusement in her voice, “but I’ll take it.”

Hard to believe. It’s all hard to believe. The last time Adora served her time, the last time she was told she was clean and good to go, Hordak showed up at her door. This time is different. There are more eyes on this. She has back up now, and she has powerful friends now. Her name is finally cleared, for good this time, as is the rest of her family. It is more than likely Hordak has passed now. Shadow Weaver was killed right before her eyes.

Trouble will find them no more. The only thing to either of their names now is a home in the countryside and honest jobs.

Adora’s eyes fall on Finn in the yard, laughing with their newly blond hair, patting Swift Wind as the horse eats an apple whole. Melog is in the background, looking ready for adventure, as well.

A hand falls on Adora’s, the letter cast aside on the table. Her eyes fall on Adam’s revolvers, hung above the fireplace, retired now. Then she turns her attention to Catra, who is staring into her eyes. “We’re finally free,” Adora says. Her heart starts pounding,

because she knows exactly what's about to come out of Catra's mouth next.

"We can finally do it. Adora, do you want to get married?"

A feeling overtakes Adora at violent speed. She feels assaulted by her own emotions, and any minute she'll collapse, bursting into a puddle of nothing. Her chest starts burning, her temples tightening with the effort. The skin of her face goes hot as her vision starts to blur away. She blinks a few times to get back the clear sight of Catra in front of her. "Yes, Catra. I want to marry you."

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for reading this story, it really means a lot! This one was probably the most special one I've written in a long time, and damn did writing it teach me a lot about a lot.
>
> I am pleased to announce my next story is completely finished and will start to be posted in the next bit here. It features super powered Adora, a really shitty and unfair work system, Big Scary VillainTM, Shadow Weaver being an asshole (lol), and Catra being smarter than everyone else (lol x2). Thank you so much again for reading, it really means a lot.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!